

Psych 270 The Psychology of Morality

Numbered Transcript

PSYC 270 • Dr. Rob Henderson

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Lecture 1: Morality by Nature

At a glance — Henderson on morality by nature.

- 1.1 Well, good afternoon. My name is Dr. Rob Henderson. I'll be your instructor for this course. These lectures are based on ideas I've been researching and thinking about and developing over the last few years. I'll, of course, be drawing from the work of many historical thinkers and contemporary scholars as well. I'm truly delighted that this material will be able to reach a broader audience.
- 1.2 I see this endeavor as a good and honorable use of the Peterson family's expanding resources and influence, bringing education to more people. Of course, this is also part of Dr. Peterson's plan for world domination. I received my PhD in psychology from the University of Cambridge about three years ago, in 2022. During that period, I wrote my thesis, I wrote a book. I describe in that book, *Troubled*, my pathway through higher education, how I came to be interested in studying psychology.
- 1.3 I very briefly grew up in foster homes in Los Angeles. I fled as soon as I could, enlisting in the military at age 17. Later, studied psychology at Yale with the help of the GI Bill, and then went to the University of Cambridge to get a PhD with the support of the Gates Cambridge scholarship. One of the benefits of taking a course with a recent PhD graduate is that a lot of the studies I'll be citing are fresh and contemporary. This is the latest cutting-edge stuff, state-of-the-art.
- 1.4 How many of you are familiar with the replication crisis in psychology or the social sciences? A couple of you. That was a pretty disruptive moment in academic psychology and in other academic disciplines as well. Essentially, around the mid-2010s, it was discovered that many of the findings in psychology research did not replicate. They tried to reconduct the studies and got different results.
- 1.5 Fortunately, there have been many improvements in the field since then. A lot of things have gotten better, improved statistical methods, recruiting more participants, things like pre-registration. I'll put online in advance what I think the conclusion of this study will be, what the results will be, instead of hiding the data and manipulating it and then saying, "Oh, here's the result that I predicted all along." There are a bunch of different ways that psychology has improved over the last decade or so.
- 1.6 But I should note that we're going to be investigating different frameworks within moral psychology. There have been a lot of ongoing contentious debates and disputes within this field. I'll be presenting you these different arguments and these different frameworks. One way to think about this is that the science is not settled in moral psychology. I'll present you this work, and you'll be able to make up your own mind as you learn the material throughout the course.

- 1.7 I'll share some of my views about what I think is more robust, maybe what requires more improvements, the shortcomings of some of these frameworks, some of the strengths of these frameworks. But overall, I think that moral psychology is an important field, and there are different reasons why we should study it. This is an overview of what we'll be talking about, moral psychology, moral philosophy. We'll be talking about the origins of kindness and cooperation, cruelty and malevolence.
- 1.8 We'll talk about the differences between liberals and conservatives, how they think about morality. We'll talk about some controversial work regarding sex differences in morality. Are women more moral than men? Are men more moral than women? We'll talk about some age differences, too. Does moral character change throughout the lifespan? We'll conclude with a discussion of happiness and morality. Is there a relationship between being happy and being moral?
- 1.9 Why would you take this course? I think the most important reason is that these are inherently fascinating topics. Who wouldn't want to learn about the origins of morality, why people become violent, why cruelty exists, political differences, why do liberals differ from conservatives. We'll also go over some high-level interdisciplinary insights. I'll be drawing, of course, from the field of psychology, but also evolutionary theory. We'll talk about criminology, a bit of philosophy, some anthropology, behavioral economics, and other fields as well.
- 1.10 The third reason, and this is much more speculative, is that it might make you a better person. It's possible that having some deeper insights into moral psychology will help you to understand yourself better and help to understand others better, a clearer insight and a richer perspective of yourself and other people. I think this is what the playwright Anton Chekhov meant when he said, "Man will become better when you show him what he is like."
- 1.11 Sometimes, when I teach courses on moral psychology, some people will say, "Is morality even real? I don't believe in morality. I believe in Nietzsche. I don't believe in that moral stuff. It's nihilistic. I'm a cynic, I'm a nihilist, I'm a relativist. All this moral stuff, this is just unsettled disputes. There's no way to find a clear-cut answer." Well, people will say that, but then if you present them with specific moral transgressions, suddenly you'll see the moral outrage activate.
- 1.12 I pulled this up, this news story. Just a couple of months ago, there was an animal care services worker who was caught on film dragging a dog by the leash. So she had the leash on the collar and dragging the dog against its will. The dog was clearly not happy about this. I saw this story go viral on social media, and there were thousands of comments trying to dox the employee of this animal shelter, trying to find out what her name was, how to get her fired. Some people said she should be locked up, throw away the key.

- 1.13** It's clear why the dog might be upset by something like this. Maybe the previous owner or the future owner, why they would be upset. But why are strangers, who have no contact with this dog, who don't know the employee of this place? They were outraged, and they were calling for her to be fired, and setting up these crowdfunding services for this dog. This distant moral outrage, this occurred in San Antonio, but people all over the world were very caught up in this. I think this tells us something important about moral psychology, which we will be discussing throughout this course.
- 1.14** Is morality real? Well, I want to take my cue here from Adam Smith, the great Scottish Enlightenment philosopher, and he wrote in his masterpiece—everyone knows about *The Wealth of Nations*. I think his other book, his other less famous book, is even more interesting and valuable, *The Theory of Moral Sentiments*.
- 1.15** Adam Smith said, "How selfish soever man may be supposed, there are evidently some principles in his nature which interest him in the fortune of others and render their happiness necessary to him, though he derives nothing from it except the pleasure of seeing it. That we often derive sorrow from the sorrow of others is a matter of fact too obvious to require any instances to prove it. For this sentiment, like all the other original passions of human nature, is by no means confined to the virtuous and humane, though they perhaps feel it with the most exquisite sensibility."
- 1.16** Of course, the language is old-fashioned, but what he's saying here is that, very clearly, when we see someone else who experiences good fortune, when they're happy, we feel a bit of that happiness for ourselves. When we see someone in pain, experiencing sorrow, some of that also transmits to us as well. In this book, Adam Smith suggests that this is one of the contributing building blocks to human morality.
- 1.17** Here's Thomas Jefferson in 1787. "Man was destined for society. His morality, therefore, was to be formed to this object. The moral sense, or conscience, is as much a part of man as his leg or his arm. It is given to all human beings in a stronger or weaker degree. It may be strengthened by exercise, as may any particular limb of the body." And so, Jefferson here is suggesting that morality is inherently intertwined with human nature. There's no escaping it. It's as much a part of man as his arm or his leg. We'll be investigating later whether Thomas Jefferson was correct on this point.
- 1.18** There are different definitions of morality, but I'm going to read you a few of these suggested definitions, and I'd like to see if you can come up with a shared theme around these various definitions. Here's Aristotle. He defined morality as "what is for the benefit of the whole community or to the common advantage." Here's the theologian St. Augustine, who suggested that morality is "an ordered concord of civic obedience and rule in order to secure a cooperation of men's wills for the sake of attaining the things which belong to this mortal life."
- 1.19** Here's the Scottish philosopher David Hume, suggesting morality promotes "the public interest, the public good, a common end, the general interests of society, and the good

of mankind." More recent definition from the social psychologist Jonathan Haidt, who suggested that moral systems are "interlocking sets of values, virtues, norms, practices, identities, institutions, technologies, and evolved psychological mechanisms that work together to suppress or regulate selfishness and make cooperative social life possible." Here's the Harvard neuroscientist, Joshua Greene. Very clean, crisp definition. "The core function of morality is to promote and sustain cooperation."

- 1.20 What all of these definitions center around is this idea of suppressing selfishness to promote cooperation. We'll be exploring which of these definitions is correct, and if so, what implication this has for individuals and for societies. Again, is morality real? You hear this question: Is morality real? Well, I think one way to think about morality is that it is akin to language. So humans are born with this prepared capacity to acquire language. And of course, it's shaped and molded and sculpted by your specific environmental context, your culture, your peers, your parents, your family.
- 1.21 And so every human is born with the capacity to learn language. But whether one person speaks Mandarin, another person speaks Spanish, another person speaks English, that is due to cultural factors. Every society has language, every society has a moral system. This does not necessarily imply that morality does not exist. It doesn't negate the existence of morality, the fact that you have these variations.
- 1.22 Just as every language has grammar, rules around how language should work, so does every moral system. There's a shared structure. If you arrive in a completely unfamiliar country you've never been to before, you'll be able to tell that people are communicating with language, even if you have no idea what they're saying. And if you become more familiar with the culture, you'll start to recognize that they have some kind of moral system in place, even if it's completely alien to you and unfamiliar to you.
- 1.23 We absorb these moral norms in the same way that we acquire language. There's this innate preparation. We have this capacity to learn this. Then over time, it's shaped and sculpted and molded by culture. By way of analogy here, you could imagine someone saying, "Well, those people over there speak Thai, those people speak French, I speak English. I mean, does language really exist? We're all speaking different languages. Language isn't real."
- 1.24 Or you could imagine someone saying, "Well, maybe the very fact that there's a variation in different languages suggests that there's an underlying capacity to learn it," and that's what we should be studying. So yes, variation doesn't imply that language isn't real or that there isn't one true form of language. This is also what I consider to be a mistake, particularly in moral philosophy, of trying to uncover the objective true definition of what morality is.
- 1.25 To me, it's like trying to find the true language. "They're speaking French, they're speaking Italian, they're speaking Japanese, but what's the true language? What's the original language? Let's cut through all of this and try to find the original language."

Well, obviously, that doesn't make much sense. Language evolved for reasons of cooperation and communication, and we'll see that morality evolved for similar reasons.

- 1.26** We'll talk here about the question: Why is morality important for humans? This is a great quote from the anthropologist, Sarah Hrdy. Sarah Hrdy wrote, "If a planeload of chimpanzees were to take off, it would never reach its destination, not because they couldn't fly the plane, but because they would tear one another apart before they got there." Coltan Scrivner, a psychologist, echoed that sentiment when he said, "It is remarkable that humans don't impulsively kill each other more often. We take this for granted, but it is a peculiar phenomenon for a primate."
- 1.27** I want to suggest to you that there is something unique about human nature with regard to morality. I also want to attempt to persuade you that, however skeptical you may be around the question of morality, our perceptions of the social world are suffused through and through with moral considerations. There's no way to escape it. One way you might think about morality is, as far as how we evaluate moral transgressions, you could think of people maybe like a detective.
- 1.28** You arrive on the scene, someone did something horrible to someone else, and so you're gathering the facts. What happened here? Who did what to who? You're evaluating it line by line, trying to collect evidence, and then you arrive at a moral verdict. Yes, something bad happened here. This person did something bad. But what a lot of research into moral psychology suggests is that that's not how our moral psychology works. Our very evaluation of facts are colored by these moral considerations.
- 1.29** I want to tell you all about what's known as the Knobe effect, which is named after the experimental philosopher Joshua Knobe. I'll tell you about a scenario that Josh Knobe and his colleagues conducted. Imagine that there is a CEO of a company, and a vice president approaches the CEO and says, "Hey, I have an idea for a product, and if we build this product, we're all going to get really rich. But if we build this product and we get really rich, this product is also going to harm the environment." The CEO replies, "I don't care about the environment. I just want to get really rich." They build the product, they get really rich, and sure enough, the environment is harmed.
- 1.30** So the question is: Did the CEO intend to harm the environment? How many of you think he intended to harm the environment? A few of you? OK, about half. Knobe and his colleagues presented a variation of this study. It's very similar. There's a CEO of a company, the vice president says, "Hey, I have an idea for a product. We build it, we're going to get really rich. If we build it, it's really going to help the environment." Again, the CEO says, "Look, I don't care about the environment. I just want to get really rich." They build a product, they get really rich, and sure enough, the environment is helped.

- 1.31** How many of you think that the CEO intended to help the environment? OK, we got one. All right. OK. This roughly matches the results that Knobe and his co-authors found. So in the first scenario, when the environment was harmed, about 80% of people said that he intended to harm the environment. The CEO should be blamed for what happened here. In the second scenario, it was literally the reverse. Eighty percent of people said he did not intend to help the environment. These are identical scenarios. There's only one word that was changed, helped or harmed.
- 1.32** What these experimental philosophers suggested is that we are evaluating these scenarios through a moral lens. I'm telling you these factual bits of information. What's the CEO saying? What's this vice president saying? What are their goals? Some side effect over here happened. Something was harmed, something was helped. If something is harmed, we're very quick to attribute blame and responsibility, but not when something good happened.
- 1.33** What's really cool is that the same set of researchers did something similar with preschool-aged children. We'll be going over some research in developmental psychology, child psychology, because I think it helps to illuminate the roots of these moral intuitions. So, here's a scenario that they presented to four- and five-year-old children.
- 1.34** There's a boy named Andy. He's over here at his house. There's a girl named Janine. She's over at her house. Look what Andy has with him. He has a frog—this is accompanied by cartoon images for the children. Andy loves frogs. Janine hates frogs. Now, listen carefully. Andy knows that Janine hates frogs and that she will be really upset when she will see the frog. Andy does not care if Janine will get upset. He's going to bring the frog over anyway. The key question: Did Andy intend to make Janine upset? Overwhelmingly, these young children said, "Yeah, he had this frog. He knows that it's going to upset Janine. He brought it over anyway. He intended to make her upset."
- 1.35** Of course, there was the variation of this scenario. In this case, Janine loves frogs. Andy doesn't care that Janine loves frogs. He brings the frog over anyway, and she's delighted that he brought the frog over. Did Andy intend to make Janine happy? Most of the kids said no. No, he did not intend for this. Again, it seems that our evaluation of the social world is suffused with these moral considerations. Something bad happens, we immediately take a different position than if something good happened.
- 1.36** As a variation of this, again, our perceptions of the social world are suffused with moral considerations, this is a headline from just a couple of weeks ago in The New York Times. "It's not normal to raise children like this." In this piece, the author describes how, in the modern world, parents are often isolated from their distant kin. In the modern United States, you might have a mother or father, two parents, or maybe a single parent, not much help from grandparents, extended kin and so on, the way that you had in villages and in more traditional societies.

- 1.37** But what's interesting here is this headline. "It's not normal to raise children like this," but the very fact that that is how children are raised suggests that it is normal. But you often hear things like this. "You're behaving in a certain way, that's not normal," even if that very behavior is widespread and prevalent. And so, this is an interesting finding from research on the way that people use this phrase normal.
- 1.38** If I tell you that it's normal for people to spend eight hours a day in front of screens and devices, you might object, say, "That's not normal. It's not normal to live like that." But then, if I present to you data suggesting that the average amount of time people spend in front of screens each day is eight hours, you still might think that that's not normal, even though statistically, that is the average amount of time.
- 1.39** What these researchers find is that people use normal in a very specific way. Normal is essentially the middle ground between our moral preference, our ideal, and the statistical average. You could imagine, if I tell you that it's normal in a typical school in America for 10 children to be bullied each week. That's the normal amount. You might think, "Well, that's not normal." If I ask you, rather, "Well, what's the optimal amount of bullying that should occur in schools?", you'd probably say something like zero. Probably shouldn't be any bullying.
- 1.40** You have the statistical average of 10. You have your moral preference of zero. If I ask you, "Well, what's the normal amount of bullying?", you might say something like three. You might say something like four, somewhere in between. That's how people intuitively think about normal, is the gap between our moral ideal, our strong personal preference, how things should be, versus how things actually are.
- 1.41** It's funny because normal, this is actually a term from statistics, like what's the normal distribution, the normal range? It's a synonym for average or for typical. But in everyday language, because we want our moral preferences to be the norm, we use that word normal in a specific way. Morality also seems to be intertwined with our beliefs about the true self. I want to be clear here that this isn't about the objective true self, whatever that might mean. Rather, it's about our intuitions about the true self.
- 1.42** I'm going to describe a scenario to you. Imagine that there's a man named Mark, and Mark is a fundamentalist Christian, and he goes around the world, giving these workshops, talking about the importance of his faith, and telling people, spreading the word of his religion. But Mark has a secret, and the secret is that Mark has very intense feelings for other men. He's attracted to other men. But he really doesn't like these feelings that he's experiencing. Whenever those feelings surface within him, he recommits himself to his principles, to his faith. He goes and teaches more workshops, and he tries to devote himself even further to his religion.
- 1.43** Then, the question that researchers asked people was, "Who is the real Mark? Who's the true Mark?" Is it the Mark that is a fundamentalist Christian devoted to his faith, or

is the true Mark the one who has these intense feelings for other men? Keep this in mind. As you might imagine, there was a political difference here, where conservative participants, when they were presented with this scenario, said, "The religious Mark is the real Mark. He experiences these impulsive feelings, but he's overriding them with his higher values, with his principles, with his ideals. That's the real Mark."

- 1.44 The liberal participants said, "Oh, no, no, no. The real Mark is the Mark who has those intense romantic feelings for men, and all that religious stuff is obscuring Mark's true self." But then the researchers did something very clever, which was presented participants with a variation of this scenario. There's a separate Mark. Imagine there's a different Mark. This Mark is a social justice advocate. He goes around the world teaching workshops about inclusion and diversity and the importance of tolerance, and so on.
- 1.45 But this Mark has a secret, and his secret is that, whenever he witnesses or even thinks about same-sex relationships, he's sick to his stomach, experiences this intense disgust. But whenever he thinks about that or sees something that activates those feelings, he recommits himself to the principles of social justice, of inclusion and tolerance, and so on, and tries to recommit to those values.
- 1.46 Then, the question, of course, is: Who's the real Mark? In this case, the answers were essentially reversed. In this case, liberal participants said, "Oh, no, the Mark who's teaching the social justice workshops, that's the real Mark. Yeah, he has those base feelings, but he's trying to commit himself to something higher, something better, something better than those impulsive, dirty feelings within him, those homophobic feelings."
- 1.47 The conservative participants said the opposite. A conservative participant said, "Well, he should listen to those impulses. The real Mark is being obscured, is being smothered by this social justice stuff. He needs to forget all of that and listen to who he really is on the inside, deep down, his emotions, his intuitions, his feelings." Our moral preferences are coloring our judgments of the true self here. We think that people's true self, deep down, who they really are, the true self, is whatever happens to align with our own moral preferences. Again, this is not what's the actual true self, but rather, the intuitions or beliefs about the true self.
- 1.48 Interestingly, there was another study on this point about identity and what it means for someone to become a different person, figuratively speaking. The researchers presented participants with scenarios. Have them imagine a loved one. You could say, imagine you have a loved one, and this loved one is stricken with a horrible illness, and they lose all of their memories, and they have to relearn who you are. You have to rebuild that relationship. The question is: Is this the same person?
- 1.49 Other scenarios. You could imagine a person who suddenly has a wildly changed preference in terms of what they like to eat, or what they like to drink, or where they

like to travel. Maybe they change their outfit, their style, their clothing. And in most of these cases, people said, "No, that's still the same person. They lost their memories, but that's still my wife, that's still my husband, that's still my daughter. We can rebuild that relationship." Same thing with those preferences around food, around clothing, around fashion.

- 1.50** But when you ask people to imagine that their loved one overnight suddenly changed their moral values, that was the case in which people were the most likely to say, "That's not really the same person anymore." If someone went to bed with these political values and woke up the next day with completely the reverse values, people often feel like, "That's not the same person anymore." So morality is core to our intuitions of the true self.
- 1.51** Why do humans care about morality? Here's the neurobiologist, Peggy Mason. Peggy Mason said, "In mammalian communities, affective communication and prosocial acts support social cohesion, which in turn ancestrally increase an individual's chances of survival and reproductive success." We're going to be talking a lot about evolutionary psychology in this course, and the bolded portion of this quote is key here, that prosocial acts, social cohesion, this is critical for both survival and for reproduction in human societies.
- 1.52** Patricia Churchland, the philosopher, wrote a book just a few years ago called *Conscience: The Origins of Moral Intuitions*. She suggests that moral feelings, these originate in neural systems shaped by evolution. The original relationship among humans and human ancestors is the mother-child attachment. Over time, that bond, the mechanism that allows a mother and a child to bond to one another, that was co-opted by evolution and expanded to romantic partners, to friends, to kin, to other relationships.
- 1.53** Churchland writes, "Attachment begets caring; caring begets conscience." She uses conscience here as a shorthand for the moral emotions—guilt, shame, sense of betrayal, joy, pride, happiness, disgust— we'll talk about a lot of these emotions later in this course. But the idea here is that these moral emotions, tied up with conscience, evolved because it helped groups survive. So, moral emotions, they help to protect ourselves, protect kin, boosting genetic success. Moral norms, as we've been discussing, promotes cooperation, it reduces conflict, it allows groups to survive.
- 1.54** There have been some interesting studies modeling mathematically different societies. If you create a model of essentially cold-blooded psychopaths—and we'll be talking about psychopaths later in this course, people who have no sense of reciprocity, no conscience, no sense of shame—if you have a community of those types of individuals, it rapidly goes extinct because there's no trust. In the ancestral environment, humans can't survive without being able to trust one another. Physically, humans are remarkably pathetic: no claws, no fangs, no fur. The only way that humans survive is with the help of others. And so, over time, this impulse to be prosocial evolved.

- 1.55** We'll also talk here about how being seen as moral builds trust, attracts allies, attracts mates. One of the strongest predictors of attraction is kindness. This surprises a lot of people. We talk a lot about looks, status, money, all these things. But as a baseline, most people have to meet a minimal level of kindness. Kindness is the first threshold. We take it for granted because we expect people to be kind. Because we have that expectation, we almost forget about it. But most people say that kindness is one of the most important things for a romantic partner. But there are some nuances there, which we'll talk about later in these sessions.
- 1.56** We talked about this: humans evolved to care about right and wrong because it enhanced survival and reproduction, promoted the ability to recruit allies, acquire territory, resources, mates, offspring. It's important to note here that people talk about evolution as something like survival of the fittest, nature, red in tooth and claw. But that's an inaccurate portrait of evolution. We evolved the impulse to cooperate and to be kind with one another, just as much as we evolved the capacity for cruelty and inhumanity and malevolence.
- 1.57** The other important thing to note here is that the currency in evolutionary theory isn't survival; it's reproduction. You could imagine a species that didn't care at all about reproduction, didn't care about acquiring mates. All they cared about was longevity, living as long as possible, optimizing for survival. Every possible obstacle or dilemma or confrontation is a binary. Does this help me survive, yes or no? If they're always optimizing for survival, that species will rapidly die.
- 1.58** It's actually the species that favor reproduction that tend to survive. If you have a population that only cares about survival, and you have another population that attempts to balance between the two, survival, but also taking opportunities to attract mates and have children and offspring, that second population is more likely to survive.
- 1.59** This is why you see things like courage, risk-taking, sometimes foolhardy acts, particularly among young males in the prime reproductive stage of their life. Sometime between the onset of puberty through the early 20s, that is when you see the most risky and reckless behavior from young males. In large part, that's due to the desire to show off and to demonstrate that you are robust, that you are courageous, and so on.
- 1.60** This is a funny study. These researchers, they had two different research assistants visit a skate park. On one particular day, they sent a male research assistant to the skate park and asked the skaters, "Hey, can you do some tricks? I'm just curious what you guys are up to out here." They had a way of coding and measuring how dangerous these stunts were. Then, on a different day, they had a female research assistant go to the skate park and ask; they had the same request. "Can you do some stunts? Do some tricks? I'm just curious what you guys are up to." When there was a female research assistant at this skate park, the boys at this park were far more likely to do extremely dangerous stunts, perhaps in an attempt to show off.

- 1.61 But the same logic here holds for morality as well, that we want to show off that we're kind, that we're prosocial, that we're worthy of trust. We'll get into some of the studies on that question as well. But the key point here is that people will often do things that can be detrimental for their survival, but will promote their reproductive interests. Reproduction is what evolution cares about, not survival. This is especially true at the peak range of fertility during the life cycle, both for men and for women.
- 1.62 I've told you guys that we will be discussing at length evolutionary psychology here. It's useful to have a definition of evolutionary psychology. Here I'm borrowing a definition from the psychology professor, Tania Reynolds. Tania Reynolds says, "Evolutionary psychology examines how the mind has been shaped to solve recurring problems faced by human ancestors. It contends that natural selection has produced mental adaptations that enhanced our ancestors' ability to survive and reproduce."
- 1.63 Now, it's important to note here that, when evolutionary researchers talk about what's adaptive, what promotes survival, they're not talking about what's adaptive today in the modern world. They're talking about what was adaptive in the ancestral environment 10,000-plus years ago, before the agricultural revolution, when humans lived in nomadic hunter-gatherer bands. That is how human beings lived for approximately 97% of our history: we lived in these small-scale societies, pre-industrialized societies.
- 1.64 Small-scale and pre-industrial are the modern terms for what anthropologists used to call primitive societies. That is how most humans lived throughout history. When evolutionary psychologists say, "Well, this is for adaptive reasons, this promotes survival," they're talking about a very different context. But this evolutionary mismatch can help us to understand, I think, a lot of the social problems we're seeing today.
- 1.65 There are two principal pathways through which moral psychology evolved, our own moral psychology, our intuitions about right and wrong. We're going to cover these two here: kinship selection and reciprocal altruism. These are the two primary pathways. First, we'll talk about kinship selection. In this case, kinship selection, we talked about the mother-infant attachment template.
- 1.66 Compassion, empathy, concern, care, regard for others, that originated to protect offspring, pass on shared genes. You want to make sure that your children survive long enough to reproduce themselves. You have this compassion toward close kin. This boosts your own reproductive success. This is why we have these deep feelings about our loved ones, and particularly children.
- 1.67 There was a biologist, William Hamilton, who came up with this framework called Hamilton's rule. Hamilton's rule is essentially the idea that the more closely related two individuals are, the more they will be willing to sacrifice for one another. Hamilton, his idea was later popularized by the zoologist Richard Dawkins in a book called *The Selfish Gene*. Dawkins drew heavily from William Hamilton, who pointed out that a lot of

people, when they think about evolution, they'll say things like, "For the good of the species. People act this way for the good of the species," which is not correct. That's not how evolution works.

- 1.68** Sometimes people will say, "Well, evolution, it's for the good of the individual." You're trying to pass on your own individual genes, and that's what people are optimizing for. But that's actually not the case. What evolution favors is traits that help you to ensure that copies of your genes survive. This is why people care about their children so much. Children, on average, have half of your genes. You want them to survive. You pass on those genes. We'll talk about this later.
- 1.69** This is not necessarily conscious and calculated. Parents aren't thinking like, "Oh, my son has 50%, so this is why—" That's not how it works. Those impulses and desires are baked in unconsciously. We don't even think about them. In fact, as we'll see, conscious thought is calorically costly. Most of the things that benefit us operate unconsciously, from very simple things like your heartbeat and your breathing patterns, but even for things like caring for your loved ones, feeling compassion for your friends and for your family. Those things are involuntary.
- 1.70** Hamilton basically found that, if there are traits that are associated with helping your relatives survive and reproduce, pass on your genes, then altruism can evolve in this sense, which is why you'll see parents sacrificing for their children, siblings sacrificing for one another, and so on. I mentioned this, parents are more likely to help close relatives—people are more likely to help close relatives, siblings, their children, relative to distant kin or non-kin, in life-threatening scenarios.
- 1.71** Even in low-cost situations, if you ask people, "Would you loan your cousin this huge amount of money?", people are tepid. If you say, "What about a stranger?", they say definitely not. Cousin, maybe. Sibling, probably. Child, most of the time, yes. The higher the sacrifice, the more this kinship relationship matters. But it's not as straightforward as that. We evolved in these dynamic contexts where people had to make life-and-death decisions. In the ancestral environment, 30 to 60% of children did not survive till the age of 15.
- 1.72** Infections were pervasive. There was intertribal conflict, warfare, catastrophes around every corner. There were no vaccines, there was no advanced medical health care, and so on. And so there was a lot more death and disease before the rise of agriculture in modern societies. And so, as a result of a scarce environment, limited resources, this often forced hard choices, which in turn created flexible maternal responses for children and for offspring. You have these evolutionary trade-offs. This high mortality rate, combined with limited resources, perhaps scarce social support, did sometimes lead mothers in early human environments to withdraw care from infants.
- 1.73** What's interesting is that there have been some anthropologists who have suggested that—sometimes when you read about these societies, you'll read about spirit children,

changelings, goblins, these folklore and mythology. Some anthropologists have suggested that this was a way of coping with something that was very psychologically upsetting, which was either, in some cases, killing an infant or, at the least, leaving it to die. So these myths evolved that, well, this is a spirit child, or this is actually a changeling. This was a way for them to cope with these very difficult decisions.

- 1.74** I'll read you a passage here. This is from Daniela Sieff, the biological anthropologist. She writes about how there's a practice in Mali. This anthropologist, Catherine Dettwyler, spoke with one of their village chiefs, and he said, regarding sick infants, "Well, if they don't get better after a couple of years, then you know that they are evil spirits, and you give up. You take them out into the bush and you just leave them. They turn into snakes and slither away. You go back the next day, and they aren't there. Then you know for sure that they weren't really children at all, but evil spirits. When you see a snake, you wonder if this used to be your child."
- 1.75** And Sieff goes on to write that "beginning in the Middle Ages, continuing for several centuries, sickly, disabled, or otherwise challenging children risked being seen as the offspring of fairies, elves, or goblins who had infiltrated human families to steal resources from human children. Infants deemed to be changelings were left in a forest so that they could return to their magical realm. The reality was that the abandoned child was likely to succumb to hypothermia or to be eaten by a wild animal." But you have this very ugly and grim reality, and so they created folklore and mythology in order to cope with this.
- 1.76** "Out of this conundrum," so the conundrum here being scarce resources, maybe limited social support, and so on, "out of this conundrum came a set of folk beliefs about changelings. Sickly babies were believed to be the babies of fairies, elves, or goblins, who had been exchanged for human ones. Parents could then leave the changeling in the forest overnight. If the baby died, it was assumed that the fairies had refused to take it back.
- 1.77** But since it was not human, the parents had committed no crime. If the baby disappeared overnight, it was believed that the fairies had taken it back, though more likely it had been eaten by a wild animal. If, however, the baby survived, it was believed that the original healthy human child had been returned by the fairies, although what this actually proved was that the baby was pretty healthy and tough after all, and thus worth rearing."
- 1.78** This was essentially a gauntlet. It was a test. You have a sick baby, you think, "Well, maybe this is a changeling. This isn't really my baby." They would leave the child in the forest, and then return in the morning. If they saw that the baby was healthy, then they would take it back. But they created this whole mythology around it in order to cope with what they were doing. But obviously, it was the same child. It was just that it had recovered overnight and gotten better. OK, so myths and folklore as coping responses.

- 1.79** In some small-scale societies, you see that twins are seen as bad omens, and often either one or both of the twins are killed. This is because, especially in early human environments, if there's a pregnancy and you're expecting one child, but then there's two, that's twice as many resources that are being consumed. Again, this is seen as a bad omen, a way to justify either abandoning one or both. Care was often withheld from infants when food, time, or energy were scarce. And so, you have these stories in order to deal with what were often very tragic, very ugly decisions.
- 1.80** There are two things, two points to keep in mind here, is that we evolved to care for our offspring, but when we are forced by circumstance to withdraw care, it can often be so troubling that you have to develop very elaborate stories to justify and to explain and to rationalize and to cope with it. But there's a very interesting flip side to this. I've been speaking about these difficult choices that mothers faced in the ancestral environment.
- 1.81** There's a Jungian analyst, Marion Woodman, who created this idea of the death mother. This is a Jungian perspective. This takes the perspective not of the mother, but of the child. Marion Woodman describes this death mother archetype as representing the opposite of the nurturing mother. The death mother is cold, rejecting, unfeeling, suffocating, instead of caring. She describes how this will often appear in dreams, in culture, a devouring mother figure, a witch figure that drains life rather than giving it.
- 1.82** But there's an evolutionary interpretation here as well, which is that this archetype may instill anxiety in young children in order to motivate them to receive care. You often find that children are terrified of being abandoned, of being rejected, of being uncared for, and so they act in such a way as to help to promote and crystallize that bond. I think something interesting here is that this actually suggests a very interesting evolutionary explanation for what Freud called the Oedipus complex.
- 1.83** Of course, the straightforward cartoon version of the Oedipus complex, the boy falls in love with the mom, wants to kill the dad, that kind of thing, because the dad's in the way. But from an evolutionary perspective, because children require a lot of support to raise into adulthood and they care deeply about ensuring that their parents provide care for them, they often—this is implicit and unconscious, of course—but they often worry that if a sibling were to arrive, this would reduce the amount of care and resources that the child, him or herself, would receive.
- 1.84** One way to prevent the arrival of a sibling is to interfere with the relationship between the parents a little bit. Be disruptive, cry loudly, monopolize the attention of one of the parents, typically the opposite-sex parent. It's this quasi-romantic, innocent feelings about—you often see this with little kids. A little boy might say, "I want to marry mommy." A little girl will say, "I want to marry daddy." Those sentiments were the early building blocks of the kind of ideas that Freud developed.

- 1.85** I don't really put much stock in those ideas, but I do think that there may be an evolutionary idea here, where children develop those feelings, not because they literally want to kill their father and marry their mother or vice versa, but more so because they want to interrupt the relationship temporarily, especially during those early childhood years when they require the most care and attention. You see this with —when there are siblings, if you have two or three kids, one of the kids gets more juice than the other, the one that gets less explodes. "Why does he get more than me? Why does she get more than me?" On an unconscious level, the child has this fear that receiving less juice means that the parent is less invested in their well-being, and so they protest against this.
- 1.86** On this point here, about how critical support is for infants, for young children, you often see babies will cry even when nothing is wrong. There's an evolutionary psychologist, Randolph Nesse, who talks about the smoke detector principle. The smoke detector principle, as you can probably guess, is that smoke detectors are calibrated to be annoyingly overreactive. They don't actually respond to live flames. They respond to smoke.
- 1.87** But it's better for your smoke detector to be calibrated such that it will go off in response to some burnt toast, rather than to be underreactive when there's a live fire going on. They're calibrated to go off even if there is the hint of a possibility of danger. The idea here for humans is that something similar is at work, for example, with crying and infants. Infants tend to be calibrated to be annoyingly overreactive. They tend to be fussy even when nothing is wrong. You feed them, you change them, you do everything you can for them, and still they're a little bit fussy.
- 1.88** The idea here is that they want to make extra sure that you're paying attention to them, just in case something might go wrong. They want to make sure that you are there for them. There's also this suggestion that some biologists have put forth, which is that crying itself may signal strength and robustness. In the ancestral environment, if there was an inert, lifeless baby who was relatively unresponsive, there was this fear that maybe the baby is sick or is not strong enough to survive.
- 1.89** But if you have a baby that is crying and very colicky, very fussy, very energetic and spirited and mobile, then the idea here would be, oh, this is a strong baby. It's worth investing resources into ensuring that this baby survives to adulthood. Yes, with Hamilton's rule, this can extend to kin beyond just offspring. You see it with extended family members, siblings, cousins, that people care deeply.
- 1.90** If you were to meet someone, and they presented you with irrefutable evidence that they're your long-lost sibling, you would be much more interested in building a relationship with this person or even sacrificing for them, knowing nothing else about them, other than the fact that you share blood and ancestry and kinship.

- 1.91** We'll briefly go over the grandmother hypothesis, which was advanced by Kristen Hawkes. The grandmother hypothesis related to kinship selection. Kristen Hawkes and her colleagues have suggested that, first, if you look at nonhuman primates, you'll see that, for the females in particular, they don't tend to live much longer beyond their fertility window. So, for example, chimpanzees, the latest they can give birth is around 40 years old, and their lifespan is also around 40 years old, 45 in some cases, but they don't live much longer beyond the end of their fertility window.
- 1.92** For humans, it's very different, obviously. Women usually live—that's kind of the halfway point of their life, and then they can continue living another 40 or 50-plus years. This has puzzled anthropologists. Through a lot of very clever means, they have suggested that grandmothers evolved in order to help provision care for their daughters' children. They found a lot of evidence that when grandmothers are involved in a child's life, they're much more likely to survive to adulthood, and they're more likely to form relationships of their own and so on.
- 1.93** At a certain point, you have a child, and then the child grows up, has children of their own, and then you can devote your attention not to attracting mates or to having children yourself, but more so to directing that attention to those children. There's also something to be said here for the complexity of human culture, especially in pre-industrialized societies. Older women often have a vast repertoire of knowledge for medicine-making, child-rearing, all kinds of things that can help prolong a child's life and nurse them back to health and so on.
- 1.94** That's kinship selection. We're going to briefly turn to reciprocal altruism. This idea of reciprocity is often seen as the cornerstone of morality. You have this quote here, the golden rule, this famous golden rule from Christ. "As you would that men should do to you, do ye also to them likewise." Then, Confucius, when he was asked for a single word that summed up morality, he said, "Is not reciprocity such a word? What you do not want done to yourself, do not do to others." This idea of reciprocity seems to be a foundation of morality.
- 1.95** Biologists and evolutionary theorists describe this as reciprocal altruism. This idea is that we have the expectation that, when you help someone, they'll help you in turn. A lot of modern people, I think, have a difficulty with this because many of us live in big cities. Maybe we don't know our neighbors. We're atomized and distant and isolated in many ways. But again, keep in mind that, in the environment in which humans evolved, they were in small bands. They would almost never meet an unfamiliar person or a stranger, and so it was critical for them to invest in relationships with one another.
- 1.96** Someone does something to help you, even if they're unrelated to you, you're expected to help them and vice versa. There's a lot of fascinating work in laboratory experiments, where you give people the opportunity to cooperate with one another, to earn money in these lab games. If someone cheats or fails to cooperate, people are

very good at remembering who that person was. Then, multiple iterations down, they will remember that person and refuse to play the game with them again.

- 1.97** If you're cooperative and helpful, if that person is given the opportunity to play with you, they're very quick to resume that relationship. Through these mechanisms, we learn to keep these mental ledgers of one another. We're very good at remembering who betrayed us. We're also pretty good at remembering who was helpful to us in the past.
- 1.98** I remember there was this interview with Richard Dawkins, who famously wrote *The Selfish Gene*, but he said that book could have easily also been called *The Selfless Gene*, because one of the points of that book is that, because of kinship selection and reciprocal altruism, this is evidence that people can also go to extraordinary lengths to help one another, as in the case of parents sacrificing for their children, or in these extreme cases of, for example, service members; when they're on deployment, you hear these stories, Medal of Honor recipients jumping on explosive devices to protect their peers, their comrades, their brothers-in-arms.
- 1.99** You can think of humans as being selfish in that sense because the gene wants to survive. But that also implies that humans can be selfless as well, because humans would not survive and reproduce to this point without those instincts, those impulses, the willingness to help others and build a moral reputation. I mentioned this—we're quick to recall faces of cheaters as well as cooperators. We seem to have these specialized mechanisms to recall people who do not pull their own weight. We also track favors as well.
- 1.100** There have been these very clever studies showing that people, without explicitly verbalizing it, "Oh, this person helped me today. Oh, that person betrayed me," no, it was very quick to remember these things. We'll talk about the self-domestication hypothesis as well, because this is critical for understanding how humans evolved a moral sense and how we came to be as peaceful and as docile as we are. Richard Wrangham, he's an evolutionary biologist. I think he's at Harvard. He wrote this fascinating book just a few years ago called *The Goodness Paradox*. He writes at length about what he calls the self-domestication hypothesis.
- 1.101** The self-domestication hypothesis is, essentially—he started with this question. If you look at the levels of intergroup, rather intragroup, so you have a troop of chimpanzees, and they all live with one another, and they spend time in the same community. Then you measure the level of interpersonal conflict between these chimpanzees, you find that they are roughly between 150 to 550 times more violent than human beings are in hunter-gatherer societies. In other words, chimps are way more violent than human beings are.
- 1.102** You can watch documentaries about this, just the amount of aggression and hostility, confrontation, and bloodshed that takes place, of course, between chimpanzee troops,

so there's the intergroup conflict of, if they run into another chimpanzee troop, that's often extremely bloody and vicious. But even within those communities, there's high levels of violence. You may know about bonobos. Some people talk about bonobos as the peaceful ape. It's true that bonobos are more peaceful than chimpanzees. They're about half as violent as chimpanzees are. Half as violent, which means that they're also far more violent than human beings.

- 1.103** This was a question that Wrangham and others have explored. Why are humans relatively more docile and more peaceful and cooperative than our nearest evolutionary relatives? They suggest the self-domestication hypothesis, which is essentially the idea that, throughout evolutionary history, human beings have taken out bullies, psychopathic males—it was usually males—people who took food from other people, attempted to steal other people's wives, behaved in a very domineering and aggressive way. If someone behaved in this way, a whisper network would form in the community, usually the other males, and they would say, "This guy's a problem; let's take him out."
- 1.104** There was one report from an anthropologist, Jane Murphy. She did an ethnographic report of the Inuit, and she asked one of them, "Well, what if you had someone here who was extremely selfish, monopolized the food, refused to contribute, behaved very aggressively and selfishly?" They said, "Oh, we would just push him off the ice when no one was looking." Wrangham said that that happened a lot throughout evolutionary history. If someone was a problem, they found a way to either ostracize this person or to kill them. Over time, this made us more docile and peaceful. We weeded out the bullies, the intimidators, the psychopathic types.
- 1.105** Christopher Boehm, in his book *Hierarchy in the Forest*, which is probably the most important anthropological text, writes about this topic as well. He says, "How did this happen? How were humans able to weed out these bullies?" He suggests first the invention of hunting weapons, so humans learned how to use hunting weapons to hunt large-bodied mammals. Then at a certain point, they realized, well, humans are large-bodied mammals, too. Then they learned that with spears, you can take someone out at a distance.
- 1.106** If you see chimpanzee documentaries, sometimes the lower-ranking males will unite to take out the alpha male chimp. But in the process of those very vicious and aggressive disputes, the tyrant is killed, but the lower-ranking males are often severely injured as well in the process. But once the conspirators all have spears, weapons, rocks, ways to throw, ways to kill at a distance, the likelihood of suffering injury yourself dramatically declines. So this is intertwined with the second point here, the advent of large game hunting.
- 1.107** Then also important is the development of a large brain and the capacity to communicate via language, so that a group of low-ranking males can form—well, that's not the right language to use, is it? Not low-ranking males, but rather, the non-bully

males in a human community can whisper to one another and say, "Do you think so-and-so is a problem?"

- 1.108** I think a good modern illustration of this is the reality TV show, Survivor. If you watch Survivor, obviously, they're not killing people, but they are ostracizing people in a way, and often taking them by surprise. The way this happens is, they're in this makeshift outdoor environment, and they're whispering to one another, like, "Hey, what do you think of this person?" They're building alliances, coalitions, and they're trying to build a consensus for who should be taken out. Something similar to that occurred in our evolutionary history.
- 1.109** But there's another explanation that is not necessarily a competing explanation. It can rest alongside the self-domestication hypothesis, the hypothesis of taking out bullies, the capital punishment idea. This idea was put forth by Lesley Newson and Peter Richerson, and they report that, in modern hunter-gatherer societies, not only are bullies, fully grown men, often taken out, but so are very hostile and aggressive children.
- 1.110** So if you have a child that's very aggressive, very confrontational, selfish, sneaky, conniving, those kinds of things, a lot of these communities will intentionally just leave the child or abandon them somewhere or even sometimes take them out. Over time, this practice reduced those kind of aggressive tendencies within a community. So, these two explanations can sit alongside one another.
- 1.111** You're taking out the adults who are aggressive, but also the children as well. Then multiple generations later, you'll find that humans are generally peaceful and cooperative. But of course, this doesn't necessarily mean that violence and hostility and confrontation, psychopaths and those kinds of things, those still exist, and we'll discuss that later. But generally speaking, humans are a lot more peaceful than other primates.
- 1.112** We may discuss this later, but the basic idea here is that we seem to implicitly calculate how much value and worth other people have to us, and that this in turn motivates us to care for one another. We have these norms and rules about reciprocity in trading. If we value someone very highly, we'll invest more in them. If others value us highly, they'll behave in turn. We'll get into this more later.
- 1.113** A simplistic scenario here. If you ask people, if I ask you straight up, "I can give \$8 to you or \$10 to your friend," almost everyone will say, "Give me the \$8." But if I say, "Well, I could give you \$1 or \$10 to your friend," most people say, "Give my friend \$10." The reason here is because the amount of value offered in each case. \$8 is not that much less than \$10, so I'll take the \$8. But \$1 isn't much, so I'd rather help my friend out. He'll get a lot more out of this. These numbers would obviously change depending on the relationship.
- 1.114** We have the evolutionary context here, which I've been alluding to, which is, we evolved in contexts where we knew everyone. Humans knew everyone in their

community. We did not evolve in contexts with one-shot interactions, where you go into the Starbucks and you make your order, and then you never see that person again. But because we evolved in that context where essentially you'd never run into a stranger, we carry those emotions around with us.

1.115 This is why you can experience intense humiliation and shame and embarrassment, even in front of people you know you'll never see again. Because on some level, you don't believe you'll never see them again, because that's not the context in which we evolved. In some ways, this can be helpful. It keeps us honest, even when dealing with strangers, but also obviously detrimental, social anxiety, even for inconsequential interactions. There are people who have difficulty ordering a pizza on the phone, that thing. But all of those things are rooted in this evolutionary framework.

1.116 We'll talk about grooming and small talk among nonhuman primates later. Our next session, we're going to talk about how people think about right and wrong and start to get into different moral frameworks. The purpose of this lecture was essentially an attempt to persuade you that morality obviously very much matters, even if you're a skeptic. We'll leave it there for now. Thank you.

Lecture 2: Moral Foundations

At a glance — Moral foundations.

- 2.1 At the start of this second lecture, I want to make something clear here, which is that I've cited a couple of different moral philosophers, Adam Smith, David Hume. But moral psychology differs from moral philosophy. These are very distinct branches of knowledge and areas of study. Moral philosophy has long been concerned with how people should act. What moral principles should we live by, how should you live a good life? Everyone from Confucius to Aristotle to even modern-day philosophers like Peter Singer, this is something they're preoccupied with, questions around should and ought.
- 2.2 Moral psychology is different in that, instead of looking at how people should behave, it looks at how people actually behave. Observational, empirical, it's uninterested in telling people how to act. It's more so detached observer, looking at how people behave in the real world, and trying to come up with consistent patterns and ideas and frameworks around this. Moral psychology is not trying to find out what is the true objective, impartial moral way to live. It investigates people's beliefs and intuitions and ideas and behaviors around morality.
- 2.3 Another way to think about this is that philosophy is prescriptive. Here's how you should behave. And moral psychology is descriptive. Here's how I've observed people actually behaving in the real world. It aims to tell us how people are, not necessarily how they should be. And so, I just say all of this to make clear that the point of this course is not necessarily to commit you to any one viewpoint. I'm not going to tell you what's right and wrong.
- 2.4 I'll share with you some information, some data, some interesting research findings, but none of this suggests that, and therefore, you should do this, or therefore, you should behave that way, or you should adopt any view in particular. And so, that's what we're interested in as moral psychologists, is how people form their moral viewpoints. Are there patterns in terms of moral behavior? I think this is a question of great intellectual and also a practical importance.
- 2.5 And so, quoting Adam Smith again, Adam Smith really was a pioneer in the realm of moral philosophy, but also, to some extent, in moral psychology as well. He actually neatly separated these two questions of philosophy versus psychology. So he says, "In treating the principles of morals, there are two questions to be considered. First, wherein does virtue consist? Or what is the tone of temper and tenor of conduct, which constitutes the excellent and praiseworthy character, the character which is the natural object of esteem, honor, and approbation?"
- 2.6 And again, the language here is kind of old-fashioned, but what he's actually saying is, what is morality? How should we behave? What behavior should we consider

admirable? Which behavior should we confer praise, and what behavior should we applaud? That's a question of moral philosophy, the question of should or ought.

- 2.7** But then he goes on here and says, "And secondly, by what power or faculty in the mind is it that this character, whatever it be, is recommended to us? Or in other words, how and by what means does it come to pass, that the mind prefers one tenor of conduct to another; denominates the one right and the other wrong; considers the one as the object of approbation, honor, and reward, and the other of blame, censure, and punishment?"
- 2.8** So here he's asking, so what is it about the mind that leads us to have these beliefs about right and wrong? He's not asking in some objective sense, what is morality? He's asking, what is it in the mind that leads us to form these beliefs and these moral judgments? Those are the two approaches to studying morality.
- 2.9** Of course, moral psychology draws from moral philosophy. Moral philosophy came first. I mean, it's been around for thousands of years, dating back as far back as Aristotle and even before that, and then in the Eastern tradition with Confucius and Sunzi and so on. And so, modern empirical psychology draws from those thinkers, but also attempts to use the modern tools of social science to see, in some cases, to test. Philosophers will often say, "Well, this is what human nature is." And psychologists will come along and say, "Well, is there a way to test that? Is there a way to formulate that into a falsifiable hypothesis?"
- 2.10** One way that psychologists have looked at this question is to first identify these two competing strains of moral philosophy, moral philosophical thought: consequentialism and deontology. Moral philosophers have argued for one or the other of these for centuries. Which one of these best explains how humans actually behave, and then which one of these should human beings actually aspire to?
- 2.11** These philosophers have aimed to be both descriptive and prescriptive. Sometimes when you read moral philosophical texts, it's hard to track how they're separating those two, because it's very easy to conflate these things, prescriptive and descriptive. So, those are the two competing frameworks we'll be discussing: consequentialism and deontology.
- 2.12** What is consequentialism? It's a long word, but essentially, it's most associated with the English philosopher, Jeremy Bentham, and, to a lesser extent, with John Stuart Mill. But what these philosophers suggest is that morality is really about outcomes. It's a situational approach to ethics. It's about maximizing pleasure, minimizing pain. There's not necessarily a fixed moral framework or set of principles you should abide by.
- 2.13** Rather, whenever you come upon an event, or you're trying to decide what to do, you add up the happiness, add up how much pleasure might happen. You make this decision, this much happiness arises; you make that decision, this much happiness

arises. Or you make this decision, and this will lead to this much suffering, but that decision will lead to this much.

- 2.14** Consequentialism is associated with a similar idea, utilitarianism. Utility here, as moral philosophers use it, is basically a word for happiness or pleasure or joy. You weigh up how much happiness, how many individuals are affected, how strongly you do this, this arithmetic, the pluses and minuses. That's both how people do behave, and then that's how they should behave.
- 2.15** As an aside here, Jeremy Bentham, for a while, there was a wax replica of his head at the University College London. They had this wax replica on campus. I think this was in the '70s, some students on campus, they made it a challenge to steal the wax head, and then they would play soccer with it. Obviously, they were penalized for this. But some commenters have suggested that, actually, Jeremy Bentham would say, "Well, if the overall amount of happiness was increased, nothing bad happened here. Maybe that was the right thing to do."
- 2.16** Then, there's deontology. This is most often associated with the German philosopher Immanuel Kant. Kant said that there are actions that are wrong, regardless of the consequences. Rather than being a form of situational ethics, it's, these are hard and fast moral rules, and you should live by them regardless of what the outcome might be. Kant tried to ground morality in pure reason, rather than emotion and desire and gut feelings and intuition. He had this idea of the categorical imperative.
- 2.17** He said, "You should act in such a way that you would want everyone else to act." If you make this choice, and it carries moral weight, you should ask yourself, "Well, what if everyone did this?" One example he gave was lying. If you want to know whether lying is wrong, ask yourself, "What if everyone lied?" Well, that would make the world a worse place. This isn't how people would want to live. Societies wouldn't operate functionally in this sense. So act in this way. Obey the categorical imperative. There are hard-and-fast rules that you should abide by. It's the opposite of consequentialism.
- 2.18** And so these have been claims that have been made dating as far back as the 18th and 19th centuries. Moral psychologists have wondered: How do people actually think about these questions? Is there a way to test? Are people natural consequentialists? Are they natural Kantians or natural deontologists? Do we actually weigh up the goods and the bads, then make a decision from there? Or do we actually have this belief in firm, fixed moral principles?
- 2.19** This is a snapshot of the definitions of the two. Consequentialism: You don't know what's right or wrong until you evaluate the situation. Deontology: You already have your principles, you're already equipped with them, and then you use those to determine whether something is right or wrong.
- 2.20** How many of you are familiar with the trolley problem? OK, good. A lot of you. This is a classic scenario used in moral philosophy and in moral psychology. The trolley problem

is very simple, and it goes like this. Imagine that there is a train on a set of tracks, and it's currently hurtling toward five people who are tied onto the tracks, and they can't escape. You are standing by a switch. If you flip the switch, the train will divert onto another set of tracks where there's only one person tied down.

- 2.21** The question in these studies is: Would you flip the switch, or would you do nothing? If you do nothing, five people die; you flip the switch, one person dies. How many of you would flip the switch? In this case, you would be consequentialists. You're adding up the number of lives saved here, and that is determining whether you'll intervene.
- 2.22** But there's a different variation of this scenario. In this case, now there's a train; it's headed toward five people. They're tied, they can't escape. You happen to be standing on a bridge above this set of tracks, and there's a very large man in front of you. If you push this man, it'll stop the train and save those five people. I know it's contrived, but just go with it. The question is, do you do nothing? The train runs over five people, or do you push the very large man? How many of you would push the large man? It's OK. All right. You two need to leave.
- 2.23** As you might imagine, when researchers conduct these studies and read these scenarios to people, in the first case, people overwhelmingly say they would flip the switch. In this case, it drops to about 30%. Less than half of people say they would push the large man. The majority say, "No, that's wrong." And so, I'm going to share with you a final scenario along these lines. Now, imagine that there's a surgeon in a hospital, and the surgeon has five patients in the hospital who she's responsible for—again, this is going to be contrived, but just go with it.
- 2.24** Each of these five patients has a different organ that is failing, and they will soon die. One day, the surgeon meets with a healthy patient, who just happens to be a match for all five of those other patients. The surgeon has a choice to essentially put this healthy patient under and remove their organs and save those other five lives. How many of you would recommend the surgeon taking this patient under and saving those other five patients? Anyone? All right. OK, consistent. All right. But you really do need to leave. No.
- 2.25** When presented with this, almost no one, very few people, say that they would condone this. And so, this gets at something here. Are people consequentialists? Are they deontologists? Well, it kind of depends. It depends on how uncomfortable we feel, how distant we are from the actions. Flipping a switch, you feel far removed, distant, detached. All you did was flip a switch. Pushing someone off a bridge is very up close. It activates all of these uncomfortable feelings. Then obviously, with the surgeon, literally cutting someone open to take their organs.
- 2.26** And so, because each of these scenarios elicits such different responses, there have been challenges posed to this idea of whether people are natural consequentialists or natural deontologists. This approach to moral psychology, it basically treats people as if

they're philosophers, as if we have consistent, fixed moral principles. I'm always going to be a consequentialist, no matter what, or I'm always going to be a deontologist, no matter what, but that's not how humans actually are.

- 2.27** It's a bit messier than that. Sometimes we lean one way, sometimes we lean the other way. This way of testing, what is the true way that people actually think about right and wrong, has been very influential, but there's been a bit of a backlash. The way that everyday humans think about morality is not about these abstract rules that moral philosophers tend to be concerned with. It's about gut feelings, it's about intuitions, it's about emotion, it's about the context.
- 2.28** There's a very nice quote here from the New York Times columnist, David Brooks, on the point about gut feelings. He says, "Think of what happens when you put a new food into your mouth. You don't have to decide if it's disgusting. You just know. You don't have to decide if a landscape is beautiful. You just know. Moral judgments are like that. They are rapid, intuitive decisions and involve the emotion-processing parts of the brain. Most of us make snap moral judgments about what feels fair or not, or what feels good or not. We often can't explain to ourselves why something feels wrong."
- 2.29** You often see this when you present various scenarios to people. You present the original trolley problem, and they'll give you the math. "Well, I flipped the switch because I wanted to save five lives [rather] than one." Then you present them with the footbridge problem, and then they start to become uncomfortable, but they feel like they have to be held to a consistent behavior. Then you present them with the surgeon scenario, and suddenly they back off and say, "Well, maybe that's not the way I actually make my moral decisions after all. It's just weighing up the goods and the bads."
- 2.30** The moral judgments seem to be this way, and it's often unconscious. We have these feelings, and then we find ways to explain them in the same way that Brooks here is suggesting the way that we evaluate a landscape. You immediately know it's beautiful, and then if I ask you why, then you start to struggle to verbalize and to articulate why it's beautiful. If I ask you why something is wrong, sometimes you'll have the same kind of response.
- 2.31** This is Jonathan Haidt's view. He wrote this groundbreaking book, *The Righteous Mind*, summarizing his work on moral foundations theory, which we'll get into later. What Haidt suggests, he calls it the social intuitionist view, but he basically says that it's not that reasoning leads to moral judgment. Rather, reasoning is a post hoc construction that we come up with after the judgment has already been reached. We feel in our gut that something is wrong. Then if I ask you why, then you struggle to come up with an articulable and reasonable and cogent explanation. But Haidt says, it's not as if you're coming at this as a scientist or a philosopher; you feel it immediately in your gut, and then you start to activate your cognition to explain why this is the case.

- 2.32** And so psychologists like Haidt, writers like David Brooks, they're building on this long view, see morality as rooted in emotion and in intuition. And this was something that David Hume argued in the 18th century. He suggested that "reason is, and ought only to be, the slave of the passions." So he's saying this is how things are, but that's also how things should be. He's conflating these things. But Hume and Haidt and others have suggested that intuitions and emotion come first, and then reasoning comes second.
- 2.33** Schopenhauer, in the 19th century, wrote something similar. "The intellect remains so much excluded from the real resolutions and secret decisions of its own will that sometimes it can only get to know them, like those of a stranger, by spying out and taking it unawares." The Germans are a little different, the way that they phrase things, a bit more exciting. This is the idea here. Emotions first, reasoning second.
- 2.34** One important emotion that has been studied, perhaps more than any other in moral psychology, is disgust. People vary in their sensitivity to disgust. There are very basic disgust sensitivity scales that psychologists will use, asking people how grossed out or uncomfortable or repulsed they would be if they had to use a stranger's toothbrush, or if they saw somebody urinating in a public pool, or if they sit down on a public bus and they find that the seat has been warm because someone else had been sitting there earlier.
- 2.35** There's a huge range in variation of disgust sensitivity. Some people are unbothered by using a stranger's toothbrush. Others would get disgusted even at the thought of it. What these studies find is that people who are extremely sensitive to disgust also tend to express sharper disapproval for various moral transgressions. The more sensitive to disgust, the more prone to feeling disgust you are, the more likely you are to condemn all kinds of moral transgressions.
- 2.36** Disgust forms what is part of the behavioral immune system. You have your physical, physiological immune system, and that protects you when you're already sick. You're sick, you have your immune system, the white blood cells, trying to combat these illnesses and infections. The behavioral immune system precedes that. The behavioral immune system attempts to ensure that you don't get sick in the first place. That's why you experience disgust.
- 2.37** Disgust evolved to protect you from pathogens, from illnesses, from infections. So, if you see a rotting piece of meat, you want to keep your distance from it. You're disgusted by it. There's a pathogen disgust element here. There's also sexual disgust. It motivates us to keep our distance from potential partners that could carry contaminants and illnesses and infections and so on. But then this can also be extended into moral disgust, where we will feel disgusted at people who behave extremely unethically.

- 2.38** This idea falls under the framework of error management theory. Error management theory was developed by David Buss and others, and he suggested, with error management theory, that people tend to err on the side of making errors that will reduce their likelihood of being harmed. As an example of this, there have been some very clever studies here where you find that—you ask people, "Would you eat a piece of fudge shaped like feces?" A lot of people would say no. You ask people, "Would you drink apple juice out of a sterilized clean bedpan?" Most people say no. "What about eating a sterilized dead cockroach?" Again, most people say no.
- 2.39** Even though these would all be perfectly fine. This would not affect your health in any way. But error management theory says the reason why we feel a little queasy at the thought of doing this is because it's better for you to avoid fudge-shaped feces than to accidentally ingest something that might contain feces in it, where we err more so on the side of protecting ourselves from contaminants, rather than mistakenly consuming something that could infect us or poison us.
- 2.40** What's really cool here is that you see this compensatory effect in pregnancy with mothers, or what some people call birthing people. With pregnant women, compared to when they're not pregnant, they're more prone to experiencing disgust. And the reason for this is that, when a woman is pregnant, her immune system is compromised because her body is directing resources into growing a fetus. And so she's more prone to becoming sick, to illnesses, and to infection.
- 2.41** And so, as a result of this, the body compensates in a different direction by making them more prone to, and sensitive to, disgust, avoiding anything that could possibly lead to them being sick in the first place. This is why you get things like morning sickness and avoiding certain kinds of foods. There are anecdotal reports of pregnant women who suddenly become very interested in eating the foods that they consumed in childhood. One possibility here is that your body knows you consumed that food in childhood and you've lived long enough to survive to this point, so that food is almost certainly not going to kill you.
- 2.42** When you ask people about these scenarios that elicit disgust, if I ask you, "Why is peeing a pool disgusting?", you're not going to tell me about microbes. You're not going to tell me about pathogens and parasites and sickness and so on, at least not at first. At first, you're just going to say, "Well, that's just disgusting. Why do you even need to ask me that?" But then, if I ask you to think about it, you might reference pathogens, parasites, illnesses, and so on.
- 2.43** But people have been feeling the emotion of disgust long before the germ theory of disease, long before we had these articulate, scientifically sound explanations. Before the germ theory of disease, people were still disgusted by bodily excrement, by rotting meat, by coming into contact with anything that could possibly make them sick, even if they couldn't explain why this was the case. This gets us to something important here, which is that you don't need to know why a behavior is effective for it to work.

- 2.44 Disgust has been keeping humans safe long before we understood why we felt disgust in the first place. You don't need to know why you should avoid ingesting rotting meat. You just avoid it, and that's good enough to keep you alive; you don't need to know the explanation. When I talk about the unconscious mind, some people are skeptical of this, but from an evolutionary perspective, I think it helps to go into different examples from other species.
- 2.45 So, spiders weave webs. Why do they weave webs? Because they're trying to catch insects to consume them, keep them alive long enough to reproduce. Spiders don't know that they're doing this for this reason. They couldn't articulate this reason. Even if you could communicate with them, they don't have the neurons and the sophistication and so on to be able to communicate to this. They're just acting on impulses that have been shaped by billions of years of evolution.
- 2.46 Elk don't know why they lock antlers. They do this in order to impress females during mating season, but they would not be able to communicate to you that this is why they're doing this. They just act on instinct and impulse. This leads them to mate, to have offspring, and so on. They don't need to know why they're doing this for it to be effective.
- 2.47 Take a look at this image of the bower bird. Developing and building this nest took years. What's the point of building this nest? It's to impress female birds. This behavior evolved to impress female birds, so that they'll come along. If you watch extended documentaries of this, you'll see female birds coming along and inspecting the place. If it's up to par, they'll mate, and if not, they'll just look around and fly away, unimpressed. What's really cool is that this is not even the nest that the female bower birds use to lay their eggs. The female birds build a separate nest entirely that's not nearly as elaborate or beautiful.
- 2.48 This whole thing is not for the eggs. It's simply to impress the female birds. That's it. What's funny is that sometimes the male bower birds will build these. They'll fly away looking for additional supplies and material. A different male bird will come and sabotage the whole thing, fly away. The original bird comes back and just panics and stresses out. Like, what happened to my beautiful artwork? But again, this is a bird, not an especially sophisticated creature. Probably couldn't explain to you why it's doing all of this. It's obeying its instincts, its impulses.
- 2.49 In many ways, humans are the same. Chimpanzees behave this way as well. So we act before we understand. You don't need to know why your behaviors work in order to aid evolutionary fitness. Even for human beings, conscious mental effort is calorically costly. So, evolution made most of our actions and desires and patterns of behavior unconscious.
- 2.50 A simple way to think about this is the first time you learn to drive a car, that is extremely demanding mentally. Then, once you have mastered this skill, this frees up

mental space to think about other things, to plan, to daydream, to think about the future. But you could imagine, what if every aspect of life, every single day, was as difficult and cognitively demanding as driving a car for the first time? We wouldn't survive for very long. Most of our actions and desires are unconscious. This helps us to survive, reproduce.

- 2.51** On this point, we should make a distinction between proximate versus ultimate explanations here, because I'll be focusing on ultimate explanations. What is a proximate explanation? Evolutionary psychologists say that the proximate explanation is: What is the immediate cause of the behavior? If you take something like eating, if I ask, "Why are you eating that cronut?", you'll say, "Because I'm hungry." That's the immediate, obvious, intuitive answer. You eat because you're hungry. That's the proximate explanation.
- 2.52** But then the ultimate explanation, the question here is, from an evolutionary perspective, why did that desire or behavior evolve in the first place? Of course, the answer is: you eat because you require calories to survive; you require energy. Very few people will cite the ultimate explanation to explain their everyday behavior. It'd be very weird if I asked, "Why are you eating that?" and you're saying, "Well, evolution implanted in me this desire to consume calories because it converts it into energy, which allows me to survive and reproduce."
- 2.53** But those two explanations are not mutually exclusive. Those are both correct. But evolutionary scientists look at the ultimate explanation for behavior. You say this for something like sex as well. You ask someone, "Why do you have sex?" They enjoy it. We evolved to enjoy sex. But then evolutionary psychologists say, "Well, why did we evolve to enjoy sex?" The obvious answer is because, in the ancestral environment, sex predictably resulted in offspring. Perhaps at some point in the mists of evolutionary history, there were humans or prehuman ancestors who didn't enjoy sex or didn't pursue sex. Those are not our ancestors.
- 2.54** It applies to friendships, sexual relationships, and so on. Even for things like status symbols, something like, if you ask a man, "Why did you buy that Lamborghini?", he might say something like, "Well, because it makes me feel confident." A woman might say something similar for wearing cosmetics. But of course, feeling good can't just arise out of nowhere. Why do you feel more confident as a result of this? Why do you feel better when you act in this way?
- 2.55** Of course, the answer is that it makes you a more appealing romantic partner, gets the people around you to hold you in a little bit higher regard, or at least that's the aim. Now, makeup and sports cars didn't exist in the ancestral environment, but that motivation still existed to do things, to impress other people, to ingratiate ourselves, to build alliances, attract romantic partners, and so on. Here's a quote from Geoffrey Miller, the psychologist. He says, "A costly behavior cannot evolve just because it

happens to feel good. Feeling good must have evolved to motivate the behavior, which must have some hidden benefit."

- 2.56** This gets at this idea of the ultimate explanation. You see this for things like modifying voice pitch. People who view themselves—this is especially true for men— men who view themselves as physically stronger than their male interlocutor will subtly speak in a deeper voice, especially in competitive situations. If they see themselves as weaker than their conversational partner, their voice will elevate slightly in pitch. The evolutionary explanation here has to do with dominance and submission, of wanting to demonstrate strength versus submission.
- 2.57** All of those things are tied up with evolutionary explanations of promoting your evolutionary interests. If you're a strong person, it can be beneficial for you to display that strength. If you're not particularly strong, it can be helpful for you to downplay yourself, to be a little bit meager, so as to not present a threat and invite some reprisal or violence. You see this for—this applies to both men and to women. When you ask people to speak on a topic they have expertise in, they tend to speak in a deeper voice than when they're asked to speak about a topic they do not have expertise in. The lowered pitch, generally, signals status, authority, dominance, expertise, those kinds of things.
- 2.58** I've been watching this mini-series called *The Dropout*, about Elizabeth Holmes, the disgraced founder of Theranos. And famously, she intentionally developed this deep voice because she believed that people would take her more seriously. And there's all these clips online of what she was like before she founded Theranos versus after, and she sounds very different. But maybe she was familiar with this research, or she just understood this intuitively, that if she spoke in this unnaturally deep voice, people would defer to her or take her more seriously.
- 2.59** It's not just voices or disgust. Even for things like our policy preferences, political preferences, there was a study years ago from Rob Kurzban and his colleagues, and they were trying to understand why people held such strong beliefs around the legalization of drugs. What they found in their paper was that, of course, it's tied up in concerns about harm. Drugs can hurt people, that kind of thing. But it also seems to be associated with people's relationship orientation, their reproductive strategies.
- 2.60** They basically found that people who preferred a more monogamous relationship style held more prohibitive views on drug use and drug legalization, whereas people who favored a more short-term, casual approach to relationships were much more permissive in terms of drug legalization and drug use. What's funny is, even when they — so they looked at the association between something like religion. Maybe religiosity predicts these strict attitudes. What's the association between religiosity and views around drug use? They found this significant relationship.

- 2.61** But then, once they controlled for sexual attitudes, the relationship disappeared. What this suggests is that it's actually more so about people's attitudes around sex, more so than their attitudes around religion, that's responsible for these attitudes. The idea here is that drugs seem to increase the likelihood of casual sex and promiscuity. This can threaten the stability of committed pair bonds. If people are doing drugs, and there's parties and raves and all of these substances out there, this can create an environment that's better for people who are oriented towards short-term relationships versus long-term relationships.
- 2.62** The idea here is that there may be some hidden motives that we're not even aware of for attitudes around something like drug use. You can see this even within the span of a single life, where often when you're very young, and you're in your exploratory phase, you tend to take a more permissive view of drug use. Then, as you get older and you form a relationship and get married and have kids, your priorities shift, and then often the same person later in life will hold a stricter view with regard to drug use. And yes, the point here is that each side is in effect trying to control the social costs of promiscuity. Again, this is happening unconsciously.
- 2.63** The same thing seems to be happening with attitudes around abortion as well. This is a very recent study where they tested whether opposition to abortion is primarily about sanctity of life concerns or a hidden sexual strategy. Of course, the face value view says that, if you are opposed to abortion, you should favor any policy that reduces abortions. But then there's this other view, which is that people will back policies that are consistent with their approaches to relationships and their attitude towards casual sex.
- 2.64** They conducted a series of studies, and they found that a lot of people who have strong belief in the pro-life stance, that attitude is also tightly linked with their attitudes around regulating sexual behavior as well. And so, the idea here is that, of course, people who are pro-life sincerely believe in the sanctity of life. But then, there's this other motive alongside of that, which is to ensure that people form monogamous pair bonds and relationships, and they don't want to introduce options for people to behave in a more short-term-oriented way.
- 2.65** Of course, the flip side is also true, that people who are pro-choice are essentially attempting to reduce the cost of casual sex so that they can partake in more of it. If you support abortion access, those people do sincerely believe in the importance of choice and health care rights and all those kinds of things. They do believe that. But alongside that, they also tend to favor a more short-term-oriented approach to relationships, and they want to have options, in case consequences arise as a result of their behaviors.
- 2.66** So the key point here is that both sides use moral language sincerely, but also to advance their favored relationship and reproductive strategies. The people who are pro-choice also tend to be very permissive in their attitudes around drug use. That's not a coincidence. Those things cluster together because they have a short-term approach

to mating. People who are pro-life also tend to hold rigid views around drug use. That's not a coincidence either, because people who do lots of drugs and have access to abortion and so on, this can raise the possibility of more short-term relationships taking place, but then also it can make it harder to form long-term relationships.

- 2.67** If everyone around you—this is a very simplified, reductive way to think about it—but if everyone around you is very interested in casual sex, and they have options, and you can take drugs and all this stuff, it becomes harder to find a committed partner in that environment. Then vice versa. If you're a person who's very interested in casual sex, but everyone around you is rigidly pro-life and anti-drug and holds those types of attitudes, it's going to be harder for you to enact your favorite sexual strategy as well.
- 2.68** You see these unconscious forces also operating for anger. Anger is involuntary. Anger also has an evolved purpose, just like disgust has an evolved purpose. Anger is essentially a bargaining tool. When you experience anger, you're not thinking, "This person is treating me badly. Something wrong is happening in my life. I'm going to get angry now to orchestrate cognitive and physiological and emotional and behavioral responses, in order to get this person to place more weight on my well-being." None of that is consciously happening in your mind.
- 2.69** Someone does something that makes you feel like they have mistreated you, you feel anger immediately. This is an involuntary, unconscious process. I think that this evolutionary view of anger, the bargaining view of anger, is interesting because it suggests that there can be these evolutionary misfirings. So, hitting inanimate objects. I wish I had this figure for you, but there's a very funny graph of at what age people are most likely to be hospitalized for punching walls, specifically for males. It peaks around 15 to 25. That's the age in which they're most likely to go to the hospital as a result of punching a wall, and then it rapidly declines after 30.
- 2.70** I think what's going on here is that, because we're socio-cognitive creatures, typically when we experience anger, it's the result of a conscious, sentient being mistreating us, and so we express anger in order to get them to calibrate their response to us and treat us better. But that anger can be redirected. I remember, years ago, I was living with some roommates, and my friend, he punched a hole in the wall because he was playing Call of Duty, and he lost a game, and he threw the controller against the wall and shattered it and then punched a hole in the wall.
- 2.71** That doesn't really make sense, but you think of this as a kind of misfiring of the purpose of anger. But you see this with disgust as well, like the earlier scenarios I read you about eating a feces-shaped piece of fudge or something. We can experience these emotions, even when they don't necessarily benefit us. You see this with blushing as well. Blushing is also involuntary. The purpose of blushing is to inform observers that you know that you made a social faux pas.

- 2.72** There have been these really cool studies where, if you have the same person commit some kind of faux pas, and in one case, they're blushing, and in another case, they aren't, and then you ask the observers, "How embarrassed do you think this person is? How likely do you think they are to do that again? How much do you trust this person?" and so on, people generally like the person who blushed more than the person who didn't blush, because they're aware that that person knows that they did something wrong. They're going to try not to do it again.
- 2.73** In some cases, blushing can even replace a spoken apology. If you see someone blush, and then they start to apologize, you can often say something like, "Yeah, I know. It's OK." You can tell immediately that they're sorry. They don't even have to say it. Again, you don't have this well-thought-out sequence. "I have made a fool of myself in front of these people. I'm going to get embarrassed now and orchestrate the blushing mechanism." This is involuntary. Your face flushes before you even decide how you'd like to react.
- 2.74** So much of human life is like this. The same thing for crying. Crying evolved to signal need, to elicit care for others. Again, these are ultimate explanations. This is not consciously happening in your mind. But we cry more when we are with people who we know will support us, versus people who won't. You'll often see people suppress their tears when they're around people who they don't believe care very much for them. But then, when they get home, and they're with their loved ones, then they'll break down and start to cry, because, unconsciously, they're aware that this will elicit social support from the people who care for them.
- 2.75** People cry more when loved ones are nearby, and less when they're alone or isolated. The idea here is that tears act as nonverbal requests for help. Because there have been a lot of interesting physiological studies, trying to figure out: Why do we eject tears from our eyes? What's the purpose of this? Is there some kind of physical benefit? So far, the answer seems to be no. It doesn't actually do anything for us. Sometimes crying can make us feel better, but people feel much better if they are being socially supported.
- 2.76** And that seems to be the reason why crying feels good most of the time. You see this with children as well. Children are more likely to cry when they're near their parents than when they're with their friends or when they're alone, regardless of how much time they spend with each group. Sometimes kids don't know whether they should cry or not, and then they see a parent nearby, and then they decide to cry, because they know that that will lead to some nurturing and care and reward and so on. You see this with infants as well.
- 2.77** I want to quote here Carl Jung, in *The Development of Personality*, who suggests that "actions are to be judged more by their results than by their conscious motives. The importance of conscious thinking for action is boundlessly overestimated. The criterion for the psychology of the act is not the conscious motive, but the result of the act."

- 2.78** Conscious motives matter, but from the perspective of evolutionary psychology, we want to know the effect of the act. What is the underlying purpose of this, things like hunger, disgust, anger, crying, these things? It's very interesting to know: What is their underlying purpose? How do they aid our evolutionary fitness? What purpose do they serve beyond that they feel good or they feel bad?
- 2.79** So when we understand the unconscious mind, we're not trying to drag every hidden motive out into the open, but it helps to recognize that we have some of those underlying drives, cultivating an awareness of them. We can act a bit more deliberately, exert a bit more control over ourselves and our lives. It can help us to understand other people more. So yes, what matters is not just intentions, but outcomes as well, the effect of the behavior, not necessarily the explicit verbalized reason why.
- 2.80** And so, we took that long detour through the unconscious to get to this point that morality is shaped by the unconscious. I quoted David Hume, David Brooks, Jonathan Haidt, that much of moral judgment happens automatically before conscious reasoning. We feel what's right, we feel what's wrong. We justify and explain it afterward. That's the idea here. It's less about conscious, explicit thought, more about intuition. This is the task of moral psychology, understanding these gut feelings and to perhaps gain some control over them.
- 2.81** So, with that in mind, things are about to get weird. I warn you, trigger warning. This was a scenario from a landmark psychology paper from Jonathan Haidt. I'm going to read you this scenario. Julie and Mark are brother and sister. They are traveling together in France on summer vacation from college. One night, they are staying alone in a cabin near the beach. They decide that it would be interesting and fun if they tried making love. At the very least, it would be a new experience for them. Julie was already taking birth control pills, but Mark uses a condom, too, just to be safe. They both enjoy making love, but they decide never to do it again. They keep that night as a special secret, which makes them feel even closer to each other.
- 2.82** What do you think about that? Was that OK? Who thinks it's OK, what they did, Julie and Mark, brother and sister, making love? OK, good. I knew some of you would shoot your hand up and look around. Why isn't anyone with me? How many of you think it's not OK? OK. How many of you aren't sure? Not sure? That's the weirdest one of all. So, as you can imagine, people have this impulsive reaction to this. They feel disgust, a brother and sister. When Haidt and his colleagues presented this scenario to people and asked them, "Is this OK?", the vast majority of people said this was wrong. They shouldn't have done this.
- 2.83** You ask them why, and they might say something like, "What if they have a kid, and the kid will grow up freaky?" Then, they said, "They used a condom. There's birth control." Then, why else would it be wrong? Why else would—and they say, "It's not good for siblings to have a relationship with one another." They said, "They did agree to only do this once. It's a one-time thing." Eventually, you'll find that participants experience

what psychologists call moral dumbfounding. Eventually, they'll say, "Look, it's just wrong. It's just wrong. It's hard to articulate why, but I know that something went wrong here."

- 2.84** All right, another scenario, the family dog. It's not what you think. The family dog. The family dog runs out into the street, gets hit by a car. The family brings the dog in. They're very sad, but then they realize they have nothing planned for dinner tonight. So they cook the dog and eat it, and it's delicious, and they're very happy. Have they done anything wrong? People are slightly more likely to say this is OK versus the sibling scenario, but still, most people say this was wrong.
- 2.85** Then, when you ask them, they often struggle to come up with reasons why this was wrong, and we'll discuss this later, particularly in Western countries, which, some anthropologists say, we hold to what's called an ethic of autonomy, that as long as no one's hurt, as long as everything is consensual and no one's hurt, then it's OK. But then you start presenting scenarios like this, where no one is hurt, and still a lot of people have this uncomfortable feeling that something went wrong here.
- 2.86** The flag. A guy's toilet is very dirty, but this guy has run out of cleaning supplies. Fortunately, he has an American flag, or the country of your origin. He takes the flag, uses it to scrub the toilet clean. Now he's very happy. He has a clean toilet. Has he done anything wrong?
- 2.87** I think an interesting variation of this would be not to use the American flag, but to use other symbols of reverence for different communities, because you could imagine that, especially in our highly politicized climate, people may not feel that using the American flag in this context is wrong, but if they use a different flag, the LGBTQIA flag or other types of flags, a lot of people would object to this. Again, no one is hurt. It's in the privacy of this person's home, but a lot of people would say this person did something wrong.
- 2.88** The chicken, and this one is as weird as you would think. A guy is lonely, so he purchases a frozen chicken from the supermarket, brings it home and has sex with it, then he cooks it and eats it. Again, a lot of people are repulsed by this. No one's hurt, no one's harmed, no one even knows except this guy and the chicken, I guess. But still, we feel this gut reaction. Again, when you ask people about this, they often struggle to come up with reasons. You press them on it, and they can't necessarily explain why they think that these things are wrong. And this inability to justify our gut feelings is called moral dumbfounding.
- 2.89** But I want to make a point here that this isn't necessarily—just because we can't articulate the reasons why we feel a certain way, this doesn't necessarily lead to relativism or nihilism or something. In fact, I think that if you were to reject a theory simply because you think it might make people nihilistic, that's almost as nihilistic, or perhaps even more nihilistic, than the theory itself.

- 2.90** If you say, "Oh, people shouldn't be aware of these ideas because it might make them think that morality isn't real," or something along those lines, but Haidt doesn't deny, by the way, that reason can shift moral values, but he just says it's mostly rooted in gut feelings. It's harder to change people's moral views through reason alone. And even when reason does change people's minds on moral topics, it usually works by eliciting specific emotions.
- 2.91** This leads us to this point about, how do you change people's minds on moral questions? What's funny is that, if you ask people directly, "How do I change your mind about a hot-button contentious political topic? Would you rather have the facts or would you rather have anecdotes and stories?", just about everyone says, "Give me the facts. I want the numbers. I want the studies. I want the statistics. I want to know what's actually true." But then, when you actually present people with facts or stories, people are far more persuaded by the stories than they are by the facts.
- 2.92** This was a very recent study, which essentially, they brought people together, and they may be on opposing sides of the gun control debate, for example. Maybe independently, they'll first present them with facts. Here are the numbers on gun control. Here are the facts, here are the figures. People are generally unmoved by these studies, statistics, and so on.
- 2.93** But then when they interact with someone who tells them a story, someone who they disagree with, but they have a personal story—a woman who lives alone, an intruder breaks in, and the only reason she survived is because she had a gun, or someone, opposing sides of the immigration debate, someone who's very against immigration, here's a story from someone who describes how his father came to this country to seek a better life, and then he was deported—those types of stories seem to be much more persuasive than just giving people the facts and figures on immigration or on gun control.
- 2.94** Of course, what does this imply? This implies that emotion changes minds more so than reason. We like to think of ourselves as very rational, reasonable, logical people. This is how we form our moral judgments, our political views, but a lot of it is rooted in these pre-attentive, unconscious, emotional impulses. We're going to leave it there. We're going to go over more moral intuitions, moral foundations, different frameworks. But I want to open this up to a Q&A. We have a few minutes left. So, who has questions? What are your questions? Yeah, here.
- 2.95** I'm still thinking about these babies that are left to exposure, to be eaten by an animal and so on. And thinking about what you had said, when folks are repelled by rotten meat. They might not know the reason why, or the reasons might change. But that's a behavior that has changed. We no longer leave infants to die of exposure. You would think, based on this evolutionary theory, that we might change our reasons for it. And yet it seems that, in our culture, people are continuing to fight till the bitter end for sick

children, even when they know that there's no hope that they can survive. So what's changed?

- 2.96** What's most likely changed in the modern world is the abundance of resources. We have access to medical technology. We have options. In many countries, it's illegal for hospitals to turn you away. Once you have these options available to you, then you would go to any length. I would imagine, if those societies in times past, or even in contemporary hunter-gatherer societies, if they had the level of resources and access and medical technology and so forth, they too might also say, "We need to go to extraordinary lengths to save this life or to keep this child alive." But likewise, modern people, if— you've probably seen enough disaster movies and so on where suddenly you're forced to make heartbreaking choices. Maybe you would find yourself leaving a loved one when you would rather not do it. Other questions? Yeah, Paul.
- 2.97** Going back to the beginning, I've been wondering the whole time, you had quoted, I believe, a philosopher about the definition of morality, right? And the definition of morality, most simply put, is cooperation. So I was wondering what your views were about John Forbes Nash, and the Nash equilibrium concept, which is cooperation, but it's a mathematics of cooperation. I've always viewed that as being like a mathematical proof of karma.
- 2.98** Oh, interesting.
- 2.99** So what do you think of karma, John Forbes Nash, *A Beautiful Mind*?
- 2.100** Yeah, some of you probably saw the Russell Crowe film, *A Beautiful Mind*, depicting the life of John Nash. I'm thinking about game theory. The most basic game in game theory or interaction is the prisoner's dilemma, which essentially shows that cooperation, especially in repeated patterns of interaction, has the highest payoff. There have been game theorists and people who are into computational modeling and those kinds of things which have found that there seems to be an optimal level of cooperation.
- 2.101** I brought this up earlier. If you have a community of cold-blooded psychopaths who have no regard for other people, that community will be rapidly wiped out. But then, if you had a group of extreme altruists who unthinkingly help anyone who asks for it, regardless of their own level of need, that community would also be wiped out as well. So we seem to be selective cooperators. I have seen some interesting work on this, attempting to model this mathematically, that there is an optimal level of cooperation. You don't betray everyone around you, but you also don't say yes to every single possible request from other people as well. Good question. We have time for one more question. Yeah.
- 2.102** So, regarding the ostracization you just mentioned regarding people with the psychopathic tendencies and everything, especially among the youth, how would we start to address this domestication practice in a more increasingly online environment that's largely devoid of such accountability?

- 2.103** It's a good question. The question is: Can we apply some of the tools of self-domestication in the modern online world, where, if we're increasingly online, this can incentivize bad behavior? It's harder to penalize it. What's really interesting is that there has been some fascinating work on this very question. I actually think we're going to get into this at a later lecture. But one popular hypothesis about what's happening online, why you see so much misbehavior, is that you're depersonalized. You're distant, there's no penalty. You can insult people, badmouth people, and you're in the comfort of your own home. So this leads people to behave worse. That's one hypothesis.
- 2.104** But then another hypothesis is that the people who are nasty online tend to be nasty offline as well, and the people who are kind in real life also tend to be kind online. But because of the way that the online environment is shaped, because it tends to promote the most sensational, outrageous, negative, toxic content, and because people who have elevated levels of narcissism and other antagonistic traits tend to post more frequently online, this creates the illusion that social media is full of toxicity when, in fact, it's a very small number of people who post a lot of content online, and that's what we're exposed to.
- 2.105** The evidence seems to lean more toward the latter, that most people, the internet doesn't make them worse. But for people who are not very pleasant to be around in real life, they have found a playground online, to basically flood it with a lot of toxic content. But we're going to get into this more in a future lecture. Good question. I think we'll leave it there then.

Lecture 3: Moral Theories

At a glance — Moral theories.

- 3.1 OK. Good morning. In our last session, we spoke about moral dumbfounding, another important work from Jonathan Haidt and his collaborators. Today, we'll be continuing our discussion of Haidt's contributions to moral psychology, and we'll also transition into some critiques of his framework, and then some alternative conceptions of moral psychology.
- 3.2 Recall some of the scenarios we discussed. We talked about incest between siblings. We spoke about families eating their dogs after an accident. We spoke about a man making love to a rotisserie chicken. Many people feel some discomfort with these scenarios. They think that something wrong has happened. Maybe this is immoral, even if they explicitly state that they believe in this ethic of autonomy. As long as no one's hurt, then you should be able to do whatever you want. Still, in these scenarios, no one is explicitly harmed; and yet, a lot of people would condemn these acts.
- 3.3 One of the most fascinating ideas to come out of moral psychology is this idea of moral foundations theory. According to moral foundations theory, there's more to morality than just harm. Moral foundations theory was developed by Haidt and his collaborators. It's a cross-cultural theory informed by evolution. The idea here is that our moral psychology evolved in response to adaptive challenges in our environment.
- 3.4 And so, again, we spoke about this, that our psychology is primarily equipped to—rather, it was shaped by the lives of humans in nomadic hunter-gatherer societies. In that environment, evolution favored the emergence of these quick and rapid intuitions around what's right, what's wrong, sensitivity not just to harm, but to some additional what are called moral foundations under this theory. These foundations arose to solve social dilemmas, suppress selfishness, promote cooperation.
- 3.5 Moral foundations theory has generated hundreds, if not thousands, of studies by now. It's a diverse account of morality. It's not a one-size-fits-all, that this is the right framework to understand morality; this is the wrong way to understand morality. Rather, the idea here is that, wherever you go cross-culturally, or if you examine cultures throughout history, you'll recognize these five foundations, and morality will be expressed under these five foundations in different ways.
- 3.6 What are the five foundations? We have care, the opposite being harm. You have fairness and cheating, loyalty and betrayal, authority and subversion, and purity and degradation. In many Western societies, what are sometimes called WEIRD societies, which we'll discuss later in this lecture, if you ask people explicitly, "What are your moral principles?", they'll usually cite things like care or harm. You shouldn't hurt other people. Then, to a lesser extent, they'll endorse the foundation of fairness. You

shouldn't cheat people, you shouldn't betray people, you should be impartial and avoid cheating people.

- 3.7** But what a large body of research shows is that these other three foundations are critical as well. The care foundation is rooted in empathy, in compassion, protecting the vulnerable, ensuring that people aren't, either physically or verbally, being aggressive toward others. We spoke about this before, that the original evolutionary attachment for mammals is between mothers and infants.
- 3.8** Then later, evolution co-opted that mechanism to expand toward other family members, toward other kin, and then eventually to social allies, friends, romantic partners, and even in modern societies, to strangers, which is historically extremely unusual for people to care about those who are outside of their social circle. We'll talk a bit more about in-groups and out-groups later. Again, empathy and compassion under this foundation shape our sense of right and wrong.
- 3.9** But then there's the fairness foundation. If you were to take one of the moral foundations questionnaires, you would essentially see a series of transgressions, and then you would rate them. How wrong is each of these violations? Then you would get a score on the five dimensions to see how much you endorse each foundation. For the fairness foundation, you'll see that people care deeply about when someone takes more than their fair share. Of course, in our evolutionary past, cooperation only worked when people believed that things were more or less allocated fairly.
- 3.10** Not equally, by the way. We'll discuss that in a second. But we tend to experience extreme resentment toward cheaters, people who violate our notions of fair play. This foundation of fairness underlies our intuitions around justice, around reciprocity, around trust. There was a paper that came out just a few years ago, which surveyed a large body of research. This paper suggested that people actually prefer unequal societies.
- 3.11** People, when you pose specific questions to them, "Do you prefer fairness? Do you prefer equality?", you show them different scenarios. Generally speaking, people prefer an ethic of fairness rather than equality. People want to live in a society where they are fairly recompensed for their efforts, and they don't like societies in which everyone receives an equal distribution of resources regardless of their contribution. So, I'll just quote you here part of the abstract to this study.
- 3.12** "Despite appearances to the contrary, there is no evidence that people are bothered by economic inequality itself. Rather, they are bothered by something that is often confounded with inequality, economic unfairness. Drawing upon laboratory studies, cross-cultural research, and experiments with babies and young children, we argue that humans naturally favor fair distributions, not equal ones, and that when fairness and equality clash, people prefer fair inequality over unfair equality. Both psychological

research and decisions by policymakers would benefit from more clearly distinguishing inequality from unfairness."

- 3.13** And a very simple way to think about this, examples from the real world, you've had communist societies separated by partitions, and in free-market capitalist societies, those inevitably become unequal. But people generally have some notion of fairness that, in a capitalist society, you put in more effort. On average, you will receive more rewards; whereas in a communist society, equality is valorized, regardless of whatever your contributions happen to be.
- 3.14** Where do people flee? When people vote with their feet, what do they prefer? Even America, which is one of the most unequal societies in the world, far more people try to enter the United States than exit. And that is in part because the United States is an unequal society. I had a conversation awhile back with this Filipino guy, a Filipino American guy, manager of a restaurant. He had a lot of Filipino employees. He expressed his surprise. When he first moved to the U.S., he said, "Wow, if I work harder, I earn more money. Then, now that I've been running this restaurant, a lot of my employees are saying the same thing."
- 3.15** That link is intuitive to us. You work more hours, you put in more effort, and you expect greater rewards. In a lot of other societies, that is not the case. Of course, there are even more unequal societies than the U.S., but the U.S. is one of the most unequal, and yet people still prefer to flee here. There are more equal societies. There's very little inequality in a place like North Korea, but very few people would like to relocate there.
- 3.16** And so, in the real world, people prefer these unequal distributions when they view them as valid, as earned, as justified. People don't seem to mind inequality if it reflects effort or merit or fair procedures. But people are also bothered when their efforts go unrewarded, when they believe that the system is rigged, and then this can activate feelings of resentment. It's not so much the objective measure of fairness in a society, but the perceived level of fairness; and if people believe a society is unfair, regardless of whether it is actually fair or not, this can activate resentment as well.
- 3.17** What's interesting here is that, at least in the U.S., you find this distinction between educational levels, as far as how much people are bothered by inequality. If you pose people the direct choice, a forced choice, what's more important? Ensuring that Americans don't live in poverty or closing the gap between the rich and the poor? The first question is just about ensuring that people aren't poor. The second one is, we need to shrink the level of inequality in society.
- 3.18** For non-college-educated Americans, more working-class Americans, they say that ensuring Americans don't live in poverty is a more important policy goal. For college-educated Americans, they say that shrinking the gap between the rich and the poor is a more important policy goal than ensuring Americans don't live in poverty. You see different intuitions here. My suspicion is that, for a lot of college-educated Americans,

they harbor a deep skepticism about whether the U.S. is a fair society or not. Often, you find the opposite attitude among more working-class people. College-educated Americans are more concerned about inequality than poverty.

- 3.19** What's also interesting here is that, if you look across societies, you tend to see that poverty and inequality are inversely correlated. In other words, the more unequal the society, the less poverty there tends to be. And the more poverty there is in a society, the less inequality there tends to be. Typically, what happens is, when societies get rich, you got people who are getting rich, but even within rich societies, you still have some poor people. In societies that are undeveloped, or developing societies, the vast majority of the people are poor, very few rich people. As a result, because everyone is relatively impoverished, you have very little inequality.
- 3.20** Now we have the loyalty foundation. This explains our coalitionary instincts. Evolution favored genes that get people to stick together, to defend one another, to care for those in their group, because this enhanced survival. Loyalty feels satisfying as well. When someone expresses their loyalty to you, that can feel satisfying. If you express your loyalty to someone else, that can also feel satisfying and fulfilling. This foundation underlies feelings around patriotism, sports, religion, our admiration for self-sacrifice, but also our condemnation and our dislike for traitors and for apostates.
- 3.21** Then, there's the authority and subversion foundation. So, throughout history, humans have formed these uneasy hierarchies. Hierarchies tend to perform best when they are based on prestige, on skills, on knowledge, rather than on dominance. This is a new framework to understand how hierarchies work, how social status works among humans. You have these two pathways. You have prestige, and you have dominance.
- 3.22** Dominance is, both in human societies and in animal societies, acquired through intimidation tactics, bullying, being confrontational, being hostile. Essentially, in hierarchies based on dominance, you defer to the dominant individual because of what they can do to you: inflict violence, physical disfiguration, damage your reputation in some way. There can be these non-physical means of dominance and intimidation tactics. As an example, someone like a brutal dictator, Joseph Stalin, acquired his authority through dominance.
- 3.23** Then there's, I mentioned prestige. Prestige seems to be unique to humans, although there seems to be—you can identify traces of it in nonhuman primates. Prestige, that type of authority is based on being knowledgeable, about being impressive, doing things that benefit the group, that other people value. Someone acquires prestige, not for what they can do to you, but what they can do for you—teach you things, share knowledge with you. Often, just by being associated with someone who acquired authority through prestige, that prestige can rub off on you.
- 3.24** Authority promoted survival. We admire legitimate leaders. We resent those who attempt to undermine them. We value this sense of respect and this sense of order if

we believe that the authority is legitimate. I mentioned this: the basis of stable authority is prestige, not dominance. Authority based on dominance is often highly unstable. You can see the pathologies around this in totalitarian societies, where there's often this lingering fear among dictators and the dictator's allies that the society will be toppled, and so they have to enact mass surveillance and all kinds of other means in order to attempt to sustain the society.

- 3.25 The opposite of authority is subversion. Subversion can be a tactic to actually co-opt authority for your own ends. There's a rich body of history, especially during the Cold War, of subversive groups attempting to plant insiders into trusted organizations to subvert the authority and then co-opt it for themselves. In communist societies, in Eastern Europe, there were subversive priests who were sympathetic to the communist project, and they were quietly pushed into parishes in the Catholic Church, in these Eastern European communities, in order to promote the communist ideology.
- 3.26 Researchers have found that young people who attended those parishes that were infiltrated by these communist priests were less resistant to the communist regime. They were more favorable towards the ideology of communism. This is one reason, among others, why people often are very interested in infiltrating influential organizations, and then often will redirect the mission toward their own ends. Obviously, there's nothing like that going on today.
- 3.27 Then we have the purity and degradation foundation. We talked a lot about disgust in our previous sessions. The foundation of purity is intertwined with disgust. Disgust evolved in order to protect us from disease, from contamination, and also expanded over time, not just to protect us from rotten food or from contaminants, pathogens, parasites, but also we now often experiencedisgust over misconduct, misbehavior, things that we think are wrong.
- 3.28 According to this foundation, we see the body and soul as having sanctity, a kind of purity, and we react strongly to things that feel corrupting or are degrading. This underlies taboos around food, around sex, around cleanliness, with a possible exception of developed Western societies. Cross-culturally, you tend to find that societies have taboos, particularly around food: what you're allowed to eat, what you're not allowed to eat. If you eat that, that's contaminating; it's polluting your body in some way, so you should eat this instead.
- 3.29 Then, the same for sex. The reason for this is that, historically, food and sex have been common pathways toward infection and illness and damaging the likelihood of survival. That seems to be the function of the foundations. We have these evolutionary explanations that underlie each one. For the care foundation, the original trigger in the ancestral environment: suffering, distress, neediness, especially as expressed by one's child. For fairness and cheating, we detect deception. We dislike betrayal, loyalty, threats or challenges to the group. We enjoy solidarity with those that we trust.

- 3.30** Authority and subversion, we recognize signs of dominance and submission, and we value legitimate authority. Then, for purity, sometimes called sanctity, we avoid contaminants, things that could potentially lead to infection. You see these foundations in the modern world now, with the care-harm foundation. Often, when you see a cute animal, for example, you feel this impulse to protect it, to express how cute it is to you. Then, that in turn will activate a protective response if that cute creature is under threat in some way.
- 3.31** Fairness, that foundation underlies marital vows, bonds with friends, with teammates on a sports team. Same thing for loyalty, sports teams, nations, that kind of thing. Authority and subversion. In modern corporations, organizational hierarchies, we have people who are responsible for others, and we expect them to behave with responsible authority. Then with purity, degradation, we're avoiding pathogens and so on, as I've mentioned.
- 3.32** But then also, that idea of avoiding contaminants seems to extend also to ideologies as well, where people will feel disgust at, for example, political views they might disagree with. You see this a lot online. "Oh, you're disgusting. How could you believe that? That's so gross." Even though posting or expressing an opinion is not going to lead you to become infected or sick in some way in a literal sense, but there's this feeling of, it might spread to me, it might affect me. Just hearing about it makes me feel disgusted and uncomfortable, and therefore, I want to keep my distance from it. It activates this avoidance response.
- 3.33** We're going to go over some items here for each of the five foundations. Here's one. You would rate these. If you were taking a moral foundations questionnaire, you would rate these on a scale from not at all wrong to extremely wrong. Here's one. You see a woman throwing a stapler at her colleague who is snoring during her talk—if I hear snoring in this class, I do have a stapler, heads up. You see a man laughing as he passes by a cancer patient with a bald head. You see a woman swerving her car in order to intentionally run over a squirrel. You see a boy setting a series of traps to kill stray cats in his neighborhood.
- 3.34** Imagine if this was your day. You'd have to get a new job, maybe change neighborhoods. But what you'll notice here is that these items are relatively mundane. Harm is being committed, but they're not very extreme. You're not talking about mass murder or killing, that kind of thing. This kid is killing stray cats. This woman is killing a squirrel. This guy is laughing at a cancer patient. Someone throws a stapler.
- 3.35** The reason why these items are relatively muted in terms of the amount of harm they cause is because, when you ask people about overt acts of harm—you see someone slapping someone else across the face, you see someone shooting a gun at someone else—when you pose these items to people, they almost always say it's a five out of five on the scale, extremely wrong. And if you have a questionnaire where everyone

always chooses the uppermost rating, then that doesn't tell you anything interesting, statistically.

- 3.36** As an analogy, if I wanted to know the statistical relationship between college grades and income, but everyone in my sample has straight As, then I'm not going to be able to identify any meaningful associations there. They created these items to essentially get people to score somewhere in the midpoint, where people will say, "These are somewhat wrong or very wrong, but not extremely wrong," although some people will say extremely wrong because you want that variation.
- 3.37** So, fairness items. You see a professor giving a bad grade to a student, just because he dislikes him. None of you are in danger of that. Not yet. You see a politician using federal tax dollars to build an extension on his home. You see a judge taking on a criminal case, although he is friends with the defendant. This gives you a sense of what they're trying to tap into with this fairness foundation.
- 3.38** Loyalty items, you see a mayor saying that the neighboring town is a much better town. You see a Hollywood star agreeing with a foreign dictator's denunciation of the U.S.—this is if you're posing these questions to Americans; you can replace that with the participant's country of origin.
- 3.39** Authority. You see a man secretly watching sports on his cell phone during a pastor's sermon. You see a boy turning up the TV as his father talks about his military service. These are disrespectful items.
- 3.40** Purity. I think that one looks familiar. You see a man having sex with a frozen chicken. You see a drunk elderly man offering to have oral sex with anyone in the bar. You see an employee at a morgue eating his pepperoni pizza off a dead body. Anyone else getting hungry?
- 3.41** Again, you would rate these on a scale from not at all wrong to extremely wrong. Then, you can find meaningful associations with the moral foundations questions, but other psychological traits as well.
- 3.42** One thing that's interesting about the moral foundations theory is that it purports to explain some interesting differences between liberals and conservatives. If you look at the moral attitudes as measured by the moral foundations theory of strong liberals, what you'll find is that they tend to endorse or agree that violations of care and of fairness are very wrong. You see these two lines up here, of harm and fairness, at the very top, so you can see the uppermost.
- 3.43** And as you trace it along, so the x-axis of political identification, you see that it's relatively high all along the x-axis, where just about everyone, regardless of their political orientation, says that violations of harm and fairness are wrong. But then the bottom three lines are lower across the board, but you see the gap is largest for strong liberals.

- 3.44** What this suggests is that, for strong liberals, they agree that harm violations and fairness violations are very wrong. But then, when you ask them about the authority violations, loyalty violations, purity violations, they tend to have a more relaxed, permissive attitude for things like having sex with a chicken, or if a boy turns up his television while his dad's talking about his military service. Strong liberals tend to hold less strict moral attitudes around those kinds of transgressions.
- 3.45** But then, as you travel along the x-axis to strong conservatives, they become much stricter in their attitudes. In other words, liberals and conservatives care about harm and fairness a great deal. Strong liberals tend not to place as much weight on authority and purity and loyalty violations, whereas conservatives tend to endorse all five foundations pretty strongly. They think that all five of these foundations are important.
- 3.46** This leads to some interesting directions here. Some researchers will call the care and fairness foundations individualizing foundations, because they're mostly about the self, this ethic of autonomy again, of, as long as you're not hurting anyone and you're treating people fairly, then whatever else you choose to do is OK. It's about protecting individuals from harm, protecting them from exploitation.
- 3.47** But then, you have these other three foundations, what are sometimes called the binding foundations, of loyalty, authority, and purity. This is more focused on holding groups together. It's more than just about the autonomous individual, but also about social functioning, cooperation, cohesion, social harmony. This holds groups together through cohesion and shared norms.
- 3.48** Now, again, liberals emphasize those individualizing foundations, this ethic of autonomy. Harm and fairness are important, care and fairness; the other foundations may be not as important. But for conservatives, they draw on all five of the moral foundations to inform their moral preferences, and they seem to care more about group identity, cooperation, tradition, respect for authority, and so on.
- 3.49** I think this does help to explain, to some extent, why these two groups seem to talk past each other in moral discussions. One thing that's really interesting here is that conservatives seem to understand liberals better than liberals seem to understand conservatives. The reason for this is, again, conservatives also value care and fairness. That's important to them. But they also value those other three foundations.
- 3.50** And so, when conservatives consider various moral transgressions and political disagreements, they can understand, OK, care is important, fairness is important, but they're also drawing on the other three. Whereas for liberals, they value care and fairness, and they have difficulty understanding that those other three foundations might be important to people. It's hard for them to have that sort of theory of mind, of taking the perspective of a conservative who cares about those other three foundations.

- 3.51** What's really interesting, this study has been conducted where you essentially take a group of liberals, give them a series of items, and say, "Answer this as if a conservative were taking this questionnaire." You do the same thing with conservatives. You say, "Hey, conservatives, here's a questionnaire. Fill this out as if you were a liberal." What the research shows is that conservatives are pretty good at this task, of jumping into the mind of a liberal and answering these questions as if they were liberal.
- 3.52** Liberals have difficulty doing this task, trying to imagine the mind of a conservative. What you'll often find is that liberals think that conservatives don't care about care or fairness, especially fairness. They'll say, "OK, yeah, conservatives don't want to physically harm anyone, but they don't really care about fairness. They're hyper-competitive, that kind of thing." But that's actually not the case.
- 3.53** Another interesting implication of moral foundations theory, findings extrapolated from these results, is that U.S. conservatives seem to be closer to the typical person around the world in terms of their moral preferences, because when you travel to non-Western societies, you'll find that they also endorse all five foundations. They don't endorse this ethic of autonomy, of, "Hey, as long as no one's hurt, let your freak flag fly."
- 3.54** No, in small-scale, pre-industrialized societies, developing countries, non-Western societies, they care deeply about authority, loyalty, purity. They care about identifying subversives and promoting social harmony, obeying religious edicts, and so forth. I've been using this acronym WEIRD. The acronym WEIRD comes from—this was a landmark paper from Joseph Henrich and his colleagues. The acronym stands for Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, Democratic societies.
- 3.55** When you talk about WEIRD societies, you're talking about the U.S., North America, parts of Europe, parts of Asia as well. There's a discussion about whether certain countries like Singapore, Japan, they're kind of WEIRD, kind of not WEIRD. The WEIRDer you are, both in the psychological sense, but also in the colloquial sense, the more you care about autonomy, individuality, personal fulfillment, putting yourself first. Some people make this distinction between individualized and collectivist societies.
- 3.56** WEIRD societies generally lean toward an ethic of autonomy. This is especially true for more liberal members of those societies. So more on WEIRDos. I mentioned this, non-WEIRD societies put a lot of weight on the binding foundations, which isn't to say that they don't also care about care and fairness, but they also value deeply the other three binding foundations. WEIRD societies emphasize care and fairness more strongly.
- 3.57** But then, within these WEIRD societies, you see that conservatives tend to be less WEIRD in the moral foundation sense than liberals are. This is why I said that conservatives seem to be more similar to people around the world in non-Western societies because they care about all five foundations, whereas liberals are particularly unique in terms of their moral preferences.

- 3.58** Then, most WEIRD of all: affluent college students. They seem to be extremely invested in this ethic of autonomy. When I presented some of those incest scenarios to you earlier, the researchers found that just about everyone says that incest is wrong. The sole exception to this, where people were slightly more likely to say incest was OK, were college students at elite universities.
- 3.59** So, how do liberals and conservatives differ from one another? I want to talk a bit more about this. There was a recent study where they essentially showed these study participants. It was a laboratory study. They brought people into a lab, showed them images of two faces side by side, and they asked them repeatedly to look at various different images side by side. Which of these faces looks more like a liberal? Which face looks more like a conservative? Then, over time, the researchers created these composite images that revealed how each participant views their own political side, and then also the opposing political side.
- 3.60** Here you can see, in the top left, conservative participants evaluating faces that looked more conservative. It looks like a nice guy. Again, I'm looking at the upper left here. Conservatives, looking at faces, that was the composite face that they thought looked the most conservative. Then you have the upper right, and that's liberal participants choosing faces that look very liberal. Also looks like a pretty nice guy, too.
- 3.61** Then, you look at the bottom left, and this is conservatives and their perceptions of what a liberal looks like. It looks neutral, slightly dour expression. Then, in the bottom right quadrant, you see the way that liberals perceive conservatives. That's the composite face that they believe represents what a conservative looks like. He looks very unhappy, quite angry. That's the one that doesn't look like the others. I posted this online, and someone thought that this looks like Elon Musk.
- 3.62** This same study also evaluated perceptions, not just of physical appearance, but also of personality traits and temperament of the opposing political side. One interesting finding here is that conservatives and liberals rated one another as equally immature. Conservatives thought of liberals as immature; liberals thought of conservatives as immature. Immature here meaning naive, misunderstands how the world works, that kind of thing.
- 3.63** But then, they also measured how savage each side viewed the other. Savagery here is about being callous, unfeeling, having this disregard for other people. What they found is that liberals rate conservatives as very high on savagery, whereas conservatives don't really rate liberals in the same way. One implication of this study seems to be that liberals seem to have a uniquely poor opinion of conservatives.
- 3.64** The other interesting finding from this study is that, they straight up asked people, "How much do you dislike the other side?" Then, they asked each side, "How much do you think the other side dislikes you?" What they found is that conservatives underestimated how much liberals dislike them. If you ask conservatives, "How do

liberals feel about you?", "I know they don't like me, but they don't hate me." That didn't seem to be the case here. Liberals had a strong disregard for conservatives.

- 3.65** Then they also found that liberals overestimate how much conservatives dislike them. If you ask liberals, "How do conservatives feel about you?", liberals respond by saying, "Oh, they hate us. They hate liberals. They hate me," when in fact, conservatives didn't like liberals as much as they liked conservatives, but it was not— the magnitude went in the opposite direction, where conservatives had their reservations about liberals, but they didn't hate them as much as liberals hated conservatives.
- 3.66** And so, yes, liberals have a uniquely poor opinion of conservatives. You see this with this kind of out-group dehumanization, which we'll discuss later in this course. Conservatives view liberals as immature, gullible, irresponsible, naive. You see a little bit of this with liberal perceptions of conservatives as well. Then liberals have this strong view of conservatives as being savage, aggressive, cold-hearted, self-centered, unfeeling. Liberals overestimate how negatively conservatives view them. Conservatives underestimate how negatively liberals view them.
- 3.67** There's also something to be said here about class versus culture. You might think that culture plays the most prominent role in our moral preferences, which is an important factor that contributes to how we view the social world and how we inform our moral judgments. But class and education also seem to play important roles here. A study some years ago looked at populations in Brazil, India, and the U.S., and they found that education was a stronger predictor of moral preferences than culture. Educated elites in Brazil, India, and the U.S. were all more similar to one another than they were with the native populations in their own countries.
- 3.68** Lower-income people in those countries, non-college-educated people, they were more similar to one another than they were to the elites within their own countries. Lower-income people valued those binding foundations of loyalty, authority, and purity, whereas the educated elites held to this ethic of autonomy, valuing care and fairness, and not so much the other three foundations. I think this is important here. Educated elites tend to be mobile. They interact more with one another. They share ideas. They're more transient.
- 3.69** This is a famous headline a few years ago, that most people around the world, including in the U.S., they live pretty close to where they grew up. They have roots. The typical American only lives 18 miles from their mother. The vast majority of Americans live within a two-hour drive from their parents. Whereas this small sliver of society, they tend to travel a lot, interact more with one another than they do with people in their own country. A lot of people who live in the U.S. might feel more at home in London than they would in a small town in their own country.
- 3.70** The ethic of autonomy shapes not just morality, but personality as well. Some of you may be familiar with the Big Five personality traits. How many of you are familiar with

the Big Five? Oh, good. OK. We'll talk a little bit about that later. One important finding with regard to the personality research is, psychologists have long assumed that the Big Five traits were universal. They thought, "Well, wherever you go, you're going to find these five personality traits." But this actually doesn't seem to be true. These are the Big Five personality traits—openness, conscientiousness, extroversion, agreeableness, and neuroticism. We'll go through these very briefly, and then I want to show you how much culture can shape these personality traits and maybe even compress them.

- 3.71 So, openness: entrepreneurial, creative people who are high on openness. They have a strong interest in receiving information from various sources. They tend to be interested in art. They're more likely to get tattoos and piercings. They enjoy, as far as reading material, philosophical novels, experimental and surrealist films. They tend to obtain more education on average, and they also tend to have fewer children.
- 3.72 Just very briefly, if you were to take a Big Five personality test, you would get a score on each of these five dimensions. This isn't like some typology where you take the test and, "Oh, I'm an open person, and you're a conscientious person." Rather, you get a score on all five of these dimensions, and then this can help you to understand your own personality. We covered openness.
- 3.73 Then, there's conscientiousness. Conscientiousness. People who score highly on this trait tend to be punctual. They tend to excel at school and work. They save money. They stick to their exercise routines. They favor books about history, about leadership, and they tend to favor films with plots involving weddings and fistfights. I suspect there's a gender difference there.
- 3.74 Interestingly, people who are high in conscientiousness also tend to use more verbal fillers, or what are sometimes called the discourse markers, more "um" and "uh" and so on. One suggested explanation for this is that people who are high in conscientiousness have this impulse control, and they want to be very careful with how they speak, and so they tend to pause very frequently and think as they speak, rather than speak freely in this more impulsive way.
- 3.75 Extroversion. Most people understand extroversion: people who enjoy social attention. They're more likely to assume leadership positions, not necessarily because they are more effective leaders, but more so because they are more social and they are more likely to capture the attention of those around them. When you think, "OK, who should be up for this leadership position?", you think about the people you know, people who you're familiar with, people who you seem to know the most about, and those tend to be extroverts, because they put themselves out there more. But extroversion actually has no relationship with leadership effectiveness.
- 3.76 Extroverts tend to have more friends, more sexual partners. They also get into more car accidents. Each trait has benefits and drawbacks. For reading material, they like memoirs, they like books about relationships, they like films about dating and

friendship. Interestingly, there's been a lot of work on this question of: Do people become happier if they behave as extroverts? The answer seems to be yes.

- 3.77** Generally, when you measure happiness, you correlate it with extroversion. The higher you are in extroversion, the more happy people report being. If you get introverts and you say, "I want you to go to this party and behave like an extrovert," they predict in advance that this is going to be an extremely miserable experience. But then afterwards, they actually report being happier than if you take an introvert and say, "Just go in there and behave like yourself." So, pretending to be an extrovert actually seems to have some benefits.
- 3.78** Agreeableness. So agreeableness is about maintaining social harmony, avoiding conflict, favoring negotiation and compromise. They tend to spend more time volunteering and helping people in need. Agreeable men tend to have fewer sexual partners on average, but agreeable people in general tend to have more children. It's also associated, interestingly, with slightly lower earnings. And agreeable people tend to favor books about family, about relationships. They enjoy conventional feel-good films.
- 3.79** And then finally, the fifth personality trait, neuroticism, sometimes referred to as emotional stability. The hallmark of this trait is mood variability. People who are high in neuroticism have a strong reaction to minor frustrations, everyday setbacks, this sensitivity and proneness to negative emotion. People who are high on emotional stability or low on neuroticism tend to experience less depression and anxiety. So people who are high on emotional stability like action movies, books about philosophy and science. Whereas people who are low on emotional stability or high on neuroticism, interestingly, many of them report liking horror films, which is a bit counterintuitive, and they like surrealist novels.
- 3.80** I mentioned that the ethic of autonomy shapes personality as well as morality. Personality psychologists have failed to find the Big Five personality traits in non-WEIRD societies, particularly non-student populations. Often, psychologists will do these studies in universities, because you have students there and you can basically require them to participate in the studies for course credit. It's low-hanging fruit. It's harder to go into societies, especially non-WEIRD societies, and get people to participate in studies.
- 3.81** Researchers have managed to do this, though. What they find is that, in places like Bolivia, Ghana, Kenya, Laos, Sri Lanka, Vietnam, and Macedonia, you don't see these five traits clearly emerge. The reason for this seems to be that, in modern developed societies, you have a lot of freedom to express your underlying traits. We value freedom, we value autonomy. You should cultivate your inner self, and then this allows all of your personality to manifest. Whereas in small-scale societies and in developing countries, you have very limited options for how you can behave, who you can interact

with, what your duties and obligations are, and this seems to compress how much of your personality you can express.

- 3.82** But you also see this, I think, for morality as well, that the foundations of loyalty, authority, and purity seem to compress individual personality traits. If you are required to be loyal to a particular group, respect this type of authority, adhere to these norms around purity, there's a limit to how much you can express your underlying self. But if you live in a society that primarily values care and fairness, you have a lot more leeway to express your underlying preferences and traits.
- 3.83** This is speculative, but I sometimes wonder if there's more personality variation among Western liberals versus Western conservatives, because again, while Western societies in general tend to value this ethic of autonomy, you see these political differences, where Western conservatives seem to be more similar to non-WEIRD people. I would imagine that maybe there's some personality compression among conservatives relative to liberals, where because liberals value autonomy so much, they are able to even more express those personality traits that they might hold.
- 3.84** We'll talk about the intelligence of these moral intuitions around these five foundations. Haidt, as we discussed, suggested that our moral judgments, our moral verdicts, are driven more so by emotions and by intuitions. And then we justify it ex post facto. We try to find reasons, explanations, and try to formulate a coherent explanation for why we have the gut feelings that we have. But it's also important to know here that reason also plays a role in shaping our moral intuitions and our moral responses as well.
- 3.85** One way that reason can triumph over our gut feelings is that you can manage what you expose yourself to. For example, if you know that if you scroll online, you're going to encounter something that upsets you or gets you angry or riled up, you can choose not to use your phone, or you can choose the types of accounts that you follow, and you can choose how you consume information. You can bind yourself in advance using reason, because you know that, once your attention is hijacked and once you're exposed to information, this will start to activate all of those gut feelings.
- 3.86** You can avoid temptation. You can also seek out alternative sources of information as well, speak with different kinds of people. You can deliberately seek counterexamples to ideas that you happen to agree with. Our point here is that intuitions matter, those gut feelings matter, but they aren't entirely sealed off from reasoning. We can use reason to control and shape those gut feelings, and determine when and in what manner we might consult our intuitions versus our reason.
- 3.87** There are a lot of stories now of people who avoid the news, in part because the news is optimized to make people angry and to get them to feel some kind of emotion. People will avoid news for all kinds of reasons, maybe because they want to avoid this feeling of empathy before they go on with their day. You might avoid a documentary

about a famine before going to dinner. You might seek out gossip that makes you feel justified in disliking someone. There are different ways that you can identify information, both to inform your moral preferences, but also to avoid reaffirming them.

- 3.88** This was an article in The Washington Post a couple of years ago. This is a professional journalist who said, "I have a secret. I kept it hidden for longer than I care to admit. It felt unprofessional, vaguely shameful. It wasn't who I wanted to be." Again, this is a professional journalist who says, "But here it is. I've been actively avoiding the news for years. But half a dozen years ago, something changed. The news started to get under my skin. After my morning reading, I felt so drained that I couldn't write or do anything creative. I'd listen to Morning Edition and feel lethargic, unmotivated, and the day had barely begun. Then one day, a journalist friend confided that she was avoiding the news, too. Then I heard it from another journalist, and another. If so many of us feel poisoned by our products, might there be something wrong with them?"
- 3.89** Even journalists are avoiding the news because they know it will activate these emotional feelings. It can affect your psychology, how you feel about yourself, about the world. What this journalist is doing, and what a lot of other people do, is they're using reason to not look at the news, an effortful avoidance of material that might upset you. The other thing is, because I don't want to dismiss the importance of reason, reason as a result of maturity can also shape our moral intuitions. I want to show you a very interesting study. But first, I'll very briefly describe these two competing notions of what constitutes a moral act.
- 3.90** So there's one view associated more with Aristotle, who suggested that you should only receive moral credit for an act if it came effortlessly to you. You have the choice to do something right. You do it without thinking. You're not even tempted to do anything else. That's what a moral person looks like. Someone who does the right thing, doesn't think about it, doesn't have to deliberate. It's not difficult for them. It's easy, it's effortless. That's a moral person.
- 3.91** Then, you have this other view associated with the German philosopher Immanuel Kant, who argued the opposite. He says that you only get credit if it's hard. If you're tempted to do something else, but you do the right thing anyway, then you deserve more credit. That's what a moral person looks like. It only counts if it's hard. How many of you agree with Aristotle that you should get more credit if it's easy, if you do it effortlessly? OK. None of you. OK. How many of you agree with Kant, that it counts more when it's hard? All right. How many of you aren't sure? No. OK. All right, a couple that aren't sure. All right.
- 3.92** So they presented this study, these researchers, to young children. These are preschool-aged children, and they showed them different scenarios. In one scenario, there's a boy. He's playing with his ball in the living room. He's kicking it around. He shouldn't be doing this. It's against the rules. But he kicks the ball around, and then he

knocks over a lamp, and it shatters. Then, the boy's mom comes in and says, "What happened here?"

- 3.93** One set of participants were told that, describing the boy's inner monologue and thought process, this condition, the boy's thinking, he immediately tells the truth. He's a goody two-shoes. He says, "Yeah, sorry, I played with the ball. I shouldn't have done it. I was kicking it around, and I broke the lamp. I'm sorry." Then children were asked, "How good is this boy? How much moral credit does he deserve?"
- 3.94** Then, in a different condition, it's the same exact scenario. The boy is kicking the ball around, he breaks the lamp, the mom comes in and asks what happened. In this scenario, the boy, his inner monologue is described as he's struggling, he doesn't want to get into trouble. He could lie. He could say something else. But then, he eventually decides to come clean and tell the truth. There's this inner struggle, this inner drama. But finally, he comes clean. Again, how much credit does this boy deserve?
- 3.95** They presented various scenarios like this to preschool-aged children, but also to adults as well. The finding here is that children are more like Aristotle. They gave more credit to the boy who effortlessly told the truth and didn't even think about lying, whereas adults were the opposite. Adults were more like Kant. Adults thought the boy who struggled to tell the truth, but did it anyway, gets more credit here.
- 3.96** In this sense, I think reason can shape our moral intuitions, because what's most likely going on here is that kids don't have much experience with temptation. They're naive, they're immature, they're undeveloped. It sounds nice maybe to someone who hasn't had much exposure to temptation and to the world to think, "Oh, just doing the right thing without thinking, that's very nice."
- 3.97** But as you get older and you experience more of life, more options to do the easy thing, the expedient thing, rather than the hard and difficult thing, even if you know that hard and difficult thing is right, over time, our intuitions can mature, and then we make this interesting transition from this Aristotelian view of morality more to a Kantian view, where you get more credit when it's hard and you do it anyway. With age and maturity, we start to apply reason, develop our moral judgments a bit more.
- 3.98** There have been some critiques of moral foundations theory. One critique, and I mentioned this at the start, that the science on moral psychology is not settled. Moral foundations theory has many proponents. It has a lot of supporters, but there are also some critics as well. One critique is that this began as a top-down theoretical model, where essentially people thought very deeply, read a bunch of papers, and said, "Oh, what are the foundations? Harm, care, seems to be one, maybe fairness." I'm oversimplifying this, but this is essentially what happened.
- 3.99** It was conceived of, this top-down model, informed by evolutionary, psychological, and anthropological reasoning. But if you read a bunch of papers and ethnographies and consult other experts, and then you list five things, and then afterwards, you test it with

surveys and statistical techniques, that's not always the best way to identify whether there are five different dimensions to a particular framework.

- 3.100** Personality actually seems to have been discovered in the opposite way, where those five personality traits were discovered. One way was through lexical analysis, where personality psychologists consulted dictionaries, and then spoke with people, and had them list out adjectives for how they would describe themselves and others. Then, through this brute-force empiricism, took all of these adjectives and, through sophisticated statistical techniques, saw that they started to cluster into five different categories.
- 3.101** Moral foundations almost began in the opposite way, where they listed in advance five possible foundations, and then ran a series of statistical techniques. There have been some critiques for how these foundations have been advanced.
- 3.102** The other critique is that there seem to be—the scenarios are weird. You're relying on these very strange stories that you seldom encounter in real life. They're pushing the boundary of what you could possibly imagine other people doing. It relies on these odd researcher-invented cases, these bizarre taboos, eating a pepperoni pizza off of a dead body in a morgue, the incest taboo, all those things. They don't necessarily reflect real-life moral transgressions that we see in everyday life.
- 3.103** Then, finally, these foundations are defined somewhat loosely. And so, the critique here is that maybe moral foundations theory is hard to test or to falsify, where, if you give me any kind of moral transgression you can think of, I could probably find a way to squeeze it into one of the five categories, even if it doesn't neatly do so.
- 3.104** For example, one critique is that the five foundations seem to not include wastefulness. Some cultures consider wastefulness to be a moral transgression. But then, which of these five foundations would it fall under? Maybe you can squeeze it into fairness if you make a bit of an effort, but does that really make sense? There are limits to this framework, but there are many strengths as well.
- 3.105** One is that it's an integrative framework. It draws from a lot of different studies. Often, you'll find that academic disciplines are siloed. Psychologists only talk to psychologists, anthropologists only talk to anthropologists, and so on. But with moral foundations theory, it unites various different disciplines. It also helps to understand political divides, once you understand that conservatives value the binding foundations more so than liberals do, that maybe this can help to explain why they talk past each other in debates.
- 3.106** Also, it has generated some cross-cultural research. It shows that morality isn't just about harm and fairness. It's not just about the ethic of autonomy, which, for a long time, a lot of Western philosophers and psychologists suggested, and that these other foundations also matter: loyalty, authority, and purity. It's a generative theory as well. It's inspired many hundreds of studies, experiments, debates, and it's a landmark

contribution, even if it has its flaws. I like this quote here from the statistician George Box. "All models are wrong, but some are useful."

- 3.107** We're going to transition here into a competing framework called moral dyad theory. Moral dyad theory was developed by Kurt Gray and his colleagues. He's written two popular trade books explaining this idea, as well as many, many different peer-reviewed papers. Moral dyad theory suggests that you can forget about the five, or rather, four of the five foundations, that these aren't real. The only thing that matters is care or harm. That's what informs our judgments of morality.
- 3.108** We see a morality, and then we believe that someone has suffered as a result, and then we come to the conclusion that something wrong has happened here. Gray and his coauthors write that "harm is not simply something that is bad or immoral, but involves the perception of an intentional agent and a suffering patient." I know that it's kind of jargony here. I don't really like that. In psychology papers, you'll see this phrase "agent" a lot. An agent just means an individual or a person.
- 3.109** I remember I was a research assistant years ago as an undergrad, and I overheard one of the graduate students talking to—it was a child psychology lab. The grad student was talking to one of the parents, and the parents were like, "Oh, what's this study about?" The grad student said, "Oh, we're looking at how children evaluate agents who are involved in misconduct." I thought, you can just say it's about children evaluating bad things or bad people or something like that, but "agents involved in misconduct."
- 3.110** And so, in this case, an intentional agent is a person who's doing something knowingly. Then suffering patient here means a victim, the recipient of those immoral acts. You have the intentional agent doing something to a suffering patient. And if that is occurring, then we believe there is harm that has taken place, and then we deem that bad or immoral. We see something is wrong if there's a victim, and then we see harm when there's a perpetrator.
- 3.111** This is why it's called the moral dyad theory; you need to have both roles in place. If we believe that something wrong has occurred, and there's not an obvious victim, people will still cite one, and we'll get into that. This idea of harmless wrongs, some people would say, smoking marijuana is a victimless crime. Something like masturbation, a victimless crime. But a lot of people have moral reservations about smoking marijuana or about masturbation.
- 3.112** Then, when you ask people who have those objections, they will say things like, "Well, the person's harming himself or herself, or they're harming society in some way." Maybe there are some second-hand downstream consequences. This idea of the harmless wrong, Kurt Gray and other proponents of moral dyad theory say that there's no such thing. If there is a wrong, people will infer that some kind of harm has taken place, and that's the root of our moral judgments.

- 3.113** Recall some of those scenarios from moral foundations theory. Researchers would explicitly tell participants, "No one's harmed, no one's hurt," particularly with the sibling incest case. It was Mark and Julie, there's birth control, there's this, that, and the other. People would still say, "But it's still wrong, it's still wrong." They still continue to perceive harm, even if you explicitly state that no one was harmed. Gray and his colleagues are skeptical of this.
- 3.114** You could think of an analogy to something like drunk driving. I could say, imagine a guy who every day drives to the bar, gets drunk, blasted out of his mind, and then drives home, but no one was hurt. Was this OK? Almost everyone would say no, but no one was hurt. You still know that it's wrong. You still think that it's wrong. The intuition remains, even if I explicitly tell you repeatedly that no one was hurt.
- 3.115** People seem to think that the potential for harm remains; that, OK, in this one narrow, specific case, no one was harmed by drinking and driving, but the act is wrong, and that if a lot of people did this, that obviously harm would eventually result. Same thing for something like incest. Maybe in this specific case, no one was harmed, but if this practice became common, then the potential for harm could possibly arise.
- 3.116** And so, this question of: Do harmless wrongs exist? Remember, we had these various violations, sex with a corpse or kicking a dog, swerving to run over a squirrel. In this particular study, they were testing whether people perceived harm, even in cases that did not involve care or harm. They looked at purity violations, but they also looked at those harmful actions as well.
- 3.117** But what they wanted to do was to see: Do people perceive harm when there is a violation of purity, having sex with a corpse or using a stranger's toothbrush, that kind of thing? Do people think that harm has taken place? Then do people perceive the presence of a victim in these cases? Now, it's clear enough that we would see this with cases of harm. If I ask you, is it wrong to kick a dog? Was there a victim? There would be a consensus that something wrong has taken place and that harm has taken place here, with the kicking of a dog.
- 3.118** The purity violations are less clear. Is there a victim or is there not a victim? They presented these scenarios to people and just straight up asked them, how wrong is this? And then, is there the presence of a victim? People overwhelmingly thought that even purity violations were immoral and then also harmful, even when told explicitly that no one was hurt. They still seemed to identify a victim for these acts.
- 3.119** Sometimes they would name abstract victims. They would say, well, maybe the person isn't harmed, but it's bad for society, or it's bad for the community, or it's bad for themselves. It's bad, or inflicts harm or suffering on God. Moral condemnation was tightly linked to this perception of a victim. The idea here is that harmless wrongs don't really seem to be perceived as harmless to most people, and that people seem to intuitively complete this moral dyad by citing some victim.

- 3.120** So even if someone is doing something, the scenario of the man who cuts up the flag and cleans his toilet, no one is immediately harmed. But then, when you pose this question to people and ask, "Is there a victim?", people still seem to cite things like the person's fellow citizens or the country or to the community or even the person's own self, that this could be damaging in some way. And so this is the moral dyad. It requires a victim. It requires a perpetrator.
- 3.121** People consistently perceive that something wrong has taken place if there is a perpetrator who has done something wrong, or if there is a victim who suffers. In both cases, interestingly, people have this motivation to complete this moral dyad. If one half of the dyad is missing, people will complete it by—inventing is the wrong word, but consulting their intuitions to find a reasonable explanation for why this is harmful, they'll complete it.
- 3.122** You can imagine there's a victim, for example. Many people would see someone who lives on the street as a victim. Then, if they believe that this is immoral, that someone is living on the street, they would fulfill it by completing the other half of the dyad. So you have the victim on the street. Well, who's the perpetrator? Then again, it would be something like maybe society or the government or other people, or maybe the person themselves is both a victim and perpetrator.
- 3.123** And so, these judgments of immorality are strongly linked to perceptions of harm of an intentional perpetrator and a suffering victim. Even in cases of purity or these weird taboo cases, people still seem to intuit that these are really about harm. We will close this one here.
- 3.124** For the next lecture, we're going to be talking about differences between blame and punishment. We're going to continue our discussion of moral typecasting, as well as evil and cruelty. We have just a few minutes. Maybe we could do a couple of questions. What are your questions? I know yesterday we didn't get to everyone. We'll start here. Yeah, in the middle, and then the guy next to him.
- 3.125** I noticed that, with liberals, there was sometimes an inaccurate understanding of conservatives. I think also, with liberals, sometimes they have an inaccurate understanding of minorities or other people that they share the luxury beliefs that they have, whereas African Americans may not want to defund the police or so on. So I'm just curious if there's been any studies into what could help puncture those inaccurate beliefs and correct the inaccuracies.
- 3.126** Oh, yeah. Well, that, I mean, if someone discovered the answer to that, they would be a very rich individual. This has been a perennial question, of questions around persuasion, of how people arrive at their beliefs. I touched on one in a previous session of stories versus facts. For better or worse, people are more swayed by stories. There was a news story, I think in 2022, 2023, multiple stories of individuals being attacked or killed. There was a tech executive in San Francisco who was stabbed on the street.

There were journalists in Philadelphia and another one in New York. They were murdered by street crime.

- 3.127** And so, those stories seemed to get a lot more people to pay attention to some of the policies around reducing funding for law enforcement and that kind of thing. And then you did see, after 2023, there has been this slight dip in violent crime, and I think as a result of those very high-profile cases. You had plenty of statistics up until that point, measuring the rise in violent crime from 2020 to 2022. But it wasn't, I think, until people saw these very vivid illustrations of what can go wrong, particularly for college-educated, white-collar people are also being affected by crime, and then people began to take it more seriously. All right, next question here.
- 3.128** You mentioned that there are not cultural food taboos in the West so much, and as well as the lack of wastefulness in personality trait. I'm wondering if you might elaborate on that.
- 3.129** Sure. I don't want to give the impression that there are no food taboos, but in Western countries. They exist, but they're less pronounced relative to more traditional, non-WEIRD societies. But you'll see taboos around what you should eat on Friday, or whether your food is locally sourced or whether you're a vegan or a vegetarian. There are these subcommunities in Western countries. There's a discussion around factory farming and that kind of thing. So people do still seem to hold these moralizing attitudes around food, but it's less intense, or less rigid, rather than in non-WEIRD countries.
- 3.130** Then, the other question was about wastefulness. This is a proposed foundation or moral intuition that people have, that if you are wasteful, if you have resources, but you're not allocating them properly, or if you're using them inappropriately, or there are people around you maybe who could use them and you choose not to help them, and then to burn those resources in some other way instead, that this can activate feelings of anger.
- 3.131** And so, in the context of a pre-industrialized small-scale society, people would have intense feelings of, if someone were to come upon a bush full of berries or something, and then they just started smashing them and not allowing people to access it, this would activate feelings of wastefulness and moral outrage. It's not entirely clear what exactly is going on there. If you try to fit it into one of the five foundations, maybe care would be the one that that would fit the most into, but it's not especially straightforward.
- 3.132** Under the moral dyad theory, people would say that it is a form of harm. People are intuiting that there's a victim. People are unable to access that food resource, and therefore it's wrong. We'll get into this more later, but there's this ongoing discussion, the blurry boundaries between what's right, what's wrong, each of the five

foundations. But ultimately, people will be encouraged to form their own conclusions about which framework they agree with. So we will leave it there.

Lecture 4: Judging Harm

At a glance — Judging harm.

- 4.1 All right. In our last lecture, we spoke about moral dyad theory. We're going to continue to build on that during this discussion, and then we'll move on to a discussion of evil and cruelty. But I first want to talk about what psychology can tell us about blame and punishment, and how we have different intuitions about these two expressions of moral disapproval.
- 4.2 Imagine a scenario where there's a man named John, and he puts what he believes is sugar, but is actually rat poison, in his friend's coffee. So it was an honest-to-God mistake. But then his friend dies. How much blame does John deserve? How much punishment does John deserve? Now, in this case, when you present scenarios like this to research participants, they tend to say that John doesn't really deserve much blame. It was an honest-to-God mistake. He didn't mean to do this, but someone is dead, and he is directly causally responsible for that death. So maybe he does deserve some kind of penalty, some kind of punishment. Those are the questions. How much blame? How much punishment?
- 4.3 Now, imagine an alternative scenario where this John believes he has some rat poison, and he's going to put it in his friend's drink, but he accidentally puts sugar in instead. He intends to kill his friend, but he puts sugar, which he believes is rat poison, in the friend's drink. The friend is unharmed. How much blame does this John deserve? How much should he be condemned for what he did here? How much punishment does this John deserve? He attempted to kill his friend, but he was unsuccessful. Should he be punished in some way?
- 4.4 In this scenario, and scenarios like it, people have the reverse intuition, where this John, who attempts harm but fails, deserves a lot of blame. He should be condemned. We should rightfully express outrage at what he has done. But does he deserve any formal punishment or sanctioning? Should he go to prison? Should he be penalized in some formal way? In this case, people seem to have much weaker intuitions about this.
- 4.5 In other words, if you accidentally cause harm to someone, people still think that you should be punished in some way, because there's someone who is harmed, even if it was a mistake, and even if you are, in some sense, blameless. But if you intend to cause harm, but you fail, in this case, people seem to believe that you deserve a lot of blame and condemnation, we should rightfully express outrage at you. But as far as a formal penalty, people are much more uncertain about this.
- 4.6 This is sometimes called the two-process theory of moral judgment, that we have these differing intuitions about blame and condemnation, expressions of outrage versus formal penalties and punishment. You have these two distinct processes. We track the mental states. Did you intend to do this? Did you not intend to do this? That's one

component of moral judgment. But then, causal responsibility: What is the outcome here? Was someone harmed? Was someone not harmed? Did you mean to do this? Did you not mean to do this?

- 4.7 And so, if someone intends to commit the transgression, regardless of how much harm is actually caused, we'll issue blame, but less punishment. In contrast, if someone is directly responsible for an immoral outcome, even if they didn't mean to do it, regardless of intent, we still think that the person should be punished, even if they are, in some sense, blameless.
- 4.8 This two-process theory, some psychologists have suggested that this underlies the legal distinction between murder versus manslaughter, for instance; that if you're driving on the road and you accidentally hit a pedestrian, it was a mistake, but someone is dead. People still think that you should be on the hook in some sense for this, even if you didn't mean to, even if it was a total accident. In contrast, if you're zooming along the road and you see someone you want to kill and you swerve, but you miss and hit a tree instead, people would think, "Well, you're a bad person." They'll express anger at you. But should you go to jail for this? Maybe not.
- 4.9 This is a really interesting study here, also related to this idea of our intuitions around blame and punishment. A man is driving home and he hits an oil slick, he loses control of his car, and crashes into a pedestrian. The reason the man was driving home is because he knows his parents are heading to his house, and he wants to hide their anniversary gift, so they don't see it. He's driving home, there's the oil slick, he crashes into someone, he hits them.
- 4.10 How much blame does this man deserve for crashing into this pedestrian? How much punishment does this man deserve? In this case, people tend to say, "Well, there was the oil slick. Maybe it wasn't so bad. He should be blamed in some way. It was an accident." But with punishment, also tend to have relatively weak intuitions, but they still think that there should be some formal penalty in this sense.
- 4.11 Now, there's a different scenario. A man drives home, he hits an oil slick, loses control of his car, he crashes into the pedestrian. The actions are the same. But the reason the man was driving home is because he knows his parents are headed to his house and he wants to hide the cocaine he illegally possesses, so that they don't see it. Again, the actions and the outcome are the same, but the reason why he's driving home is very different in this case. What you see here is that people have different responses to this, that people are more willing to issue both blame and punishment, both because of what he did, but also the reason behind it.
- 4.12 This suggests that our intuitions about blame and punishment are informed not just by intentions and outcomes, but also by our knowledge of the person's moral character. If someone mistakenly caused harm while they were in the process of doing something good, then we tend to have more subdued judgments about that person. But if they're

doing something bad, and then they have this horrible side effect as a result of their actions, we have much stronger feelings that this person should be condemned and punished. We'll talk a little bit more about this later, in a future session.

- 4.13 Character matters. In addition to intentions and outcomes, people also tend to assign more blame and punishment when a person's intentions are immoral compared to when the intentions were moral, even if the bad outcome was exactly the same, unintentional, identical in both scenarios. So generally, these two things are intertwined, though. If you feel like someone has done something wrong, you issue some blame; you also think they should be punished.
- 4.14 But researchers have neatly identified that there's something going on here for both of these cases, where if someone intends to do something wrong and they fail, versus if they don't intend to do something wrong, but then they still do something wrong anyway, then you get these conflicting responses. In addition to that, we also see that moral judgment is influenced by knowledge of moral character as well.
- 4.15 You also see the black sheep effect with regard to moral blame with condemnation. This is an interesting finding. It's disputed, but there have been enough studies suggesting that it exists, which is that, when guilt is unclear, so someone has done something, we don't really know how much responsibility they hold for this moral transgression, there's some uncertainty around it.
- 4.16 People are less willing to punish their in-group member, relative to an out-group member. So it looks like something went wrong here. We're not entirely sure. If it's an ally of yours, you want to give them the benefit of the doubt. But if it's someone in the out-group, maybe a political adversary, something along those lines, if it's uncertain, we still respond by thinking, "Well, you did something wrong." We have this motivated reasoning to condemn them.
- 4.17 But when there's no uncertainty, when it's clear that someone has done something wrong, the pattern flips, and people will often punish their in-group members, their allies, more harshly than the out-group members. The groups punish their own members more severely when the guilt is clear. Some have suggested that this is the reason why apostates are often treated more harshly than nonbelievers, for example. People who leave a group are despised more than people who were never part of the group in the first place.
- 4.18 So we're going to return here to a discussion of the moral dyad. Recall that the moral dyad requires a perpetrator and a victim. If we intuit that something has gone wrong, but you only have one half of the dyad, you see a victim suffering, and it's unclear who the perpetrator is, we will fulfill that mental template by blaming an individual, society, some abstraction. If you see someone who seems to be doing something wrong— a victimless crime, in some sense—we still will intuit that someone is suffering as a result of this transgression.

- 4.19 And again, judgments of immorality are linked to perceptions of harm. Even for cases where no one is apparently harmed, people will still sense that someone is suffering as a result of that immoral act. Even in these weird taboo cases around purity, where it's just one individual who's doing something, we still believe that someone might be harmed, whether it's the individual themselves or society.
- 4.20 Related to this idea of the moral dyad theory is moral typecasting. Recall that, in Hollywood, the typecasting idea is that an actor plays a role, and then they get stuck playing that same role. Back in the day, Matthew McConaughey was typecast into the romantic comedy lead. Jessica Alba played the hot girl role. I guess Sydney Sweeney plays that role today. You get typecast into that role. But moral typecasting is about how we assign moral roles to groups of people.
- 4.21 The idea here is that people are seen, depending on the group that they belong to, as either natural agents, thinking doers, powerful, responsible for causing harm, capable of harm, highly competent, and then other groups are seen as natural patients, natural sufferers. They're vulnerable, they are innocent, they're easily harmed. People seem to categorize groups in this way, and we'll see some specific examples.
- 4.22 What's an example of a moral agent, a thinking doer? Highly competent, good at planning, control, communication, rational, strategic. They're seen as powerful. They have more effect on others than others have on them. An example would be a successful CEO. We think of them as thinking doers. You could think of—an android might be the purest distilled form of this, someone who's highly efficient, rational, capable. Maybe something like Spock or Data in the Star Trek universe, someone who's relatively unfeeling but highly competent and capable, but not very emotional. We think of that as a moral agent. In the moral dyad, we tend to think of that person more so as capable of perpetrating harms than being the victim of harms.
- 4.23 Then we have moral patients, the other side of the moral typecasting idea, vulnerable feelers. Moral patients are emotional, they're sensitive, they're reactive to pain, to fear, but also to pleasure as well. They feel very deeply, and they're seen as easy to hurt, as vulnerable, as in need of protection. An example of this would be something like a newborn baby or a small animal—highly emotional, but not particularly skilled and not particularly capable, full of emotions, but incapable of strategic planning, deliberation, calculation, and so on.
- 4.24 Almost the opposite of that highly competent CEO. We see the CEO as able to think and plan, but relatively unfeeling, and then the baby as having these deep emotions but unable to plan or to strategize. There's this related idea of competence versus warmth in social psychology, where psychologists will break down people's attributes into these two categories. You have warmth, which is how friendly, how kind, how well intentioned someone seems. An example would be something like a caring nurse or a helpful neighbor, a nurturing grandmother.

- 4.25 You have warmth, and then there's competence, how capable and skilled and effective someone appears to be. An example here, a talented scientist or a CEO, a physician, something like that, where they have these unique skills. But what's interesting here is that, in the research on warmth and competence, the more we see someone as warm, the less we tend to view them as competent, and the more we view someone as competent, the less we tend to attribute to them warmth.
- 4.26 As a result of this, people who are highly successful in a conventional sense are often seen as emotionally cold. Again, you can think of the successful CEO, you could think of the talented scientist, you can think of the accomplished surgeon or physician. We don't tend to think of them as particularly emotional people. We tend to think of them as these effective, highly competent individuals.
- 4.27 In contrast, if you view someone as warm, often we will, at least at first glance, view them as relatively less competent. Again, someone like a caring nurse or a nurturing grandmother, we can think of them as very friendly, as having very high regard for others, very nurturing, but we will often fail to attribute to them competence, even when they are.
- 4.28 Imagine that you have to divide three different pain pills, or three different pills to three different individuals. These are three different pills, three different people, and you have to allocate one pill to each of these three individuals. The one pill is a sugar pill. It's a placebo. It causes no pain. You have another pill that causes a moderate amount of pain if you ingest it. Then, you have a third pill that causes intense pain for the person who ingests it, and you're responsible for distributing these three pills to three individuals.
- 4.29 The three individuals—you have an ordinary bank teller, Gandhi, and a small child. I would imagine most of you, maybe not all of you, would give the sugar pill to the small child. The interesting question here is: Who gets the intense pain pill, the ordinary bank teller or Gandhi, the anti-colonialist civil rights icon? So who says that the intense pain pill goes to the ordinary bank teller? OK, we got one. Who says that the intense pain pill should go to Gandhi? Almost everyone. OK.
- 4.30 This was a simplified scenario of a study that actually took place, sometimes referred to as the pain pill study. In the actual study, you had one pill that caused mild discomfort, two that caused intense but temporary pain. These participants had to divide these three pills between Ted Bundy, the ordinary bank teller, Mother Teresa, and an orphan child. The number of pills matched the number of people.
- 4.31 So, unsurprisingly, you had one pill, which gives mild discomfort. When forced to choose, people give the orphan child the pill that caused the least amount of pain. They gave one of the intense pain pills to Ted Bundy. Also makes sense. But then the key test was the bank teller versus Mother Teresa. Do you give less pain to the nun, or do you

give less pain to the bank teller? Similar to the result we just saw in class, people allocated the intense pain pill not to the bank teller, but to Mother Teresa.

- 4.32 The reasoning seemed to be, when you asked participants why, they said, "Well, because she seems strong, she can handle it. She was highly competent, highly capable, highly agentic." They viewed her more as a thinking doer than a vulnerable feeler, the same way I would imagine many of you thought of Gandhi, someone who could handle the pain better than an ordinary person. And so, we typecast Gandhi and Mother Teresa and other individuals like this as agentic and highly competent, but also we seem to attribute to them a reduced ability to suffer from emotional pain, physical pain.
- 4.33 There was a similar study along these lines where participants were told a story about the leader of an employee walkout. They were protesting something at their organization. The leader of the walkout gets up, and someone spills hot coffee on this person. Then they were asked, "How much pain did this leader of this walkout feel?"
- 4.34 Then, they told people a scenario in which one of the followers of the employee walkout—so there's a leader who gets up, someone else follows, and then others follow as well and get up and walk out. Well, one of the followers spills coffee. The question here is: Who did participants of this study, who did they say felt more pain? The leader who spilled coffee on themselves or one of the followers who spilled coffee on themselves? People overwhelmingly said that the follower would experience more pain. The leader would experience less pain. Again, the idea here is that you have this thinking doer, this agentic individual. Maybe they felt some pain, but they're clearly competent.
- 4.35 As a result of this, we attribute to them less warmth, less capacity for feeling suffering and pain, whereas someone who is a follower, it seems to be the reverse, where we are more apt to attribute to them the capacity for suffering. This research is fascinating, in part because you see that there are political differences in the assumption of vulnerability, of who is capable of suffering, who is capable of experiencing pain, who is typecast into these different roles.
- 4.36 For obvious cases, like babies, regardless of your political orientation, people consider babies to be vulnerable feelers. Intense capacity for suffering and for emotion and pain, very limited capacity for competence. We typecast them into the suffering role, the victim role, incapable of being perpetrators. Most people see CEOs as thinking doers. They are capable of perpetrating harm, less likely to be the victims of harm, less capacity to experience pain and suffering.
- 4.37 But then, there are these interesting cases where liberals and conservatives disagree about who is especially vulnerable to victimization. Again, we have the obvious cases—robots, CEOs, babies, small animals. But then, for more politically contentious topics, you'll see that there are fundamental disagreements here. I'm going to quote Kurt Gray

from his book, *Outraged*. So, again, Kurt Gray is one of the pioneers of moral dyad theory.

- 4.38 He says, "The liberal tendency to amplify differences in vulnerability explains why they often divide the historical and modern world into oppressors (very invulnerable, powerful people) and oppressed (very vulnerable, othered people). The left-leaning amplification of assumptions of vulnerability differences can be seen when Karl Marx describes society as a struggle between the exploited proletariat and the exploiting ruling class."
- 4.39 There are examples of this. Liberals, for example, see police officers as powerful doers, highly agentic, highly competent, not warm, relatively unfeeling, not especially vulnerable or sensitive to pain. But they tend to view criminals in the reverse way, where criminals are vulnerable victims of society and therefore have an exquisite capacity to experience pain and suffering. But as a result of whatever misfortunes they may have experienced in their lives, as a result of society, they are incapable of being truly responsible for their actions. They are relatively less competent, but have a high capacity for feeling. That's the kind of liberal view.
- 4.40 The conservative view is that both cops and criminals have the capacity for both. They have similar judgments of the warmth and competence of both, the capacity for thinking, the capacity for feeling. For liberals, police are thinking doers, criminals are vulnerable feelers, whereas conservatives tend to view both as sharing these capacities to a similar extent. They can think and they can feel and they can suffer in similar ways.
- 4.41 So, in the minds of liberals, you'll see, particularly in the U.S., certain groups are more likely to be vulnerable feelers. As a result of this, liberals will often accuse conservatives of denying social inequalities, being ignorant of history, of misunderstanding that there have been othered and marginalized groups, and they accuse conservatives of flattening these very obvious differences.
- 4.42 Whereas for conservatives, they tend to believe that people have similar capacity for suffering. As a result of this, conservatives will accuse liberals of exaggerating the victimhood of others, of overstating the case, and that actually perhaps the best thing to do would be to treat everyone equally because everyone is capable of being both a perpetrator and a victim.
- 4.43 Some years ago, there was a really amusing study. I think this is the last time we're going to go over a trolley problem. But in this case, the participants faced this trolley-style choice. The stakes were raised. You could push one individual, one man, to save 100 others. These scenarios were different, two different cases. In one condition, participants—and these are the actual names that they gave these people in this story—so you could push Chip Ellsworth III, a white guy, off the bridge to save 100 Black jazz musicians. Then the question is, do you push? Do you not push?

- 4.44 Version two, you could push Tyrone Payton, a black individual, to save 100 white orchestra members. The question here is, do you push him? Do you not push him? One life versus 100 lives. What the researchers found is that there was a political difference here, where liberals were willing to sacrifice Chip Ellsworth to save 100 African American lives, but liberals were unwilling to sacrifice Tyrone Payton to save 100 white orchestra members.
- 4.45 In other words, liberals were willing to sacrifice the life of a white person to save 100 Black individuals, but they were unwilling to sacrifice the life of one Black individual to save 100 white individuals. Conservatives showed no bias in either scenario. Conservatives were equally likely to sacrifice Chip or Tyrone to save 100 lives. Race did not play a role in their choice of whether to sacrifice an individual.
- 4.46 There's another study along these lines of assumptions of competence. In this study, some researchers out of Princeton discovered both through measuring the linguistic complexity and speech patterns of politicians, as well as the speech patterns in everyday conversation, they found that white Democrats, when speaking with minority audiences, largely non-white audience members, versus white audiences, that white democratic politicians tended to simplify their speech when speaking with a largely non-white audience, compared with a white audience.
- 4.47 Whereas white Republican politicians spoke the same way in either case. They spoke to non-white audiences and white audiences at the same level of linguistic complexity. Then, in everyday conversations, white liberals shifted their speech when they were speaking with non-white conversational partners versus white conversational partners, again, simplifying their speech. Whereas white Conservatives spoke the same way regardless of who their conversational partner was.
- 4.48 The researchers here, in an interview with them, said that, speaking about white liberals, white Democrats in particular, that even if it's ultimately well intentioned, it can be seen as patronizing. The reason why, in the trolley problem case, white liberals were willing to sacrifice a white life but not a Black life, and in this study, they speak differently to non-white versus white individuals, is because they have a morally typecast white versus non-white individuals, where, in the liberal view, whites are thinking doers and non-white individuals are vulnerable feelers.
- 4.49 Therefore, it is appropriate to change how you treat them, how you behave around them, because they fall under these two categories. Whereas, again, conservatives in general tend to view everyone as equally capable of being competent, of capacity for suffering, and so forth. So they're more even-handed in these studies. I mentioned this, white liberals tend to simplify their language when talking to ethnic minorities. Democratic politicians use fewer complex words in speeches to minority audiences. Republicans show no such change.

- 4.50 This is a key point of dispute between liberals and conservatives. Who is uniquely vulnerable to suffering, where you see that more left-leaning individuals view ethnic minorities, immigrants, women, and other historically mistreated groups as vulnerable feelers more so than thinking doers. Whereas conservatives tend to see everyone as having the capacity for both competence and agency, as well as the capacity for feeling, for vulnerability, for suffering. I think this helps us to understand, to some extent, the polarization here, that both sides are going at this with fundamentally different assumptions about who can suffer and who can't.
- 4.51 This is a very spicy title for an academic paper, but the idea here, this is a paper on what's sometimes called *infrahumanization*. *Infrahumanization* is about how dominant populations dehumanize othered and marginalized groups within those societies. What this study showed is that, in the U.S., the warmth and competence, these axes, people tend to view Asians as more machine-like: highly competent, efficient, strategic, capable of rational thought and reasoning, but relatively unfeeling, not a lot of emotional depth.
- 4.52 Whereas Blacks are viewed in the opposite way, where they are exquisitely capable of emotional feeling and depth, but less capable, less competent, less able to rationalize, or to apply reason and rationality. Here in the abstract, the researchers write that "whereas Black people are more often subjected to"—what they call here—"animalistic dehumanization, Asian people are predominantly subjected to mechanistic dehumanization."
- 4.53 And so, the animalistic component here is more associated with feeling and instinct and impulse and passion. The mechanistic dehumanization is, you're an android, you're a robot, you can do things, but you don't really feel anything. This categorization occurs not just for race, but for other social groups as well. You see this for perceptions of military veterans, where they are typecast in the same way as Asians, capable of strategic planning, but relatively less capable of suffering and of pain.
- 4.54 All of these, you have Asians, military veterans, but you can think of the archetypal example of the android or the CEO, highly competent, efficient, capable, but relatively unfeeling, incapable of experiencing suffering. You see this with moral typecasting and race. You have the mechanistic dehumanization, and then you have the animalistic dehumanization.
- 4.55 Generally, even in studies unrelated to morality, you'll see that participants tend to behave more altruistically towards women relative to men. This is true for both men and women. You bring people into a laboratory to play economic games to win money. You measure the level of cheating. If participants are able to cheat, you'll find that both men and women are more likely to cheat if their competitor is a male versus if their competitor is a female.

- 4.56 This difference is in part driven by the perception that women are vulnerable feelers, whereas men are thinking doers. They've been typecast into these roles, where we have this perception here, that men have this capacity for agentic thinking, and women are more so in tune with their emotions, more capable of suffering. Some scholars have suggested, though, that you have this warmth and competence.
- 4.57 Some social psychologists call this the big two in terms of social perception, that we categorize men as competent, and we categorize women as warm, and that gender itself is the foundation of social cognition; that because we're social cognitive creatures, especially in the ancestral environment, you saw that there were these strong sex roles as far as what people were responsible for, that this mirrors this long-standing sex role of, women were cast into these roles as nurturers and caregivers and so on, and men were cast into the roles of being providers, hunters, warriors, protectors, and that this lingers with us today, this viewpoint.
- 4.58 As I mentioned, women tend to be typecast as victims, men typecast as perpetrators. But what's interesting here about the moral typecasting idea is that, if you are cast into the role of the perpetrator, the transgressions you commit are seen as particularly egregious compared with if you are typecast into the vulnerable feeler victim role. As an example, wrongs committed by men against women are perceived as more wrongful than those by women against men, men against men, or women against women.
- 4.59 People have this uniquely intense feeling of outrage when a man perpetrates harm against a woman, than if a woman were to harm a woman, or if a man were to harm a man. You see something similar with, again, the typecasting around race. To take a very inflammatory example, if a large group of white individuals beat a Black person to death, there would probably be more outrage than if a group of Black individuals beat a white person to death. Although politically, things are changing, that seems to be how things have gone for the last several decades, these perceptions.
- 4.60 The same with gender as well, that you could imagine a scenario where a group of women beat a man to death. The response would be far more muted than if a group of men were to beat a woman to death. And so, we typecast people in these roles, women as patients, men as agents. When people are presented with scenarios, these stories, men who are harmed, victims of unfair treatment, of physical pain, "How much harm did this man experience?", people judge them as experiencing less harm than a woman in the same exact scenario.
- 4.61 Participants seem to believe that men are better able to handle the pain or the mistreatment better. Again, you can think of the example of something like Mother Teresa or Gandhi or something like that. They can just handle it better. They're more capable, they're more rational, based on these moral typecasting and these stereotypes and these perceptions, that people unconsciously think men can man up and take it, viewed as tougher, less prone to suffering, less deserving of sympathy relative to women.

- 4.62 And there are some strengths to this idea of moral dyad theory, moral typecasting. There is this elegant simplicity to it. It explains moral judgment through this basic pattern. There's harm, there's a perpetrator, there's a victim, and we close this template, and then we can understand moral judgments. It also aligns with our intuitions. So, if we naturally look for victims, we naturally look for villains. We have the perpetrator, we have the sufferer.
- 4.63 This seems to make sense to us on an intuitive level, how moral judgment works, that if someone were to get struck by lightning, someone has experienced some suffering, some misfortune, but we don't necessarily think something immoral took place. But then, in other cases, if someone has suffered a misfortune, and there does seem to be a way to find a perpetrator, we can fulfill that moral template; we can come to the conclusion that something wrongful has occurred.
- 4.64 We do see this across cultures, that harm perception is very specific. It has to involve an intentional doer. It has to involve a suffering victim. Of course, the disagreement is what constitutes harm. The other thing is that moral typecasting can help us to illuminate political divides. With moral foundations theory, the divide was explained through the endorsement of the moral foundations, where liberals view care and fairness as paramount, whereas conservatives view all five of those foundations as important.
- 4.65 That was the moral foundation's proposal for why liberals and conservatives differ in their moral worldview. Whereas for moral typecasting and moral dyad theory, the idea here is rather that, if harm is the root of morality, then we can vary in how much we attribute the capacity for suffering as a result of that harm. Some groups are more prone to suffering than others. As a result, if harm is inflicted on them, that is especially egregious and maybe requires some intervention. That's the view of liberals, whereas for conservatives, they tend to view everyone as equally capable of thinking, of feeling.
- 4.66 Those are some of the strengths of moral dyad theory, but there are some limitations as well. Some have proposed that, if we're going to boil every moral transgression down to harm, if everything is harm, then eventually nothing is harm. You're stretching it too far. You can fold anything into harm. You stretch it so broadly that you risk explaining everything. But then eventually, you're not really explaining anything at all, particularly some of the nuances of moral judgment, some of the intricacies. It risks flattening moral transgressions under this one simple idea.
- 4.67 Others have suggested it leans too much on WEIRD morality. So again, WEIRD societies, Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, Democratic societies, this ethic of autonomy, of the only thing that really matters is, was someone harmed? Did someone suffer? Then, if the answer is no, then it's OK. Some suggest that moral dyad theory is a recapitulation of that idea. You're boiling everything down to harm. Whereas it's clear that, in other societies, they care about other foundations beyond care. Even within WEIRD societies, you see these moral differences as well. If you're going to say

everything is harm, you're not really doing much to explain some of the moral differences between people.

4.68 The other thing is that sometimes suffering is not considered to be immoral. Sometimes it is perceived as the right thing to do. So if harm, if suffering, if that's the root of morality, then how do you explain cases where people feel that it's actually deeply moral to inflict harm and suffering, as in the case of cultural rites of passage, for example? In many societies, this requires, especially in modern hunter-gatherer societies, whippings, beatings, confrontations with violence, exposure, all these kinds of things.

4.69 But the community views this as a deeply moral rite of passage, that this is how you shepherd, particularly boys, into the passage into manhood. Even for things like modern Western societies, prisons, you take someone who's done something wrong, and then you make them suffer by putting them in prison. People consider this to be moral, rather than immoral. The immoral thing is to let them go free; the right thing to do is to actually penalize them in some way.

4.70 This also stands in opposition to this idea that harm is inherently wrong, that the root of morality is always going to be harm. This idea of harm and violence being moral in some cases was explored at length in this great book, *Virtuous Violence*. The authors are Alan Fiske, the anthropologist, and the psychologist Tage Rai. As I'd mentioned, they talk about cultural rites of passage, that, in this case, violence in this sort of controlled sense was considered to be moral.

4.71 Intergroup conflict. Sometimes people support warfare, and they think that engaging in war or intertribal skirmishes, that this is the right thing to do. I'd mentioned penalties for legal transgressions. It's not entirely clear that harm is always deemed wrong. This may even be true, interestingly, for the victims of harm. There are cases where sometimes people who are experiencing harm, they themselves don't consider it to be wrong. They view the pain and suffering as deserved or as earned.

4.72 In other cases, pain feels psychologically different depending on whether you interpret that pain as legitimate versus illegitimate or accidental. This was a study from Kurt Gray, actually, the pioneer of moral dyad theory. You can imagine that you're paired with another person who's actually an actor working for the experimenter, but you don't know this. You're told that this other person has control of this device that can deliver electric shocks to you. So there are three different possibilities here.

4.73 In one condition, you would be told that this other person delivered a shock, and they did it maliciously because they wanted to hurt you. They pressed the button on this device because they wanted to make you feel pain. In another condition, you're told that the shock was delivered unintentionally. There was a malfunction in the device, and it accidentally sent a shock to you. Then, in the third condition, you'd be told that the shocks were delivered benevolently because your partner is trying to help you win

lottery tickets. If they can deliver a certain number of shocks to you, spaced out in a certain sequence, you'll earn lottery tickets from this study.

- 4.74** After each shock, you would rate how painful it felt. As you might imagine, if you're told that these shocks are malicious—this person did this because they wanted to hurt you; they don't like you; they said something bad about you in the other experiment room, and they're like, "I'm going to get that person"—those hurt the most. The unintentional shocks hurt less. If you're told, "Oh, sorry, it was just a glitch in the device. There was a malfunction. It accidentally was a shock," people rate that as hurting less than the malicious shocks.
- 4.75** Then the benevolent shocks hurt least of all. If you're told that you're being shocked because this person is trying to help you earn rewards, earn lottery tickets, there's a positive explanation for this that will lead to some kind of benefit for you. Keep in mind here, the voltage is the same. It's precisely the same in all three conditions. You're receiving the same level of voltage in each shock, but the subjective perception of how painful they feel differs widely.
- 4.76** This also introduces some nuances in our perceptions of harm, that sometimes harm isn't considered to be immoral or unethical, as in this case here, if the pain is for what we believe to be a good reason. Physical sensations, to some extent, are shaped by the perceptions of intent. I really like these types of studies here, where the objective conditions are exactly the same, but our subjective report of those conditions can vary depending on what we believe about them.
- 4.77** There was a study years ago where they brought in participants into a room, and they had to solve a series of puzzles. But every few seconds, there would be a loud alarm that would go off in this room while they were trying to solve this problem. In one condition, the participants were warned, "Hey, there's this alarm that goes on every few seconds, and that's part of the study, so please try to keep yourself engaged in this task." Then they measured how long they kept at it and how many problems they solved while they were in the room.
- 4.78** In a different condition, they brought participants in, and they told them there would be a very loud, piercing alarm that would go off every few seconds. "We need you to solve as many of these tasks as possible. Look, if the alarm bothers you, there's a button by the desk. You can press it; the alarms will stop. We'd appreciate if you didn't, though, because we're trying to do something for the study."
- 4.79** Overwhelmingly, participants chose not to press the button when they were given the option, and they solved more of the tasks set before them. Again, the objective conditions are the same. In both cases, a piercing alarm. In one case, you are given this option of control. "You can turn that alarm off if you want, but we'd rather you didn't." In this case, people endured for a longer period of time and solved more problems in this study.

- 4.80 This book, *Virtuous Violence*, is very interesting. They have this idea that violence can regulate relationships. The core point of this book is that it's not the case that harm is the root of morality, but rather the way that you can explain morality is through hostile feelings, and violence and anger. A lot of those negative emotions, the reason that those exist is to regulate relationships, and in some instances, violence and hostility is necessary to respond to mistreatment. Hence, the title of the book that, in many cases, people don't think that violence is immoral, but rather they believe it to be deeply moral.
- 4.81 You can imagine all kinds of scenarios, the way that interpersonal conflicts can escalate. Often, it's because one party or the other or both believe that they have been wronged in some way. You see this with social groups. You see this at the level of warfare that, when people inflict violence on one another, it's usually not done out of this belief that "I'm going to do something immoral, I'm going to commit some violence." Rather, it's the opposite. It's, "This person wronged me. I need to correct this person. The right thing to do here is to inflict some cost on them."
- 4.82 But this isn't true for everyone across the board. You see this, particularly with individuals with narcissistic or psychopathic personality styles, because they tend to believe that they are entitled to good treatment, and they are often exquisitely sensitive to the belief that they've been mistreated in some way. People with narcissistic or psychopathic personality styles are particularly likely to use violence, whether it's direct physical violence or verbal violence or indirect aggression, to get others to do what they want.
- 4.83 We're going to transition now into a discussion of psychopaths. If you could imagine an intelligent psychopath, maybe Patrick Bateman from *American Psycho*, and this intelligent psychopath knows, intellectually, the difference between right and wrong. He knows that drowning an innocent child is wrong. He knows on an intellectual level that assaulting innocent people is wrong.
- 4.84 But he feels none of the associated emotions with it. The thought of drowning a child or assaulting an innocent person—he is unmoved by feelings of guilt, shame, empathy, compassion, very limited capacity for those emotions. This was essentially the attributes that were first identified in explorations and discussions of psychopathy.
- 4.85 *The Mask of Sanity* by Hervey Cleckley is generally considered to be the landmark text, the original, first pioneering work on psychopathic personalities. It was written in the 1940s by a psychiatrist, Hervey Cleckley. The title of the book essentially explains it all, where Cleckley noticed that some of his patients appeared on the surface to be very normal, well-adjusted, educated, urbane, interesting conversational partners.
- 4.86 But then over time, as he would get to learn about their social relationships and interactions with others, he came to realize that they didn't really have the full range of emotional experiences. They didn't really seem to experience empathy in the same

way. They seemed to have these emotional deficits. I should be clear here that, because psychopathy and psychosis are often conflated in pop culture, in part, there's this phrase "psycho." You see this or hear this in movies, TV shows, pop culture in general.

- 4.87** People use the phrase psycho to describe someone who's lost touch with reality, but also someone who is a murderous serial killer. When they use that phrase psycho in both of those ways, they're conflating these two conditions of psychopathy and psychosis. They're distinct conditions. Those psychopaths appear outwardly normal oftentimes, and they can skillfully manage how they present themselves to others. They know how they look to other people, and they attempt to manage it in order to appear normal in most cases.
- 4.88** Whereas people with psychosis, psychotic individuals, have lost their grip on reality. They struggle with thinking, with self-control, and they have no sense of how they appear to the outside world. They have difficulty managing their appearance and their behavior. So these are very different. We're focusing on psychopathy, not psychosis. So, a key difference: psychopathy is hidden. If you were to interact with someone who had psychopathy, you wouldn't necessarily know. But if you were interacting with someone in the throes of psychosis, it would be very apparent to you.
- 4.89** There are some qualitative interviews with psychopaths. This is an interview with a 13-year-old mugger from the book *The Social World of a Child*. This 13-year-old mugger robbed and murdered an elderly woman. When the police asked him why he did it, he said, "What do I care? I'm not her." Ted Bundy was puzzled. Ted Bundy, the serial killer, was puzzled about the reactions to the murders he committed. He said, "Why are people so upset? I mean, there's so many people."
- 4.90** Another serial killer, Gary Gilmore, who also met the criteria for psychopathy, he said, "I was always capable of murder. I can become totally devoid of feelings of others, unemotional." This is interesting here. He says, "I know I'm doing something grossly fucking wrong," so he knows it's wrong, but he can still go ahead and do it. He went on to describe the pleasure he felt. Despite knowing that it was wrong on an intellectual level, it was still emotionally pleasing to him to do it.
- 4.91** This is another interview here with Peter Woodcock, who was in a mental institution for murder. The interviewer asked, "What was going through your mind at the time? This was someone you loved." So he murdered someone at the mental institution that he was placed in for murdering someone else. Then Woodcock says, "Curiosity, actually. And an anger because he had rebuffed all my advances."
- 4.92** The interviewer says, "Why did you feel someone should die as a result of your curiosity?" Woodcock says, "I just wanted to know what it would feel like to kill someone." The interviewer says, "But you'd already killed three people." Woodcock

says, "Yes, but that was years and years and years ago." And so, you're getting a sense here that psychopaths have a different moral sense than non-psychopaths.

- 4.93** But sometimes people get this mistaken view of psychopathy from pop culture. I'd mentioned Patrick Bateman earlier, that psychopaths are kind of these masterminds, these criminal geniuses. But in fact, in empirical studies of people with psychopathy, they tend to be slightly less intelligent than average. They're not masterminds. They have difficulty reading the emotions of other people. They tend to be insensitive to particularly expressions of fear.
- 4.94** There was one interview with a murderer who met the criteria for psychopathy, and they showed him an image of a face expressing fear, and they asked, "What emotion is this?" He replied, "I don't know, but that's the look that people get right before I stab them." They have difficulty with impulse control, prone to pathological lying, absence of remorse or guilt. They have what's sometimes called blunted affect or shallow affect, profound indifference toward the suffering of other people.
- 4.95** There was a study recently that found that 1% of the population, they are prone to pathological lying. 1% of the population is responsible for 25% of the lies that are told overall. They didn't look at that 1% to test them for psychopathy specifically. But my guess is, if they were to take one of those scales, they would score very highly on psychopathy.
- 4.96** I'd mentioned this story, actually, in a previous lecture, how pre-industrialized societies handle psychopaths. Jane M. Murphy, an anthropologist at Harvard University, was speaking with these Inuits near the Bering Strait. She was doing this ethnographic report, this visit with them. She learned that this community "had a term, 'kunlangeta', they used to describe a man who repeatedly lies and cheats and steals things and takes sexual advantage of many women; someone who does not pay attention to reprimands and who is always being brought to the elders for punishment."
- 4.97** When Murphy asked an Inuit what the group would typically do with a "kunlangeta", one of these men, the response was, "Someone would have pushed him off the ice when no one was looking." And so, there's this sense that even if—they had a different word for it, obviously, in their native language, but they had this construct, this understanding, that some people also will behave in ways that are irresponsible to social sanctioning, that they are impulsive, that they are selfish, that they are hostile, and if they're unresponsive to this treatment, then they will remove them.
- 4.98** And so, we're going to talk in the next section about the dark tetrad. We'll continue with a discussion of psychopathy, a bit about narcissism, Machiavellianism and sadism, and a discussion of the light triad as well, Kantianism, humanism, and faith in humanity, which is a more recent constellation of personality traits that have been discussed in the academic literature. We'll touch a little bit on morality and happiness as well. But I want to open it up to some questions now. We're going to go here, with Josh.

- 4.99 I do a lot of research and work on the topic of parental estrangement, adult children who have cut off contact with their parents. One of the things that I find is that there's generational differences in the moral foundations between the parents and the adult children, even if they come from the same class and they're highly educated. Highly educated, upper class is not unusual. I'm very interested in that.
- 4.100 I'm also interested in the fact of that a lot of the adult children will estrange themselves with the premise that, "Well, you didn't see that I was depressed when I was a child," or, "You didn't get me help for my ADD or my learning disabilities. Therefore, I have no moral obligation to you as a parent. And cutting you off is a virtuous thing for me to do, to protect my mental health." I'm wondering if you could speak to all of that.
- 4.101 I would imagine that, even within the same family, I think over time, people probably do come to—so when you're very young, especially in a rich, developed country, you probably do emphasize this ethic of autonomy. I'd mentioned it before, some of those very strange purity taboo cases. Affluent college students were the least strict or the most permissive in terms of what they think is OK to do or not OK to do.
- 4.102 But I would imagine, for most people over time, you start by caring about care and fairness, and then as you get older, you start to maybe gain an appreciation for things like loyalty, responsible authority, even maybe understanding the logic around purity norms and taboos. In this case, what comes to mind is some of the research on these dark personality traits. So, we'll get to them later, but I'll just briefly say that what may be going on here for some of these young people is, those traits tend to peak in early adulthood.
- 4.103 If you look at measures over the lifespan of psychopathic or narcissistic traits in the general population, so I'm not talking about people who would actually qualify for narcissistic personality disorder or antisocial personality disorder or psychopathy, but there are ways to measure these traits even in non-clinical populations, ordinary people. If you and I, anyone in this room, were to take these scales, you would not score zero. You would score somewhere in the midpoint.
- 4.104 There's some argument that a bit of narcissism, for example, may be healthy. Scoring zero would be actually not so great, but obviously, neither would be maxing out the scores either. But in young adulthood, we score the highest in our lives on those traits. I think people are probably more willing to be antagonistic, more willing to burn bridges, more willing to cut people off. In part, it derives from two different benefits.
- 4.105 One benefit is, again, living in a society where you don't necessarily need to maintain relationships to stay alive. So in pre-industrialized societies, modern hunter-gatherer societies, traditional societies, you often need to have a web of social connections just to sustain yourself, just to stay alive. That's not the case in rich, modern societies anymore.

- 4.106 Then, the other thing is being young. You have what some anthropologists call embodied capital, which is a fancy way of saying health, fitness, absence of sickness, illness, deterioration. When you're young and you have access to resources, you don't really feel like you need anyone. But often, when you get older, and you start to mature, maybe acquire some wisdom, and then as you literally start to physically decline, you start to realize that it can be good to have relationships with parents, family, friends, and so on.
- 4.107 I had this conversation with an oncologist, cancer doctor, a while back, and he was telling me how a lot of his older patients are—some of them are estranged from their adult children. Many of them were divorced, and many of them had no one to accompany them to the hospital when they needed some treatment, chemotherapy, some other operation, where they would need someone to watch over them, give them a ride to and from the hospital, accompany them. And he told me that, in many cases, it was the ex-spouse who would tag along.
- 4.108 He talked about one older gentleman who had cancer, and there was a woman with him, and she pulled the doctor aside and said, "Just so you know, we're not actually married. I'm his ex-wife, but I'm the only person he has. So I'm the one who's accompanying him to the hospital." I think, in many cases, people discover this too late, that you need to have relationships. Any other questions? This guy here?
- 4.109 On the topic of the one's, quote, unquote, true self, which it came to the idea of your true self versus the true self who is feeling strong emotions, first, who would you say is the true self? Second, why do we as a society want or like to pick people's true self?
- 4.110 The studies that I've been referencing on the true self are not about an actual true self, whatever that might mean. That's a philosophical question. We're interested in the psychology, the beliefs and perceptions about what the true self is, rather than trying to identify it in some philosophical or scientific way. On this point, what I can say is that some psychologists have suggested that what the true self actually is or what the authentic self is, what is authenticity, people will say different things.
- 4.111 It's about being real, it's about being yourself, it's not being performative, but expressing your real thoughts and opinions, that kind of thing. But then, when you look at when people actually feel the most authentic in their actual lives, it seems to be when they behave in a way that elicits social approval from those around them. For example, if you ask introverts to behave like extroverts, they'll often report feeling more authentic than if they are simply left to their own devices to behave like introverts.
- 4.112 The reason for that seems to be that when you behave in an extroverted way, people generally respond to you. It's easier to make friends that way. You're more sociable; you're more engaged. And extroversion is a trait that is valued, especially in Western societies, especially in American society. People report feeling authentic when they

behave in an extroverted way. People report feeling more authentic when they behave in a conscientious way versus in an impulsive manner.

- 4.113** People report feeling more authentic when they take on leadership roles and they've successfully accomplished the goals that they were tasked with. In more collectivistic or interdependent societies, people report feeling more authentic when they are told that they're good listeners. So, listening in a collectivistic society is valued. When people are told that they're good at this, they feel authentic.
- 4.114** The idea here seems to be that the true self, at least from a psychological perspective, is this idealistic aspirational image in our mind of who we live up to. You'll often hear people say things like, especially if they do something that is shameful in their community, they'll say things like, "That wasn't really me," or, "That's not who I am." But then, when they do something that elicits applause and praise, they'll think, "No, this is me. This is who I really am."
- 4.115** There are some exceptions to this. There are discussions around imposter syndrome and that kind of thing. But generally speaking, when people are applauded, when people feel well-liked and highly regarded, that's when they experience the subjective feeling of authenticity the most. But for the question, what is the true self? Your guess is as good as mine. Any other questions for this session?
- 4.116** When we talked about moral dumbfounding, all of those things that we discussed, like siblings having sex or cleaning a toilet with the flag, those things are legal, so they are not punished. But we feel that they're wrong. How, as a society, do we make the decision between what's legal and what's right and wrong? There's a gap, and I'm curious: How did we come to the decision of which things are wrong but not worth punishing?
- 4.117** It's a good question. The distinction between legal versus moral, or illegal versus immoral—yes, that's right, that using the flag or some of these weird cases, they are not illegal. Generally, it does seem, at least in Western societies, again, because we seem to hold more to an ethic of autonomy, most of our laws are centered on care and fairness. So obviously, inflicting violence on someone is illegal, but so is tax fraud, so is shoplifting or stealing, that kind of thing. You're violating notions of fairness by taking something that isn't yours. You're violating care when you hurt someone.
- 4.118** Whereas for the other three foundations, we might see those as immoral or unethical, to backtalk your coach or your boss or to betray a friend or commit adultery or something like that. But if you go to other societies, especially non-WEIRD societies, you'll find that they have strict laws, strict norms, particularly more religious societies. They have strict rules around how you should behave to your parents and your siblings.
- 4.119** There's this vast and intricate and thick matrix of what you're allowed to do, who you're allowed to communicate with, how you address people. If you fail to live up to those, in some cases, there are formal penalties. But as far as how that arises, societies

change over time. There was a time in this country, for example, where adultery could be punished by fine or imprisonment, and that's no longer the case. Something like smoking marijuana, in many states, is decriminalized, whereas in the past, it could carry fines or imprisonment.

4.120 I think the distinction here is about these disputes around harm. Is anyone actually being harmed by this? If we can persuade some percentage of society that this is actually a harmless act, then we can remove it from the category of illegal, but for many people, it would still remain immoral. I think we'll leave it at that. Thank you.

Lecture 5: Light vs. Dark

At a glance — Light vs. dark traits.

- 5.1 With psychopathy, it's a unique personality trait, but when psychologists study it, especially in the general population, it often forms what's known as the dark triad. The dark triad is a constellation of three different personality traits. You have psychopathy, narcissism, and Machiavellianism. Again, this dark triad construct is designed to capture these traits, not in clinical populations or among prison inmates, say, but in the general population.
- 5.2 If you were to take a dark triad scale, you would most likely fall somewhere in the midpoint. Very few of us would score zero on these three traits. Likewise, very few of us would score in the uppermost percentile. However, if you were to meet someone who scored in the top percentile of these three traits, it would probably be wise to hold on to your wallet, both literally and figuratively speaking.
- 5.3 As we'll see, there are some lifespan shifts throughout an individual's life course, where these traits tend to peak in adolescence and early adulthood, and then decline with age. We'll discuss that later in this lecture. But let's continue with the discussion of psychopathy. Psychopathy is sometimes known as the darkest of the three dark triad personality traits. It's associated with callousness and a disregard for other people.
- 5.4 They're prone to social comparison, particularly upward social comparison, where they want to know that they are doing better than others. They tend to experience envy if they see someone who has something that they don't have and that they desire it. We'll see later this relationship between psychopathy and the other dark triad traits, and happiness, life satisfaction, well-being. I mentioned before that people who have psychopathic personality styles have a poverty of emotion, blunted affect, shallow affect, an inability to experience guilt or remorse, and fear as well.
- 5.5 I watched this interview, this person who had psychopathy. The interviewer asked him, "Have you ever felt fear?" The guy says, "Yeah, I felt fear." The interviewer says, "When? Give me an example." This guy said, "I was driving on the freeway, and there was a truck in front of me, and there was a refrigerator in the back of the truck, and it fell out. And as I was speeding toward this refrigerator," and he managed to swerve away at the last minute, but he said, "As I was swerving toward it, I felt some tension in my body."
- 5.6 That was how he described fear. It was this kind of uncomfortable feeling in his stomach. He described it in these very physical terms, not in emotional terms, the way that you and I might describe what fear is like. It was this unrecognizable physiological response that he didn't know how to make sense of.

- 5.7 We talked about The Mask of Sanity, Hervey Cleckley, in his landmark book, in which he describes some of the traits of psychopathy. He used this phrase "mask of sanity" because when you interact with someone who has a psychopathic personality style, you don't always know up front. There is this kind of mask. Low impulse control, low on conscientiousness, that's one of the hallmarks of psychopathy as well.
- 5.8 I remember, psychopaths have this preoccupation with coming across in a certain way, in order to get what they want. It's a little different from narcissism, which we'll discuss, but psychopaths are often well-practiced at mimicking genuine emotion, imitating how to come across as normal. There was one interesting study where they had people watch videos of people who were high on psychopathy versus low on psychopathy, and had these individuals make different facial expressions, emotional expressions.
- 5.9 They had participants, ordinary people, look at these videos, and they didn't know who was a psychopath and who wasn't. Then they asked these participants viewing these videos: which of these individuals that you're watching is expressing the most genuine emotion? Which looks most authentic to you? And participants were most likely to say that the psychopaths were the most genuine in their emotional expression.
- 5.10 There are different possible explanations for this. But one is that, especially non-criminal psychopaths, the individuals who manage to get through ordinary society, spend a good deal of time, for example, watching television shows, learning how to come across as normal, or neurotypical, I guess, is the more PC term now.
- 5.11 There was one interview I saw of a psychopath, where the interviewer asked him, "Do you enjoy movies?" Because psychopaths have difficulty with empathy. One of the reasons people enjoy movies is because, on some level, you're identifying with the protagonist. You're with them on their journey. You hope the best for them. For a moment, you're lost in this other person's life and story and interiority. The psychopath said, "Oh, yeah, I love movies." The interviewer said, "OK, so what is it about movies that you like?" The guy said, "Well, it's like training for me. I get to watch these people. I learn what sadness looks like. I know what fear looks like. I know what shame looks like, embarrassment."
- 5.12 In some cases, psychopaths will watch the video, and then they'll literally go to a mirror and practice imitating these expressions. You could imagine that, because oftentimes in film and TV shows, you have very gifted actors, talented actors, portraying these emotions. Then psychopaths will imitate this very talented actor's facial expression, and in some case, even exaggerate it a bit more. This can come across as even more authentic than what ordinary emotion looks like.
- 5.13 Some sample items in psychopathy scales. You would rate the extent to which you agree with these statements on a scale from not at all like me to very much like me, or not at all agree to extreme agreement. One is, "I like to pick on losers." "People who

mess with me always regret it." "I sometimes get into dangerous situations," and "I like to get revenge on authorities."

- 5.14** We'll move on here to narcissism. Narcissism is similar to psychopathy, but not exactly the same. I want to make clear at the outset here that, when psychologists look at the dark triad, and they look at the narcissism component of the dark triad, they're really looking at grandiose narcissism. But there's been a large body of work now, suggesting that there are actually two different types of narcissism.
- 5.15** You have the grandiose type, the type that we'll be discussing later. But then there's also what's known as vulnerable psychopathy, or rather, vulnerable narcissism. Vulnerable narcissism, sometimes also referred to as covert narcissism, hidden narcissism. Sometimes I've seen papers where they'll describe them as shy narcissists. I give an example here: one example of a grandiose narcissist would be someone like Tony Stark.
- 5.16** As we'll see, narcissism is not always a bad thing. Some amount of narcissism may be necessary to take risks and to succeed and to have some outsized confidence in yourself. Whereas the vulnerable version of narcissism is more closeted, it is more associated with introversion, whereas the grandiose narcissists are more likely to be extroverted.
- 5.17** Both grandiose narcissism and vulnerable narcissism share a common core of antagonism, self-centeredness, belief that they deserve more than other people. But the difference is that, with grandiose narcissists, you can often tell up front. You can see a grandiose narcissist from a mile away. This is a wolf in wolf's clothing. You can detect who is a grandiose narcissist.
- 5.18** With vulnerable narcissists, you could think of them maybe as a wolf in sheep's clothing. Often, vulnerable narcissists will express how they don't want things, how they're, "I don't have any grand ambitions." That's how they'll communicate. But then internally, they often have these elaborate fantasies of success and accomplishment and achievement. But the fact that they don't act on those fantasies can cultivate bitterness and envy.
- 5.19** Grandiose narcissism is what the dark triad measures. With grandiose narcissism, it's associated with low emotional distress, low neuroticism. They tend to be more extroverted than average. They tend to experience a bit more happiness than average. Extreme confidence. They're impervious to insults, thick-skinned, where, if you try to insult a grandiose narcissist, it often doesn't really register because they think that they're great, no matter what anyone says. They'll ignore critics and pay special attention to their admirers.
- 5.20** There's a lot of self-promotion, a lot of bragging and boasting. They enjoy name-dropping. This is in contrast to vulnerable narcissism, which we'll discuss a bit more momentarily. Here are some grandiose narcissism sample items. Again, this is from

strongly disagree to strongly agree. "Others' opinions of me are of little concern to me." "I get lots of enjoyment from entertaining others." "Someday, I believe that most people will know my name." "Others say I brag too much, but everything I say is true." That's a grandiose narcissist.

- 5.21** A vulnerable narcissist, as I mentioned, is prone to shame, withdrawn, introverted, a tendency toward depression, high neuroticism. In contrast to grandiose narcissists, vulnerable narcissists are more sensitive to criticism. Often, that is the reason why they are withdrawn. Again, they have these elaborate fantasies of success, but they worry that if they strive for them, they might fail, and then invite critics and ridicule. And so they're content to just stew in these fantasies without acting on them.
- 5.22** They tend to be less happy than average, extremely envious, often self-deprecating, self-denigrating. They have this desire for recognition. Again, they seldom achieve it, but then when they do, they are often disappointed by it. They don't think that it's enough. Then they start to tell themselves, "It wasn't worth it anyway, because the world is so bad, or I'm so bad." I once heard this psychiatrist who ran a treatment facility for addicts, and he told me that one of the addicts—and this, in his view, encapsulates this idea of a vulnerable narcissist—is, you feel like a piece of shit around which the entire universe revolves.
- 5.23** Prone to anger, this sense of what some psychologists call humiliated fury, thin-skinned versus thick-skinned. Some sample items of vulnerable narcissism. "I often feel as if I need compliments from others in order to be sure of myself." "It really makes me angry when I don't get what I deserve." "When I realize I have failed at something, I feel humiliated," and "I often interpret the remarks of others in a personal way."
- 5.24** There are some important differences, though, between grandiose narcissism and psychopathy. Narcissists can often be charming and likable. They're extroverted. Narcissistic charm, that kind of charisma, is rooted in this desire for attention-seeking. They like being the center of attention. They like it when people pay attention to them. They're more theatrical, more bombastic. They are energized by being around people. The attention is an end in itself; that is the reward for a grandiose narcissist.
- 5.25** Whereas for psychopaths, they, too, often seek attention, but it's a means to an end. Attention in itself is not what they're seeking. They want the attention in order to acquire some material reward, social reward, professional reward, sexual rewards. It's more transactional. It's, "I'm going to do this in order to get that." It's more calculated. It's conscious. It's often deliberate. They know, step by step, the sequence they're trying to enact in order to get what they want.
- 5.26** Whereas for narcissists, it's often unconscious. They just enjoy the attention, and they will act in such a way to get it. It's less strategically thought-out. Some people will describe psychopaths as reptilian or cold-blooded, but people don't usually use those descriptors for narcissists.

- 5.27** Then, there's Machiavellianism, the third component of the dark triad. Of course, it's named after the political philosopher Niccolo Machiavelli. Machiavellianism measures strategic exploitation and duplicity. Other hallmarks of Machiavellianism, they tend to be cynical, suspicious of the motives of others. They have, similar to psychopaths, shallow affect, difficulty experiencing joy. They are often quick to make last-minute cancellations if a better opportunity comes along. I don't want to say anything about some of the students who aren't here today.
- 5.28** And in contrast to psychopaths, they actually have higher impulse control than average, oftentimes. They think, they calculate, they strategize. Often, when someone who has a Machiavellian personality style is treated kindly, someone is generous to them or charitable to them, they don't respond with gratitude; they respond with intense suspicion and start to wonder, "Why is this person being nice to me? What do they want from me?" Because in their mind, the only reason someone would be nice is in order to acquire something, because that's how they themselves behave.
- 5.29** Sample items for Machiavellianism. "I like to use clever manipulation to get my way." "It's wise to keep track of information that you can use against people later." "You should wait for the right time to get back at people," and "it's not wise to tell your secrets." From pop culture, one example of this would be someone like Logan Roy from Succession. Now, obviously, he probably has elevated levels of the other two traits, but I think Machiavellianism is more characteristic of a character like this, because he has high impulse control. He thinks, he strategizes. His actions are towards some goal, rather than something like attention or immediate reward. He enjoys subtly manipulating those around him.
- 5.30** Hallmarks of the dark triad. Each of these three traits, and this is somewhat oversimplified, but it's helpful to know that these three traits are interrelated but still distinct. And so, I'm going to give you a simplified summary of each. With narcissistically oriented people, what they really desire is seeking proof that they're valued in the eyes of others. They want social approval, and they often measure their success by how much they are envied by others.
- 5.31** If they acquire something that no one else wants, it's unsatisfying to them. But if they get something that is prized by other people, that other people are pursuing, and they are the ones who acquire it, which thereby elicits the envy of others, this is often satisfying for them. For psychopathically inclined people, they get a thrill out of exerting power over other people. They enjoy one-upping people, dominating people, not necessarily physically, although that's part of it sometimes, but also verbally and interpersonally. This is a source of extreme arousal for them.
- 5.32** They often have difficulty experiencing even positive emotions. We mentioned that negative emotions they seem to be more impervious to, but they're capable of positive emotion, but it's usually derived from getting one over on other people. There's a great

quote from the clinical psychologist Jonathan Shedler on psychopathic personality styles.

- 5.33** Jonathan Shedler says, "Others may puzzle over the person's motive for manipulation or cruelty where there seems little to be gained. The reason is because they can. Dominance and exerting power over another are their own rewards." Again, for narcissists, attention is the motive they're seeking. Attention is an end in itself. Whereas for psychopaths, acquiring attention is something that they seek, but it's often a means to exerting power, acquiring resources.
- 5.34** Finally, Machiavellianism. They mostly enjoy manipulating others around them, and doing this in order to ensure that the channels of pleasure and resources flow to them. They want to be in a position where they are the priority in everyone else's world, and they will use manipulation to that end. Now, when you run the statistical analyses, and we're not going to go into the weeds on this, these three traits all positively correlate with one another. If you score high on narcissism, you'll tend to score higher than average on psychopathy, and the same with Machiavellianism.
- 5.35** But still, they are neatly separated traits. You can score extremely high on one and only slightly above average on the others. These three traits are related to this recent idea that I just came across called counter-empathy. If you think about how ordinary empathy works, it's that someone's happy, and then their happiness rubs off on you. You feel happy too.
- 5.36** You see this in its most pronounced form if you walk into a room full of strangers. You've never met any of them, but they're all laughing. You will feel this involuntary response to laugh. Some of that joy will rub off on you, and you'll feel excited. Then same thing, even if you walk into a room full of strangers and they're all extremely upset, they're crying, they're dour, some of that will rub off on you, too, and you'll start to feel down. That's the normal response to the emotions of others.
- 5.37** But counter-empathy encompasses three different attributes. With counter-empathy, many of you are probably familiar with this term *schadenfreude*. It comes from a German word, literally translates to shame-joy, which is experiencing pleasure at the misfortunes of others. Some sample items when psychologists measure *schadenfreude*. "It can be satisfying when someone else gets fired," and "it can be amusing hearing about someone losing big at a casino." It's this pleasure when someone else has something bad happen to them.
- 5.38** Then there's *gluckschmerz*, another component of counter-empathy. This is another German word. The Germans have a word for everything. *Gluckschmerz* means luck-pain. That's the literal translation. This is experiencing unhappiness at the good fortune of others. It's the mirror image of *Schadenfreude*. *Schadenfreude* is experiencing sadness at the joy of others, or rather, it's about experiencing happiness at the

misfortune of others. Gluckschmerz is experiencing sadness when something good happens to them.

5.39 Gluckschmerz, some sample items. "I sometimes feel a little out of sorts when someone else's success is celebrated." "I feel bitter when others succeed." In some ways, you can think of this as emotional dysregulation. It's a counterregulation here, where generally, for ordinary people, if they see someone happy, they feel happy; they see someone sad, they feel sad.

5.40 For people with these attributes, high on these counter-empathy traits, their well-being seems to rely on the misfortune of others. When other people are sad, that's when they feel happy. When other people are happy, that actually makes them feel worse, and they feel sad, which clearly introduces difficulties for interpersonal relationships. But there's still something psychologically interesting there.

5.41 The final component of counter-empathy is affective sadism. Affective sadism is essentially going out of your way to make people's lives worse. A couple of sample items that measure this trait of affective sadism. "There's a certain pleasure in irritating someone on their worst day," and "I like to kick people when they're down." So counter-empathy is strongly correlated with the dark triad, which suggests that people who have elevated levels of narcissism, psychopathy, and Machiavellianism, in part, derive their happiness from antagonizing others, making people feel a little bit unhappy or sad.

5.42 Then, if they see people who are happy, this makes them feel worse, which will often activate this motivation to undermine that happiness in order to feel better themselves. Very strong correlation with the dark triad. Inverted emotional regulation, as I mentioned, where they feel the opposite of whoever is around them. They feel at their best when others are at their worst and vice versa. This is the reversal of the standard way that people experience empathy. It's counter-empathy.

5.43 Now, one of the interesting things about narcissism is that it is correlated with this idea of moral grandstanding. There have been a couple of interesting studies on moral grandstanding in the last few years, as well as a very interesting book by two philosophers, Justin Tosi and Brandon Warmke. Very interesting idea of moral grandstanding. Grandstanding is defined as the use of public moral discourse for self-promotion and status attainment.

5.44 You can think of it to some extent—people use this term "virtue-signaling," trying to look good. It's similar to virtue-signaling. But it's more grandstanding. It's more scientifically well-validated. It's not a colloquial term. It's a term now used in psychological and philosophical journals. Grandstanders use these excessive displays of outrage to show that they are sensitive to the injustices of the world.

5.45 They try to convince you that they're a good person through this display of outrage, which is distinct from virtue-signaling, because virtue-signaling is not necessarily about

using outrage. Sometimes it's posting a flag on your social media account or talking about how much you care about these people who are suffering, that kind of thing. But it doesn't—virtue-signaling doesn't necessarily involve displays of outrage, whereas moral grandstanding does.

- 5.46 Some sample items for grandstanders. "When I share my moral political beliefs, I do so to show people who disagree with me that I am better than them." I share my moral and political beliefs to make people who disagree with me feel bad. So people who have elevated levels of this moral grandstanding trait tend to agree with these statements. Moral grandstanding is tightly correlated with narcissism.
- 5.47 There's an author, Robert Greene, who wrote this book, *The 48 Laws of Power*, and he suggests an idea in this vein of moral grandstanding. His quote, "Those who make a show or display of innocence are the least innocent of all. You can recognize them by the way they flaunt their moral qualities, their exquisite sense of justice, throwing dust in our eyes, distracting us from their power plays." The idea here is that people who want to acquire power, recognition, and so on, will often camouflage themselves in moral virtue. But the virtue is insincere. It's the power-seeking that they're really after.
- 5.48 Moral grandstanding and narcissism. Moral grandstanding correlates with both vulnerable narcissism and grandiose narcissism. The antagonistic core of narcissism seems to be what's driving this, this desire to get one over on other people, make other people feel bad, get under other people's skin. It's primarily about making yourself look good, but also trying to get other people to feel bad. Narcissistic antagonism measures the extent to which people agree with statements like, "I can make anyone believe anything I want them to. I enjoy taking advantage of others if it helps me." That's moral grandstanding.
- 5.49 Now, there was an amusing paper that came out a couple of years ago, led by Mitch Brown, and they measured moral grandstanding and attempted to identify whether it was associated with mating motivations. You could imagine some people might make this ostentatious display of their moral character in order to look good to potential romantic partners. That's exactly what they found. But what was interesting is that they found that people who had strong mating motivations, if all they did was post on social media, this generally didn't seem to increase their appeal very much.
- 5.50 But for the grandstanders who also spent a lot of time in actual physical, political demonstrations and protests, they did become more appealing to potential partners. Just a bit from the abstract here. "Participants, particularly women, found prospective mates describing outrage-signaling activism to be more desirable for long-term meeting." And they go on to say here, "Mere expression of outrage without activism was insufficient to bolster attraction."
- 5.51 There was this meme going around, I want to say in late 2016, early 2017. I don't know if this was actually the case, but the stories floating around on social media, these guys,

these Trump supporters going to anti-Trump rallies to pick up girls, because they were often well-versed in the criticisms of Trump, because they were Trump supporters. But then they would adopt those opinions temporarily at anti-Trump rallies to get girls to like them. At least based on the rumors floating around online, many of them were successful.

- 5.52** This is sometimes called, maybe some of you heard this phrase, wokefishing. There's catfishing, which is misrepresenting yourself online, your appearance, your age, income, those kinds of things. But then, wokefishing is misrepresenting yourself as being more politically progressive than you really are. There was a bunch of articles over the last 8 or 10 years, of women, female journalists, writing about how they were wokefished, because some guy on a Tinder date or something would agree with all the progressive slogans, and then they would go home, and then she would see on his bookshelf a MAGA hat and Ann Coulter books, and like, "Oh, I've been wokefished."
- 5.53** But there are, of course, perils of grandstanding. One benefit of grandstanding is, if you do it in a tactful manner, this can boost your status and likability. It increases people's evaluation of your moral character, which is obviously why people engage in grandstanding in the first place. But if you are not tactful about it, if you attempt to shame others for their moral views, for disagreeing with you, or intimidate other people, then they tend to not like you very much. Grandstanders are usually antagonistic. This tends to actually not increase their likability, but reduces it.
- 5.54** Perceptions of authenticity are crucial here. If you are seen as a hypocrite grandstander, then people generally like you less. This seems to be because—there have been some interesting studies on the topic of hypocrisy, where generally, when someone publicly espouses an opinion, people expect you to abide by that opinion, even in your private life. The politician goes out and says, "Oh, I'm extremely anti-drug," and then you discover in their private life that they do drugs, then you go, "Oh, OK, this is a hypocrite," and then people feel shocked and betrayed and so on.
- 5.55** If you compare someone like that with someone who openly espouses drug use, and then you discover that they also use drugs in their private life, they experience no penalty in terms of their reputation. People really don't like hypocrites because they think that they're misrepresenting their own moral character. But individuals who loudly and visibly describe how virtuous they are are often held to a higher standard, which can also be a pitfall of grandstanding.
- 5.56** If I get up here and talk about how I believe in this, that, and the other, and I'm outraged that those people don't believe it, and so on, then I will be judged to a higher standard. I should live by those principles that I'm so loudly and angrily affirming. Then, if I fail to live up to those, I will be judged more negatively than if I were to have never engaged in grandstanding at all. Grandstanding can have some benefits, but also many pitfalls.

- 5.57** Over the last few years, there's been this discussion of dark triad traits, of whether or not there should be an addition, a fourth dark personality trait, which is sadism. We mentioned sadism earlier in our discussion of counter-empathy, but sadism has been—there's still some debate, but it has been suggested that it should be added to this constellation to make the dark tetrad. Sadism is distinct from psychopathy.
- 5.58** Psychopathy is an indifference to harming others. They can often experience joy at harming others, but often the harming of others is a side effect of what they're really after. If you're in my way and I want this other thing, a psychopath will say, "OK, well, then I'll just eliminate you, to get that thing that I want." Whereas for sadists, the inflicting of harm is an end in itself. It's not mere indifference to causing harm, but it's actively seeking it out, actively trying to harm others. They use cruelty to feel aroused, alive, strong, or in control.
- 5.59** Some researchers have suggested that sadism is merely an extreme form of psychopathy, but there's some debate about this. One of the pioneers of the dark triad concept, I think his name is Delroy Paulhus. I'm probably mispronouncing it. But Delroy Paulhus and his collaborators attempted to create behavioral measures of sadism. Instead of filling out a scale, they wanted to know, are there some ways to measure this behaviorally? Then do those behavioral measures correlate with people's answers on a sadism scale?
- 5.60** One thing that they did was they brought in some participants into their psychology lab, and they had this makeshift device that looked like a coffee maker or a coffee grinder. Then they showed the participants this baking sheet of insects. They told the participants, "We have these insects here. We've been using them for a different experiment. Some of our research assistants gave these insects some cute names. This is Muffin, this is Tootsie." Then they invited the participants to place as many insects as they wanted into this device, press a button, and if you press the button, it would kill the insect, and it would make this sound similar to a coffee grinder.
- 5.61** Now, some participants, when they were invited to put the insects into this device and press this button to kill the insect, were horrified and asked to leave the experiment. Other participants tepidly agreed, maybe they did one or two, and then finished. Then, the other participants not only placed all of the insects into the device, pressed the button, they then asked the experimenter if there were more insects that were available, so that they could continue to kill them. As you can imagine, those participants scored very high on the sadism scale. It is darkly amusing there.
- 5.62** By the way, in this study, no insects were actually harmed. This machine was rigged so that the insects would crawl out on the other side, and participants wouldn't know. So, sample items for the sadism component of the proposed dark tetrad. "I enjoy physically hurting people." "I was purposely cruel to someone in high school." "I dominate others using fear." And again, there's still some debate about this. Maybe sadism should just

be thought of as extreme psychopathy and so on, but statistically, you can separate them to some extent.

- 5.63** I like this quote from Robert Greene again. He talks about how "those who love the Machiavellian part of our nature and revel in it can get pretty far, but eventually they're tripped up. They don't understand that there is a whole other side to the game, which requires empathy and cooperation."
- 5.64** You see this with people who have elevated levels of the dark triad. People who are high, particularly in psychopathy, tend to be less successful in their lives than average, primarily because, again, they have low impulse control, on average; they have difficulty delaying gratification; they act on their desires; and you need to have a bit of patience and a bit of impulse control in order to succeed.
- 5.65** For narcissism and Machiavellianism, it's unclear. Some studies show that slightly elevated levels of Machiavellianism can help people succeed. Other studies show no relationship at all. For grandiose narcissism in particular, it does seem to be associated with a slightly higher likelihood of success. But if you go too far and overshoot, and then you're very grandiose, this is typically detrimental for conventional measures of success.
- 5.66** Now, this is a course about morality. The question here is, people who have elevated dark triad scores, how does their moral psychology differ from ordinary people, people who do not have elevated levels of these traits? One interesting study found that people who are high on the dark triad tend to have a more utilitarian moral orientation. They're more likely to pull the switch in the trolley problem case. They're more likely to push the large man off the bridge. They're more likely to agree that the surgeon should sacrifice one patient's life to rescue the other five.
- 5.67** It's a very mathematical problem for them. They don't really experience, I guess you could call it, the burdens of empathy, in this case. It's not thinking about the life or the person or whether it's right or wrong to sacrifice someone. It's just a straightforward math problem. They're more likely to agree with statements such as "it's OK to lie or cheat if it helps you to succeed," which suggests— and we'll go over some more studies later—that they have a distorted moral compass.
- 5.68** Generally, people who are high in the dark triad rate moral violations as less objectionable across the board. We've gone over a bunch of different kinds of moral transgressions, and people with elevated dark triad traits are more likely to say, "Those are permissible, those are fine." You see this with self-reported measures of behavioral misconduct.
- 5.69** Essentially, the finding here is that people who are high on the dark triad self-report greater measures of delinquency, getting into trouble with the law, breaking the rules as a child, more issues around sex, difficulty having prolonged romantic and intimate

relationships, more interpersonal difficulties, making and maintaining friendships, and more likely to report attempting to use manipulative tactics on those around them.

- 5.70** These tactics can be temporarily effective. But often, you'll find that people who are very high on these traits are itinerant. They move frequently. They constantly relocate because they have a tendency to burn social bridges with friends, with romantic partners, or at their job. Then they have to move somewhere else and start their new life over.
- 5.71** People who are high on narcissism, in particular, tend to be good at first impressions. Very interesting findings here where, in business organizations, for example, people who are high in narcissism are often initially very well liked, but then as time goes on, they become increasingly less well liked, and then eventually, they're less well liked than the average person in the organization, so it drops dramatically over time.
- 5.72** You see this as well with romantic relationships, that often people talk about being in a relationship with someone with a narcissistic personality style. It's often very initially exciting to be with someone like this, who's very dynamic and bombastic and attention-seeking and often well practiced at getting others to like them. But then over time, they start to see this void in the person, that there's no authentic aspect of this individual, and then it's all about impressing others and attention-seeking, and then the relationship sours.
- 5.73** I know one of the other Peterson Academy psychology instructors, Keith Campbell, has what he's called the chocolate cake model of narcissism, with regard to romantic relationships, where initially, when you eat chocolate cake, it tastes amazing, but then you eat more and more and more, and then eventually you start to feel sick. The analogy here is to people high on narcissism. Initially, it's exciting, it's fun, you really enjoy it. The more time you spend, eventually you become unwell.
- 5.74** And so, fine, we've gone over some self-reported measures. People say, "Oh, I'm like this, I'm like that." And we covered one behavioral study of sadism. But it's also useful to have other behavioral experiments to see how people who are high on these traits actually behave. In one study, they brought participants in, had them fill out these dark triad scales, and then invited them to play a game. In this game, participants were asked to privately flip a coin 10 times. It was a fair coin, normal coin.
- 5.75** The participants were alone when they did this task. There was no experimenter in the room, so they were able to cheat if they wanted. They earned money each time the coin landed on heads. But again, the flips were unobservable, and so it was very easy. If I ask you, "Flip this coin 10 times. I'll be in the other room. You tell me how many heads you got, and I'll give you money," very easy to cheat at this game.
- 5.76** They found that 13% of the participants cheated, which is about what you would expect. It's a little higher, but in the general population, you'll find that something like 5 to maybe 8% of the population has elevated levels of these dark triad traits, depending

on how you measure it. This is generally what you find. There's a small percentage of people who are prone to misbehavior and misconduct. So 13% of these participants cheated. These 13% had elevated dark triad scores, which suggests that, in this behavioral measure, people who are high on these traits are more likely to cheat to win money.

- 5.77** What is the prevalence of psychopaths in the general society? I'm talking here about actual clinical levels of psychopathy, not psychopathy necessarily as measured by dark triad scales, but actual psychopaths. These would be people who would meet a certain threshold on something like Robert Hare's psychopathy checklist. Robert Hare is one of the pioneers of the study of psychopathy. He created a checklist, and if you score above a certain threshold, you would be categorized as having a psychopathic personality style.
- 5.78** There's been some discussion about this, about the threshold and whether it's arbitrary, whether it makes sense. For most personality traits, if not all, you can think of them more as dimmers rather than toggles. It's not as if you are a psychopath or you aren't. Rather, it exists on a spectrum. Some of us are higher, some of us are lower. But for societal reasons, we often have to make these arbitrary but still useful cutoffs and distinctions.
- 5.79** For car seats, for example, there are laws. If you're a child below 65 pounds, you have to have a car seat. Is there really a huge difference between being 64 pounds versus 65 pounds? But the law decided that's the threshold, that's the cutoff. You see this for measures of mental conditions and disorders and so on, that at some point you have to draw the line somewhere for social reasons.
- 5.80** For psychopaths in the general population, about 1-3%, again, depending on which measure you use. For prison inmates, 20% of prison inmates are psychopaths. I've seen other studies suggesting it's as high as 30%. For business executives, it's 13%, quite a bit higher than the population average of 1-3%. For college students, it's 8%, again, higher than the population average. Many of those students will decline in psychopathy over the life course. One reason why that number is high is because they're young.
- 5.81** I had this conversation a while back with the British psychologist, John Barry, and John Barry told me that, when he was in training, he was told to never use adult psychopathy measures on teenage males because you would regularly get a false positive. Many of those teenage males, later in life, would not qualify as psychopaths, as their frontal lobes develop and as they mature and gain some impulse control. But if you measure a hundred 17-year-old boys, you might be surprised how many of them would score above that psychopathy threshold.
- 5.82** Thirteen percent of business executives are psychopaths. This was discussed at length by Robert Hare, who I'd mentioned before, the psychologist, one of the pioneers of psychopathy research. There's this book, *Snakes in Suits*. He has this phrase,

"organizational psychopaths" or corporate psychopaths. One thing they suggest is that, as I mentioned, people who are high on these traits tend to be less successful than average. Some studies suggest that, again, with grandiose narcissism, maybe a little bit, Machiavellianism is unclear. But if you combine the dark triad traits with a high level of impulse control and a high level of intelligence, those people can often be very effective.

- 5.83** Again, if you think about a cold-blooded psychopath who, emotionally, is cold and unfeeling, but intellectually, they've picked up on their society's rules of what counts as right and wrong, and then they just obey them because they know they don't want to end up in prison, they don't want to be penalized, they want to be successful, they want all of the rewards that go along with being a successful person, and so if they happen to be high in conscientiousness and intelligence, then being elevated on these traits may, in a narrow sense, be advantageous in the professional white-collar world.
- 5.84** Prison inmates, as we mentioned, 20 to 30% of inmates have scores high enough to reach the threshold for psychopathy. And there's this other idea in the dark personality research where they just describe it as the dark factor, which is essentially boiling down all of these dark traits into one singular measure. This is defined as a general tendency to maximize one's individual utility, disregarding, accepting, or malevolently provoking disutility for others, accompanied by beliefs that serve as justifications.
- 5.85** This is essentially someone who would score high on all three of these dark triad personality traits. It's a reduced measure. I don't necessarily want to know all three. Your score is on all three. I just want this one snapshot score. You lose a little bit of the nuance in measures like this. But still, it can be useful to have a singular captured snapshot.
- 5.86** These dark traits, the simplified measure of the dark triad predicts criminality even after controlling for other personality traits. So even if I were to control for your levels of conscientiousness and openness and neuroticism and so on, I would still find that, if you have elevated dark triad traits, you would be more prone to criminality. Relative to people in the general community, unsurprisingly, inmates have higher dark personality scores, and then also higher sadism scores. For criminal psychopaths in particular, if you compare a criminal psychopath to a non-criminal psychopath, you would still see differences in their scores on these scales.
- 5.87** This is from Nicholas D. Thomson. He's a forensic psychologist who wrote an interesting book called *Understanding Psychopathy: The Biopsychosocial Perspective*. He points out that, under the measure he uses, despite being only 1.2% of the population, psychopaths commit 30 to 40% of all violent crimes. He writes here that "psychopaths get a thrill from the crime they commit. They positively appraise using aggression. They get pleasure from hurting and dominating others, and they glibly recount and brag about their brutality. They're opportunistic in their cruelty."

- 5.88** It's important to note here that not every psychopath is a criminal, and not every criminal is a psychopath. But if you have elevated levels of these psychopathic traits, your likelihood of going to prison or having some contact with the legal system goes up dramatically. Psychopaths are prone to victim-signaling. This is also true for Machiavellians and narcissists as well.
- 5.89** I really like this quote here from the 20th-century Chicago gangster Al Capone, after he was arrested—he was responsible directly and indirectly for hundreds of murders. After his arrest, Al Capone said, "I have spent the best years of my life giving people the lighter pleasures, helping them have a good time, and all I get is abuse, the existence of a hunted man." He was arrested for tax fraud and racketeering. That's how he thought of himself, as a victim. Despite being responsible for hundreds of murders and countless suffering of others, he still thought of himself and framed himself as a victim.
- 5.90** John Wayne Gacy, the serial killer, when he was interviewed, said, "I see myself more as a victim than a perpetrator. I was the victim. I was cheated out of my childhood." Then, as he continued, he wondered aloud if there would be someone somewhere who understood how badly it hurt to be John Wayne Gacy. Again, he was a serial killer responsible for upwards of a dozen murders. But after his arrest, suddenly, he is the victim.
- 5.91** Martha Stout wrote this very interesting book some years ago, *The Sociopath Next Door*. She writes that there is "an excellent reason for the sociopathic fondness for pity. Pity is used against us by those who have no conscience. All in all, I'm sure if the devil existed, he would want us to feel very sorry for him." She titled her book, the psychologist Martha Stout, *The Sociopath Next Door*. There is often a question here. Is there a difference between psychopaths and sociopaths?
- 5.92** Part of the reason why this confusion exists is because of the inconsistency of how the terms are used in the clinical and academic literature. One suggestion to distinguish these two has been that sociopaths are made and psychopaths are born. Psychopaths were born with the genetic predisposition to behave the way that they do, whereas sociopaths become that way through socialization, through poor upbringing, difficult early life, having to acquire skills to manipulate those around them in order to survive. That was one way of thinking about it.
- 5.93** Others have suggested, actually, the way these terms should be used is that a psychopath is just a more extreme sociopath; that sociopaths are the ones who can exist in society and get along with others, even if they have those manipulative and antagonistic traits, whereas psychopaths are the really hardcore types, the most extreme version of that. Generally, psychologists today, in the academic research, talk about psychopathy. They don't really talk about sociopaths. Sociopath has survived as a colloquial term that people use in everyday life to describe someone with these traits.

- 5.94** Then, there's a related construct that clinicians will use, antisocial personality disorder, which is more about measuring behavior, rather than emotions and internal tendencies and desires. But all of these traits are related to one another. If you score highly on one, you would almost certainly score highly on the other. If you're antisocial, you qualify for antisocial personality disorder; you would probably score high in psychopathy and vice versa.
- 5.95** And so, the question here—we have these anecdotes. Al Capone talking about how he was suffering as the existence of a hunted man. John Wayne Gacy, "Oh, I was cheated out of my childhood. I'm the victim." Martha Stout, through her clinical observations, suggests that sociopaths have this fondness for pity. Is this true? Do people high on the dark triad traits have this inclination to signal victimhood? This has actually been studied empirically.
- 5.96** There was a 2021 study where they measured victim-signaling and the dark triad traits. They defined victim-signaling as the "public and intentional expression of one's disadvantages, suffering, oppression, or personal limitations." So broadcasting how you have been victimized or mistreated in some way in a public forum, whether online or in real life. Some sample items for victim-signaling. Disclosed that I don't feel accepted in society because of my identity, or expressed how people like me are underrepresented in the media and leadership.
- 5.97** The more you agree that you participate or partake in these behaviors, the higher your scores on the dark triad. People who have elevated dark triad traits are more likely to engage in victim-signaling. This is because, particularly in modern Western societies, positioning yourself as a victim can lead to rewards or sympathy, respect, trust. We'll explore this when we talk about the virtuous victim effect.
- 5.98** But I should also be clear that I'm not saying that actual victims have elevated dark triad personality traits. Rather, I'm saying that people who have high dark triad personality trait scores are more likely to disguise themselves as victims. It's very different. One way to interpret this is that they're actually making life worse for the actual victims, because they're introducing doubt in people's minds about, if someone describes some mistreatment that they've experienced, this introduces doubt as to whether they're telling the truth.
- 5.99** I posted this online some years ago. It was a 2020 study, actually, not 2021. Jordan pointed out that the correlations, particularly for psychopathy, are remarkably large. He noticed that, among the three traits, psychopathy, narcissism, Machiavellianism, all three of the dark triad personality traits correlated with victim-signaling. But the trait that had the strongest relationship with victim-signaling was psychopathy. Again, that is often described as the darkest of the three dark triad personality traits.
- 5.100** People who are psychopathically inclined are particularly likely to adopt the mantle of victimhood. And so, why would they camouflage themselves in victimhood? What's the

benefit? Well, this brings us to the virtuous victim effect. Recently, some researchers ran a series of 17 different studies, more than 9,000 participants. What they found is that people consistently judged the victims of wrongdoing as more moral and more trustworthy than identical non-victims, simply because they had been wronged, simply because they had been the victims of mistreatment.

- 5.101 One simple way that they looked at this was they presented people with stories of otherwise identical people. In one condition, the story is that the person was on their way to work and then had their iPad stolen, and then some other things happened. Then you asked the participant, "How moral is this person? How much would you trust them?" So on and so forth. Then you had another story, same exact story, person on their way to work. Very mundane, nothing happens. Who do you trust more? People trust the person who had their iPad stolen more. Somebody who had been victimized in some way, we believe that they are more worthy of trust and more worthy of the mantle of morality.
- 5.102 What's interesting is that this virtuous victim effect is specific to victims of immorality, of mistreatment by another person, not by unfortunate accidents. If you tell a story about this person on their way to work, and he was struck by lightning, people don't view that person as any more moral than the person who was on their way to work and was not struck by lightning. It's specifically being the target of mistreatment by another conscious entity.
- 5.103 It's also specific to victims of moral—yeah, it's specific to moral traits, not to other valued attributes. So, people view the victim of theft or other misfortunes as more moral, more trustworthy, but they didn't view them as more competent or more likable. It's specific to morality. You have to be victimized by a person. And the trait that people will perceive you as being especially representative of, or the exemplar of, would be morality, rather than competence or likability. This helps us to understand why people with dark personality traits would position themselves as victims. If they want you to think that they're trustworthy, that they're moral, being a victim can have benefits.
- 5.104 A common question that people ask is, what makes someone a psychopath? What turns someone into a narcissist? Why would someone become a Machiavellian? As with every other psychological trait, some of it is nature, some of it is nurture. There's genes and environment. Now, for psychopathy and narcissism in particular, those are especially heritable, seem to be largely genetic in origin. Genes are primarily responsible for scores on psychopathy and narcissism. Machiavellianism seems to be more environmental.
- 5.105 Now, to be clear, I'm not saying that psychopathy and narcissism are only genetic. There's always a bit of both. But when you measure the differences between people, it seems that genes are more responsible than the environment. Then the same for Machiavellianism as well. Machiavellianism has a bit of nature, a bit of nurture, genes

and environment. But Machiavellianism seems to be distinct in that it seems to arise more so from environmental factors than genetic ones.

- 5.106** There are different ways that people measure heritability. One is through separated twin studies. So, twins separated at birth, later on in life, they grow up, and then you have them take these psychological scales, look at their behavior and so on. You'll often find that twins separated at birth tend to be very similar. You can also look at adoption studies, where you have two kids who are unrelated but are raised in the same home, same school, same neighborhood, and so on. Then you'll be able to measure how much of their personality was environmental as a result of growing up in the same home, in the same environment, and how much of their personality seems to be genetic in origin.
- 5.107** We don't have to get into the weeds on this, but I just want to make a point about heritability. Some people, when they hear, Machiavellianism, for example, is something like 40% heritable. People hear that and then they think, "Oh, so 40% of your Machiavellianism is your genes, and then 60% must be environment." But the way heritability is measured, it doesn't measure how much of you as an individual is genetic versus environmental. It measures the difference between you and another individual.
- 5.108** So if I have someone else standing next to me, and I score 45, and this person scores 50 on Machiavellianism, for example, and they want to know how much of this difference is due to genes versus environment, and that's what heritability means, is, OK, well, the difference, there's a five-point difference between me and this other person. You have this five-point difference. What's responsible for that difference? If it's 60% environment, then you would say something like three of those five points are due to genes, two of those points are due to environment, or vice versa. I'm vastly oversimplifying this, but this is what heritability means.
- 5.109** Another way to think about this, heritability is not the same thing as inheriting something. You can inherit your eye color, your hair color, those kinds of things from your parents. But heritability is used in this very specific way. Heritability is, again, measuring how much of the difference between you and another person is due to genes versus environment.
- 5.110** A simple example is how many arms you have. If you are uninformed about the research and the terminology and everything—and it can get a little intricate and annoying—but if I were to ask you how many arms someone has, how heritable is that, how much of that is genes, how much of that is environment, the heritability of how many arms you have, a lot of people would say, "Oh, that's 100% genetic. You inherit your two arms. That's how humans are, it's biology."
- 5.111** But in fact, the heritability of how many arms you have is almost zero. Because in the real world, how many arms you have is usually due to environmental factors rather than genetic ones. Everyone has two arms. Everyone's born with two arms. Then, for a

lot of people, through accidents and misfortune and so on, they lose their arms. That is entirely environmental, how many arms you have, the variance in how many arms people have.

- 5.112** That is what heritability measures. It's not you as an individual; it's the difference between you and someone else. I have two arms; this person has one arm. That's due to the environment. That's not due to genetics. I have two arms; this person has two arms. Again, that's not due to heritability. That's due to environmental factors that we both have both of our arms. Not important for this course, but it's just something that people often mistake: heritability versus inheritance.
- 5.113** We've been talking a bit here about the darker aspects of human nature. But I want to transition into the light triad, which is a recent finding in psychology. It was this exploration and attempt to see whether or not you could measure people's positive attributes, as well as the darker aspects of their nature. So the light triad encompasses three traits, just like the dark triad. You have humanism, which is defined as the appreciation of the success and creation of others. Kantianism, a tendency toward behaving with integrity and honesty rather than deceit and charm. Then, faith in humanity, believing that people are generally good and worthy of trust.
- 5.114** The dark triad and the light triad are not opposites. If you were to take the light triad scale and the dark triad scale, you would score somewhere, most likely in the middle of the distribution for both. They are inversely correlated. If you score high on the light triad, on average, you'll score lower on the dark triad. If you score high on the dark triad, on average, you would score lower on the light triad. But all of these traits exist to some extent within all of us, but they're not opposites.
- 5.115** So, with regard to morality, people with elevated light triad traits have a greater objection to immoral acts. In this sense, there is a reversal from the dark triad, in that people who have elevated light triad traits rate moral violations to be more objectionable than average. They take more of a deontological approach to ethics, rather than a utilitarian one or a consequentialist one.
- 5.116** So recall that people with high dark triad traits are more consequentialist in their responses to the trolley problems. People with the light triad traits are the opposite. They're less likely to sacrifice someone to rescue some larger number. They generally are more likely to engage in charity. They agree that helping strangers or donating money is the right thing to do. Overall, very different from the dark triad.
- 5.117** This brings us to a discussion here about the relationship between morality and happiness. This is a question that has been discussed and debated among moral philosophers dating back as far as Aristotle and then on through the Enlightenment, through Kant and beyond. This is a quote from the Russian-British philosopher, Isaiah Berlin. Here he's summarizing a view from Immanuel Kant. He says that "ethics is

concerned with explaining not what a man must do in order to be happy, but what he must do to be worthy of happiness."

- 5.118** We're going to see here, was Isaiah Berlin, in summarizing the views of Kant, I mean, is this correct? Is there a relationship between behaving in a principled way and how happy you are? First, there's self-esteem. Is there a link between self-esteem and these dark triad traits? We went over here. People high on the dark triad tend to be more criminally inclined. They tend to rate moral violations to be less objectionable, generally more likely to participate in misconduct, relatively less moral than average.
- 5.119** How do people high on the dark triad traits feel? What's interesting here is that the dark triad, overall, does seem to have a slight relationship, positive relationship, with self-esteem. They generally feel a little better than average. When you break it down between the three traits, it seems to be mostly tied to grandiose narcissism. We'll see that people high on psychopathy and Machiavellianism actually tend to be less happy than average.
- 5.120** People high on the light triad tend to be higher on measures of self-esteem than people high on the dark triad, which suggests that people who have these more positive attributes—more helpful, more cooperative— feel better about themselves than people high on the dark triad. People high on the dark triad generally derive their feelings of self-worth from meeting their own immediate needs, putting themselves first. People high on the light triad derive much of their feelings of self-worth from looking outward and helping others.
- 5.121** Then, there's also this idea in psychology of state orientation versus task orientation. State orientation is how much you are preoccupied with yourself, your state, your emotional state: I'm oriented toward myself. I'm looking inward. How do I look to others? How am I coming across? What are my thoughts? Trapped in my own head. Then, there's task orientation, which is looking outward: What's going on in the world? How do I get involved? How do I accomplish these goals? How do I interact with others? How do I get along?
- 5.122** Studies consistently find that task orientation predicts happiness more so than state orientation. Being self-absorbed generally tends to reduce feelings of well-being versus looking outward towards others, towards your goals, towards your mission. That seems to be a stronger predictor of happiness and well-being. There's life satisfaction as well. People high in the light triad, these positive traits, have elevated levels of life satisfaction. Pretty striking statistical relationship there. The higher you are on the light triad, the higher your self-reported life satisfaction.
- 5.123** People high in the dark triad have lower life satisfaction than average. They're less satisfied. Part of that, again, is related to envy, to feelings that they haven't yet got what they deserve. The social comparison—why does that person have that and not me? That does not make for a particularly satisfying life. Measures of self-hate have

also been measured with regard to the dark triad. People who have high levels of self-hate punish themselves with negative thoughts, negative feelings, behaviors.

- 5.124** People who have high self-hate tend to view themselves through the eyes of others, particularly those who believe, dislike them. It's not so much, "I hate myself;" it's, "Other people hate me, and that makes me feel bad, and that makes me hate myself." It's closely linked with shame. There are some sample items here of self-hate. "If something bad happens to me, I feel I must have deserved it." "I do not deserve other people's respect or admiration." "I feel I do not deserve to be happy." "I believe I have tricked other people into liking me." There's this feeling of inauthenticity.
- 5.125** How do these traits, the dark triad traits and the light triad traits, correlate with self-hate? Unsurprisingly, people who are high on the dark triad have elevated levels of self-hate. They don't like themselves very much, and they think that other people don't like them, which is the main reason why they don't like themselves. People high on the light triad have low levels of self-hate, lower than average.
- 5.126** Same for mental health, this pattern. You see it with dark triad Machiavellianism. It's a strong correlation with anxiety and depression. People high on Machiavellianism tend to be more depressed and more anxious than average. They tend to have higher scores on anhedonia, which is defined as the inability to experience pleasure, higher levels of alexithymia, or disconnection from their own feelings. There's often this confusion at their own emotional state. Same with Machiavellianism and depression, psychopathy and depression as well. If you have a Machiavellian or a psychopathic personality style, you're more prone than average to experiencing negative emotions.
- 5.127** Narcissism is the odd one out here, where some studies essentially find no relationship at all between grandiose narcissism and depression. You see other studies suggesting maybe a slight positive correlation there, where the higher you are in grandiosity, maybe a little bit less prone to depression than average. But vulnerable narcissism, in contrast to grandiose narcissism, strongly predicts higher depression scores. The shy, covert, hidden narcissists, the ones who have these fantasies of power but are unwilling or unable to achieve them, that predicts higher depression scores.
- 5.128** I'll reference here Jonathan Shedler again, who talks about people with narcissistic personality styles. He says there's often this "chronic, painful gap between the person's grandiose expectations of the world versus what the world actually affords." This is specifically about vulnerable narcissism. "Instead of joy or fulfillment, the person experiences repeated disappointment and resentment. This is a pathway to what gets diagnosed as depression. Behind major depressive disorder, we often find a deflated narcissist."
- 5.129** He's not saying always. Not everyone who has depression is a deflated narcissist, but often, clinicians will report that a lot of the negative emotion arises from the person feeling like they're not valued enough, not necessarily because they're working really

hard and therefore they should be valued more and more so. They should be valued for who they are, rather than what they've done.

- 5.130** You also see that dark triad traits are associated with misanthropy, the feeling that other people are generally worthless, unworthy of regard, a kind of callousness and cynicism. Also, antinatalism or the belief that it's wrong to have children. The higher your scores on the dark triad, the more likely you are to endorse antinatalist attitudes. The link here seems to be primarily the result of depression. I mentioned that particularly psychopathy and Machiavellianism are associated with depression. The higher your score is on the dark triad, the higher your score is on depression, and that in turn predicts antinatalist attitudes.
- 5.131** If you're depressed, you feel like life isn't worth living, sensitive to negative emotion, and then you might think, "Why? Why bring children into the world? Why reproduce? The world is so ugly, so miserable, so cutthroat." So we have this devaluation of life, which in turn causes difficulty in perceiving the good and positive aspects of existence. I think that also might be related to this idea of counter-empathy we had mentioned as well, that often when people have kids, there's a lot of joy and excitement around it, and this can bother people with dark personality styles. Because, again, they have the opposite emotional regulation patterns. If other people are happy, they feel sad and vice versa.
- 5.132** There was this really amusing headline in the Boston Globe earlier this year. "Want to find out if someone is a psychopath? Take them to a magic show." What they found is that people who score highly on psychopathy don't like magic shows, in part because they don't like not knowing what's going on. They don't like feeling like they're not the dominant person in the room. The magician's doing all these cool tricks. They're getting all the attention, and they're doing something that no one else knows how to do. This makes the psychopath feel diminished and feel lesser than.
- 5.133** Paul Silvia, one of the authors of this study, says, "People who want to dominate those around them, who aren't agreeable or easygoing, and who get a high score for psychopathy, feel like they're the butt of the joke. They feel like you're kind of humiliating them." Then he goes on to say, and this is key, "These people are on the internet a lot."
- 5.134** There's this belief that anyone online can be a troll. This is, in the psychological literature, called the mismatch hypothesis, that you have this online environment. There's a lack of anonymity, lack of social cues. You feel safe and protected, texting or typing on your phone or your laptop in the comfort of your own home, so this makes people behave worse because they feel safe to say whatever horrible thing comes to mind. The idea is that it changes people. You can take an ordinary person who's very kind in real life, and then suddenly the darker aspects of their nature come out once they're on their phone or on social media.

- 5.135** But the research doesn't support that. I mentioned this before. The competing hypothesis is what's known as the connectivity hypothesis, which suggests that you see hostility more online. It's more visible online than in real life. But that's primarily because people who are hostile, high in the dark triad traits, post more frequently. They tend to gain larger audiences. They have greater reach online, and then this makes their behavior more visible.
- 5.136** In real life, there's an upper bound as to how many people I can affect with my behavior in the real world, in meatspace. But if I get online, I can bother a lot of people at the same time. I can reach 50 million people or whatever it is. You can go into the comments section and start messing with people. You can troll people. You can harass people. You can't do that, especially with the same frequency and the same volume, in the real world.
- 5.137** What these researchers find is that most people who are kind in real life are also pretty kind online. People who are very antagonistic in the real world are also antagonistic online. But because they tend to spend more time online and because they get a thrill out of antagonizing people, and it's easier to do that online, it creates this illusion that everything online is toxic.
- 5.138** Another point here is that often you have this pattern where normal people post less as a result of all the toxicity they see online. There's this belief that, "Oh, everything online is so toxic. I can lurk, I can browse, I'll scroll, but I'm not going to participate in this online toxicity." But then this in turn creates this interesting feedback loop, where the fewer people, normal nice people, post online, the more likely you are when you check what's going on online to see only toxic content.
- 5.139** And so, the conclusion. "Online environments don't seem to fundamentally change people. It just amplifies the visibility and actions of those who are predisposed to hostility." This is going over this study here. "Little evidence that online environments make otherwise nice people hostile." The conclusion is that the connectivity hypothesis seems to be the case, that the online world isn't changing people, it's just giving toxic personalities a platform to post and to broadcast and to seek attention.
- 5.140** You see this with power laws on social media. So 10% of the users of Twitter/X produce 80% of the tweets. 25% of TikTok users post 98% of the videos. Half of TikTok users have never posted a single video. When you go online, you're really seeing this massive volume of content, but it's primarily produced by a small sliver of the population. This can distort people's perceptions of what people in general are like, when really, you're just seeing the content of a small percentage of people who have elevated dark triad traits. They're a bit more exhibitionistic, more narcissistic, more attention-seeking.
- 5.141** There's also this idea of the 1% rule of social media. This is a heuristic to understand what's going on online, where 1% of users produce the vast majority of the content. 9% of people engage with that content in some way. They'll post comments, they'll post

likes, retweets, they'll share it, and then 90% of people are passive viewers. They'll read, they'll browse, they'll scroll, they'll lurk, but they don't actively engage. And so, you're not really seeing a representative snapshot of the population online. You're seeing, again, a small sliver.

5.142 Of course, that small sliver has disproportionate influence, but still, that's not everyone. Social media users tend to have higher dark triad scores, and they tend to use social media more compulsively. People who are attention-seeking—attention-seeking in and of itself is not always a bad thing. If you're an actor or a musician of some kind, you want a bit of that exhibitionism, a bit of that narcissism. Even if you aren't in the public eye, having—what is it— unreasonable levels of self-confidence may be required to do difficult things.

5.143 I spoke with a friend of mine some years ago who was in medical school, and he was like, "Yeah, if you're a doctor, you kind of have to have a God complex, because otherwise you'll just be riddled with doubt. But you have to project confidence to your patients. Otherwise, this will introduce complications, and they won't trust you, and potentially make their health worse."

Lecture 6: The Moral Life

At a glance — The moral life.

- 6.1 All right, so we've been discussing this link between morality and happiness. So far, we've seen that the evidence suggests that if you score highly on the dark triad personality traits: higher levels of self-hate and self-loathing, higher levels of depression and anxiety, difficulty experiencing joy, particularly for psychopathic and Machiavellian-oriented individuals. So there does seem to be this link between mistreating others in everyday life and having difficulty experiencing happiness.
- 6.2 Then, we saw with the light triad that people generally had higher self-esteem, low levels of self-hate, generally higher levels of well-being. But it's also useful to have behavioral measures. Is there an actual causal link between doing nice things, behaving in a moral way, and then subsequently feeling more happiness, more joy?
- 6.3 There was a very clever study about a decade ago where they tried to actually identify causality here. Is there a link between morality and happiness? Then, if so, which way does the direction run? What they did was recruit more than 1,000 participants, had them install an app on their phone, and then they were pinged at random five times throughout the day over the course of three days.
- 6.4 Then, they asked them, "Within the past hour, have you witnessed a moral act? Have you witnessed an immoral act? Have you been the recipient of a moral act or an immoral act? Have you committed a moral act or committed an immoral act within the past hour?" Then, they asked them a series of questions about their own level of happiness and well-being and life satisfaction. So, moral acts that they've committed, witnessed, or experienced, and immoral acts that they've committed, witnessed, or experienced or learned about.
- 6.5 Some moral acts that people would say yes to. If you got a notification on your phone that said, "Hey, within the past hour, have you done any moral acts?" You might say yes. Then, these are some sample notes from participants. One person said, "I helped a coworker finish a report." Another person said, "I told the truth when it would have been easier to lie." In other cases, you might get a ping on your phone, "Have you committed an immoral act?" And you would say yes. Then what would you write? These are some sample notes from participants: "lying to my partner, being rude to a cashier."
- 6.6 The key finding here is that there is a link between morality and happiness, and it seems to be causal because the moral or immoral act preceded the feelings. For people who committed moral acts, they subsequently reported higher levels of happiness relative to their baseline. People who committed immoral acts subsequently reported lower levels of happiness relative to their baseline. So, I would measure your overall baseline level of happiness, your well-being, and then, throughout the course of these

three days, I would ping you at random, and then you would report moral or immoral acts you've done, and then your own level of happiness or well-being. Then, I could compare that to what your baseline is.

- 6.7 The finding here is that on average, when people commit moral acts, they subsequently report elevated happiness. When they do something immoral, like lie or cheat or betray someone, they subsequently feel less happy. The same thing for being the target of a moral versus immoral act. If someone does something nice to you, you'll likely report feeling better. If someone does something very unkind to you, you'll feel much worse.
- 6.8 Then, the same for witnessing. If you see someone do something nice for someone else, most people tend to report feeling happier after witnessing a kind act. People tend to report feeling worse if they've witnessed an unkind act, someone doing something unkind to someone else. Then, the same for even learning about an immoral act, say through social media or through a news article. The direction of causality here—it's a very nice study—is actually doing kind things seems to boost happiness.
- 6.9 They didn't just measure happiness. They measured related constructs like sense of purpose, sense of meaning, and so on. All of these are clustered around this idea of elevated mood, well-being, feeling happy, feeling joyful, sense of purpose. Regardless of the specific measure they used, they found that being moral makes people, on average, seem to feel better. That's most people. Again, we discussed counter-empathy. There's a small percentage of the population where the opposite seems to be the case.
- 6.10 We discussed this: immoral acts are associated with reduced feelings of happiness. One thing that was interesting from this study was that committing an immoral act causes a loss of happiness that was twice as great as the gain in committing a moral act. There's a dramatic penalty in happiness for doing something unkind and a moderate positive lift for doing something kind. One way to think about this is, yeah, doing something nice will make you feel better. If you do something unkind, though, you'll feel very bad. The penalty for happiness is greater than the benefit and happiness from doing something nice.
- 6.11 This aligns, interestingly, with prospect theory. Some of you may have heard of this book, *Thinking, Fast and Slow*, Daniel Kahneman. One of his findings, he and Amos Tversky found that winning money feels about half as good as losing money feels bad. If I give you \$10, you'll report a slight increase in happiness. If you lose \$10, the penalty in your happiness is twice as great as the benefit from gaining money. The summary of that line of research is sometimes described as losses loom larger than gains. Losses really hurt. Gains feel pretty good, but losses really penalize your sense of well-being. Punchline here: happiness increases when you do something good. Happiness is reduced when you do something immoral.

- 6.12** There was another clever study on this point. The reason this study was clever is because they didn't just ask the participant about their own level of morality, "How good of a person are you?" Because you could imagine people have some incentive to maybe inflate how good they are. What they did in this study, these researchers recruited participants, but then they interviewed that person's family members, friends, romantic partners, acquaintances, coworkers, and they had those individuals around the participant rate that person.
- 6.13** So, if you were a participant in the study, they'd ask you some questions about yourself, but then I would talk to your spouse, I would talk to your best friend, I would talk to your coworkers, I would talk to whoever the researchers were able to contact about this person. Obviously, the participant themselves consented to this: "Yes, you can contact my friends and family and so on as a participant in this study."
- 6.14** These individuals were rated by members of their social circle on compassion, honesty, fairness, loyalty, dependability, all of these traits that characterize morality. Then, the participant rated their own level of positive emotion, life satisfaction, meaning in life. So, if you were a participant in this study, you would tell me how much happiness you experience, positive emotion, sense of meaning, all those kinds of things.
- 6.15** The finding in this study was that people who were seen as more moral by their friends and family members and acquaintances themselves reported more meaning in life. If I independently interviewed the closest people in your life about your moral character, and then I asked you, "How good do you feel about your day-to-day life? How happy are you?", and so on. I would find that these two things are strongly correlated. Your reputation that you have with others is linked with your own level of subjective well-being.
- 6.16** The other thing here is you could imagine maybe there's a leveling off point. Once other people have a certain threshold of a positive evaluation of you, the link tapers off between morality and happiness. You might say that people who are moral enough, beyond that point, you're not going to get more happy. There's a threshold beyond which you're not going to experience greater happiness. But what they find is that morality is consistently associated with greater happiness. The relationship is linear. The more moral you are, the more happy you tend to be. It doesn't level off at any point. Again, this is morality as judged by your friends and acquaintances and romantic partners and so on: compassion, honesty, fairness, loyalty.
- 6.17** This suggests that there is not only a relationship, but a causal relationship, such that morality directly seems to boost happiness. Whether I ask you shortly after you've committed a moral act or an immoral act, whether I ask you yourself about your moral character and your levels of happiness, whether I ask your friends and family, what moral reputation you tend to have, all of these things point in the same direction, which is that morality boosts happiness.

- 6.18** Now, there may be some bi-directional relationship where maybe you have to have some minimal level of happiness before you start behaving morally. I would imagine that there's probably some truth to this. It's a little bit both ways where moral behavior increases happiness, and then maybe happiness makes you want to be kinder to other people. There's probably, in terms of the causal direction, almost certainly the link is stronger between morality toward happiness.
- 6.19** Because you can imagine someone who does experience some temporary hedonic pleasure. If someone suddenly wins the lottery, does their moral character improve? Someone is temporarily experiencing intense joy as a result of being high on drugs. Is that person an exemplar of moral character? Probably not. But on the other hand, if someone who's generally dour, unhappy, makes an effort in terms of their actions and behavior to start treating people better—building relationships, developing trust—you'll gradually start to see increases in happiness.
- 6.20** It seems that we've discovered that being moral makes people happier. You might think that, well, people want to be happy. If morality boosts happiness, then maybe people want to become more moral. Is this true? Do people want to improve their moral character? There was a study on this very question by Jessie Sun and her colleagues. First, these participants rated how much they themselves wanted to change on their moral traits, traits like honesty, compassion, fairness, and then their non-moral traits, things like sociability, productivity. Do they want to change their levels of anxiety? Probably reduce them.
- 6.21** This was also a clever study in that they, too, recruited not only the participants' responses, but also their friends and family, loved ones, and so forth, and then asked those people how much they wanted that study participant to change on the same traits. I would ask you, maybe, "Do you want to change or improve your level of honesty, compassion, sociability, and productivity?" Then, I would ask maybe your best friend, "How much do you want this person to improve on these traits as well?"
- 6.22** What they find is that people generally want to change more on their non-moral traits than their moral ones. People don't have a strong desire to improve their moral character. They seem to want to become more sociable, more productive. They want to reduce their levels of anxiety, but they don't have a strong desire to become more honest or more compassionate or more fair. What's interesting is that their friends and family, their loved ones, had the same response. They didn't have strong feelings about whether the participant should become more moral. They, too, also wanted the participant to improve on those non-moral traits. "It'd be nice if so-and-so was a bit more sociable, a bit more productive, maybe a little less anxious," but they didn't have this strong desire for the person to become more honest or more compassionate or more fair.
- 6.23** But the desire of the loved ones for this person to change was less strong than the person's desire to change themselves, which in a way is a hopeful message that we're

harder on ourselves than others are on us. We think, "I'm so anxious. I'm not productive enough. I'm not sociable enough. I need to improve on these traits." We beat ourselves up over it. Others would like us to improve on those traits, too, but not to the same extent that we ourselves seem to want to do.

- 6.24** But it's also interesting that not only do people themselves not want to be more moral, their loved ones also don't seem to have that desire as well. One possible reason for this is maybe in terms of relationships, there is a threshold where as long as someone's moral enough, we don't really have a strong desire for them to behave even better. Most people are generally pretty kind to their friends and family anyway.
- 6.25** Then, you could also imagine this other layer of, if you are willing to partake in a study on behalf of your friend or your loved one, you probably have a pretty good relationship to begin with. It's also screening for people who are already pretty moral. But most people don't prioritize morality. They want to focus on those other aspects of self-improvement.
- 6.26** This is interesting because again, morality seems linked to happiness. People want to improve on those other traits: productivity, sociability, less anxious. Well, why? Probably because they want to be happier. But the link between something like productivity, doing well in the workplace, earning more money, getting more promotions, the link between professional success or income with happiness is pretty tenuous, especially once you escape poverty. Once you reach a certain set point where your basic material needs are met, beyond that, money doesn't seem to have an incredibly powerful boost in terms of happiness. Being in poverty is miserable, but once you've escaped poverty, earning more and more money, there's very quickly this point at which happiness becomes harder to come by. There's diminishing returns.
- 6.27** This may be a mistake in terms of what some psychologists call affective forecasting, where people believe, "If I do this, then in the future, I'll feel this way. If I do that, I'll feel this way." I think the idea here for a lot of people is if I improve on those non-moral traits, then I'll become happier, then I'll become more well-liked, then I will feel better. I'll have an increased sense of meaning. But in fact, it seems that moral character is a stronger predictor of well-being and life satisfaction and happiness than things like productivity and worldly success.
- 6.28** Also, what's interesting is that people don't seem to want to become more moral, even though morality is generally the first thing that we evaluate when we meet a new person, especially if we're going to have repeated interactions with them.
- 6.29** There's a question here. We've confirmed this link between morality and happiness. Why does it feel good to be moral? One reason is because it does make us more well-liked. There seem to be two traits that we encode right away when we meet a new person. There's moral character, and then there's competence. It's how good is this person and how capable are they of carrying out their goals. Collectively, they make up

82% of the differences in terms of how we form our character impressions of others. If I'm comparing two people, whatever difference I see between them, 82% of that is due to my perception of their moral character and their competence. Those are the two key traits.

- 6.30 The researchers on these findings, they find that not much else influences impressions besides moral character and competence. Moral character is more important, by the way. People would rather interact with someone of strong moral character who has less competence than an extremely competent but immoral person. In fact, an extremely competent immoral person you would want to keep your distance from because they're capable of carrying out their malicious goals.
- 6.31 This brings us to these intuitions around morality and happiness. This line of research is interesting in part because philosophers and psychologists seem to have differing ideas about what happiness is. Psychologists tend to define happiness in this narrow way: positive mental states, positive feelings. For psychologists, if you're happy as a result of doing a good deed, that warm glow you feel, that's happiness. If you do some drugs and you temporarily feel this hedonistic pleasure, that also gets categorized as happiness. Happiness under this framework simply means feeling good, having positive emotions. That's the extent of it.
- 6.32 But moral philosophers, as far back as Aristotle, have suggested that happiness is broader in scope than that. It doesn't just depend on whether you feel good. It also depends on whether your life and your moral character is good. This is a question we'll be discussing for a bit: Is happiness about feeling good or is it about doing good? I ask this question not to answer it in some objective sense. We're going to see whether most people, ordinary people, non-philosophers, non-psychologists, the ordinary folk intuition about what happiness actually is: Is it just about having positive mental states, good feelings, or do most people intuitively think that happiness means something deeper? Is it about your actions as well as your feelings?
- 6.33 There's this Aristotelian syllogism from the philosopher Paul Bloomfield, and he derives this from Aristotle: "Morality is necessary for self-respect. Self-respect is necessary for happiness. Therefore, morality is necessary for happiness." We can debate whether each of these steps in this sequence is actually correct or not, but it does seem to be the case, based on all of the research that we've covered, that people who behave immorally seem to lack self-respect. They seem to have greater levels of self-hate. Self-respect is necessary for happiness. Again, we see that with the studies of the dark versus the light triad. Morality is necessary for happiness. We see that in the empirical findings as well. Let's explore this in-depth.
- 6.34 Both psychologists and experimental philosophers have attempted to uncover whether the ordinary intuition about happiness is more about feeling good or doing good. One way they do this is through presenting study participants with a series of vignettes. Here's one. "Maria is the mother of three children who all love her. They couldn't

imagine having a better mom. Maria usually stays pretty busy taking care of her children. She often finds herself rushing from one birthday party to the next and is always going to pick up some groceries or buy school supplies.

- 6.35** While Maria has been preoccupied with her children, she does get to see her old friends occasionally. Almost every night, she ends up working on some projects for the next day or planning something for her children's future. Day to day, Maria usually feels excited and really enjoys whatever she's doing. When she reflects on her life, she also feels great. She can't think of anything else in the world that she would rather spend her time doing and feels like the success she's had is definitely worth whatever sacrifices she's made."
- 6.36** The question here is: Based on what we know of Maria, is she happy? How many of you say that Maria is happy? Just about all of you. Okay. Now we have a different Maria, and these study participants were presented with this story. "Maria wants to live the life of a celebrity in L.A. Maria usually stays pretty busy in trying to become popular. She often finds herself rushing from one party to the next and is always going to pick up some alcohol or a dress. Maria is so preoccupied with becoming popular that she's no longer concerned with being honest to her old friends unless they know someone famous. Almost every night, she ends up either drunk or doing some drug, just like the famous people she wants to be like.
- 6.37** Maria usually feels excited and really enjoys whatever she's doing. When she reflects on her life, she also feels great. She just can't think of anything else in the world that she would rather spend her time doing and feels like the success she's had is definitely worth the sacrifices she's made."
- 6.38** So the question: Is Maria happy? How many of you think Maria is happy? So we got a couple of people, two. Okay. As you could imagine, there was a difference. But the important thing here is the actions are different. You have the first Maria, she was a mother, she's sacrificing for her kid, she's tired, but when she thinks about her life, she feels pretty good about it. Then, you have the Maria, the aspiring celebrity. And again, her actions are attempting to live the life of a celebrity, become famous, become popular. She, too, feels pretty good about what she's doing, and she feels like it's worth the sacrifice she's making. Their mental states are described as exactly the same. Just their actions are different.
- 6.39** There was a dramatic difference in terms of people's evaluations of how happy they are. Just like we saw with the class here, there was a widespread agreement that Maria, the mother, was happy, whereas the responses for Maria, the celebrity, were much less likely to say that she was happy. Again, mental states are described as the same, but the actions were different.
- 6.40** Another scenario here participants were presented with. You see here Tom enjoys his job as a janitor at a local community college. He likes how it gives him a chance to see

his wife who is attending the community college. "Almost every day Tom feels good and generally experiences a lot of pleasant emotions. It is very rare that he would ever feel negative emotions like sadness or loneliness. When Tom thinks about the way he lives his life, he comes to the same conclusion. He's highly satisfied with the way he lives. The reason Tom feels this way is that every day he takes the handicapped students from class to class, talks with them about how they're doing, whether they're having any problems. Each night he goes to sleep thinking about the students he'll be helping the next day."

- 6.41** Is Tom happy? As you could imagine, most people say yes. Of course, there's another Tom. This Tom is also a janitor at a community college. What he likes most about his job "is how it gives him a chance to meet the young female students who are attending the community college. Almost every day Tom feels good, generally experiences a lot of pleasant emotions. When Tom thinks about his life, he comes to the same conclusion. He feels highly satisfied with the way he lives.
- 6.42** The reason he feels good is because every day he goes from locker to locker and steals the belongings from the students and resells these belongings to buy himself alcohol. Each night as he goes to sleep, he thinks about the things he will be stealing the next day."
- 6.43** The question: Is Tom happy? Again, you see this difference. Tom, the helper, the guy who helps these disabled students, people generally agree this Tom is actually happy. The Tom, the thief, they're much less likely to report this person as being happy. Again, their mental states are described as the same. Both Toms feel good about their lives and so on, but their actions are different. You have one Tom who's living a moral life, helping disabled students. He gets to see his wife. Then, this other Tom who's a creep, who's a thief. Even though he's described as having a positive mental state, people are reluctant to attribute happiness to him.
- 6.44** It seems that our judgments of happiness are suffused with these moral considerations that most people believe that you have to live a moral life or at least avoid an immoral life in order to be thought of as being happy, even if your emotions are described identically.
- 6.45** What's really cool is that even preschoolers have this intuition. Young children also have this Aristotelian notion of happiness requires doing good and not just feeling good. So they read stories of characters portrayed as either sharing, helping others, being kind, being moral, or characters who are being mean, selfish, stealing, hurting others. Again, both types of characters are described as having the same mental state —they're satisfied, they're excited, they enjoy what they're doing. But children would regularly rate the good characters, the sharers, and the helpers, and the cooperators as more happy than the cruel characters who are described as experiencing happiness as a result of stealing or hurting others or behaving immorally.

- 6.46 The researchers on this particular paper are finding that even children share this intuition about happiness. They suggest that this is innate rather than learned. They say that, "Given that the effect emerges surprisingly early, it seems unlikely that children come to learn it through extensive real-life experiences, e.g., by observing that agents who perform morally bad actions often seem to be happy on the surface but feel bad deep down."
- 6.47 You could imagine that the social learning idea would be that, over time, you come to be exposed to people who do bad things and they seem happy, and then you learn, actually, they're not. Children seem to have this innate belief that such a person isn't truly happy. They conclude here in this paper—again, these are children as young as four years old. "We found that moral judgment plays a fundamental role in our happiness conception, which is surprisingly early emerging and robust across ages, cultures, and languages."—So, they did not just look at children in the U.S., but in other cultures as well.
- 6.48 "These findings thus not only contribute to a better understanding of the nature and origins of our happiness concept, but also uncover the unique role of morality and perceived happiness as a fundamental cognitive feature of the mind. Therefore, the answer to the ancient question 'what is happiness' is actually within us from early in life. Happiness is more than just good feelings. It arises from goodness in the soul." This is very poetic writing. You almost never see this type of writing in psychology journals. I'm surprised they got it through. But it is a very nice conclusion to this finding. All right, so morality and happiness. Not only do we have the intuition that morality leads to happiness, it actually seems to be the case in the real world that moral actions lead to more positive feelings.
- 6.49 Now we're going to transition into this question of whether there are sex differences in morality. I'll put it this way: Are women more moral than men? People seem to think so. There was a very recent study on this question where participants viewed pairs of faces side by side. I've described this type of study before with the political differences. You see two faces side by side, and then you see two images repeated over and over, two different faces, two different faces, and you're supposed to ask, "Which one looks more moral?" Just on a gut feeling level.
- 6.50 I'll show you maybe 100 pairs of faces, and then I would say, "For each of these 100 pairs, you tell me which one you think is more moral." Ninety-nine percent of the time, they chose the more feminine-looking of the faces. Here's the composite based on this study: the average morally bad person, the one that they evaluated over time as the less morally good or more morally bad, and then the composite of the average morally good person. So this is an amalgamation of all the faces that people tended to say was the more morally good of the pairs. You can see here that the average morally bad person has a more masculine face, and the morally good person has a feminine-looking face.

- 6.51** When you asked people to describe, or rather to categorize different traits for men versus women, traits like peaceful and angelic, those were categorized by research participants as being more feminine relative to masculine. While traits like valuing the self first or being challenging or stubborn, those were categorized as more masculine.
- 6.52** This aligns generally with what some psychologists call the women-are-wonderful effect. Generally, when you have sets of bad traits, negative traits, antagonistic traits, and then more positive traits, cooperative traits, value social harmony, those kinds of things, people will say that the antagonistic traits are more male, the more cooperative, and other-focused traits are more female. Then even for simple things like, "Who would you trust more? A random man or a random woman?" Almost everyone would say they would trust a random woman over a random man.
- 6.53** As we continue this discussion of sex differences, I want to keep in mind here that we're speaking about averages. There is always going to be these exceptions. Obviously, with something like height, men, on average, are taller than women. But you have exceptions here where the average WNBA player is taller than the average man in the general population. Tom Cruise is shorter than the average man. You have Caitlin Clark, the WNBA player, who's taller than the average man. There are always going to be exceptions here. It's important to keep this in mind that just because you can think of an exception to a general pattern, it does not negate the fact that the pattern exists.
- 6.54** You have overlapping bell curves as well for something like height, for example, where the average man is about 5 inches taller than the average woman. But when you have these overlapping bell curves where there might be small differences in averages, you can have extreme differences in the tails. With height, for example, you pluck a random man and a random woman out of the population, you'll see a noticeable, but not dramatic difference in height. But if I were to ask you to go round up all of the tallest people in the world, you would have a collection of men. If I asked you to go around the and round up a collection of the shortest people in the world, it would be almost entirely women. At the extremes, you can see these dramatic differences, even if the averages aren't wildly different.
- 6.55** You see something like this with aggression as well, where the average man isn't wildly more aggressive than the average woman. It can be noticeable, but it's not a crazy large difference. But then, again, if I were to ask you, let's find the most aggressive people on Earth, it would be entirely male.
- 6.56** Are women more moral than men? People seem to have the intuition that they are. When you look at self-report data, you ask people to evaluate different moral transgressions, things like, "A biology student realizes she could copy another person's lab data to save time." "A supervisor takes credit for an employee's idea during a company presentation." You present participants with these scenarios and say, "How wrong was this? First, do you endorse it? Do you not endorse it? Then, if it's wrong, how wrong do you think it is?"

- 6.57** Overwhelmingly, women are more likely to evaluate these things as wrongful. They have a stronger emotional and moral reaction to these, saying, "No, this is not right." Whereas on average, men tend to have a more permissive view of this type of misconduct. So women are more morally sensitive to these types of violations relative to men.
- 6.58** And you see this across different cultures and ages and professions. You see this gender gap, not just for cheating or for stealing an idea, but also for things like harm and dishonesty. Women are more likely than men to boycott companies if they believe they're behaving immorally. They're more likely to condemn companies if they believe their products cause harm. It's not that women are more likely to believe products cause harm. It's that if you have a man and a woman, they both believe that the company is causing harm with their products, the woman will be more likely to express outrage at this than the man. Women show greater outrage in general at corporate misconduct.
- 6.59** There was another study. This was a much more large-scale study, across 67 different countries, 300,000 plus participants, and they looked at gender differences in the moral foundations. Recall: care, fairness, loyalty, authority, and purity. Women scored higher than men on care, fairness, and purity violations, and they didn't really find a difference in the other two foundations. But overall, women were more sensitive to violations of the moral foundations.
- 6.60** These sex differences were the largest in WEIRD societies—in rich, prosperous, developed countries, especially the individualist countries. Whereas in more interdependent, collectivistic societies or in more male-biased, male-dominated cultures, you see that these sex differences are actually smaller. This seems to be because, as countries become freer and more prosperous, you generally see an amplification across a variety of different traits with regard to sex differences. This is known as the gender equality paradox.
- 6.61** The gender equality paradox is the finding that as a country grows richer and more socio-politically equal, the larger the differences grow between men and women. When you measure things like personality traits, the dark triad traits, frequency of crying, you find that— and preferences for occupation as well—you find that the differences are the largest in Western countries, especially in Scandinavian countries. So if you look at Denmark or Sweden or Norway, you actually find that the sex differences in terms of psychology, personality, occupational preferences are larger relative to less wealthy, less developed countries like Vietnam or Brazil or Botswana, where the sex difference in these traits is much lower.
- 6.62** What's also interesting is that you see this not just with psychological and personality traits, but also with physical traits as well: differences in blood pressure, height, BMI. Men, on average, tend to be taller and heavier than women. They tend to have higher

blood pressure than women. But that gap is especially pronounced in, again, more prosperous, wealthy, developed countries.

- 6.63** All of this seems to suggest that as a country becomes richer, with regard to physical traits, you're actually able to physically grow more because you don't experience malnutrition. So men have the capacity to grow taller than women. But if they are malnourished, then you don't see that dramatic height difference as much. But in a country where you have abundant food and adequate nutrition, you start to see that sex difference magnify because men have a higher ceiling with regard to their height.
- 6.64** The same thing seems to hold for personality traits as well, that once you're a rich country and you have options for what to do, how to express yourself, the choice for a career, and so on, you start to see men and women make very different choices. Whereas if you visit a developing country, for example, in developing countries, women are more likely to study stem fields, in part because stem fields are more lucrative. So if you are a young woman in a poor country and you study engineering, that can be your ticket out of there into a better life. But if you already live a pretty good life in a first-world country, who wants to study engineering anyway? Go study something easier.
- 6.65** All right. Are women more moral than men? We have the self-report data. We have this evidence, women condemn these moral violations. People think that women are more moral than men. Let's look at some behavioral studies and lab experiments. You see that men lie for profit more often than women. If you have people come in and play these economic laboratory games, men are more likely to cheat, particularly when the stakes are small. If you have the opportunity to win \$1 or \$2, men are more likely to cheat than women are. If you raise the stakes and suddenly you can win \$10 or \$20, men continue to be— their level of cheating remains essentially the same. They seem to be insensitive to the level of reward they might receive. They respond uniformly, dishonestly, regardless of the profit.
- 6.66** Whereas women are more sensitive to possible profit. When the stakes are low, women are less dishonest than men. But then, once you raise the stakes, the reward grows, then that gender difference shrinks, and women are a bit more likely to cheat and act deceptively if they can win money. You could think that women are sensitive to the rewards, whereas men are insensitive and oblivious and will act uniformly, dishonestly. Women seem to engage in this cost-benefit analysis. All these calculations about personal gain, moral compromise, reputational concerns, and so on.
- 6.67** We talked about the gender equality paradox. It seems to be true for morality as well. You see the gap in terms of moral judgments, where generally across societies, women condemn moral violations more harshly than men. But that gap is especially large in rich and socio-politically equal societies. You see this with the dark triad as well. Men score higher on the dark triad than women do. The gender gap is larger in first-world developed socio-politically equal societies.

- 6.68** Some studies show women scoring higher on vulnerable narcissism than men. Other studies show no difference at all. So this seems inconclusive on the point about vulnerable narcissism, specifically. Whereas for grandiose narcissism, there's a large and consistent gap that men are higher on grandiosity than women are.
- 6.69** What about actual wrongdoings? We talked about cheating in laboratory games, responses to self-reports in scenarios. Well, what about actually committing crimes? I know you'll all be surprised to learn that men are far more likely to commit crimes than women. I'll give you a second to catch your breath. This is a shocking fact. In the U.S., nine times more men than women have ever been incarcerated in a state or federal prison. This is true worldwide.
- 6.70** But even for relatively low-crime societies like Japan, men account for between 80 and 90% of all police arrests. There's not a single country on Earth where there are more women in prison than men. Wherever there is a country with a legal system and formal prisons, there are going to be more men than women. For actual wrongdoing, you see that there is this gap in terms of behavior.
- 6.71** For violent crimes, homicides, more than 90% of homicides are committed by men. Interestingly, men also account for 70% of the victims. Most homicides are one a young man killing another young man. That accounts for the plurality of violence, regardless of the society. Again, even in low-crime societies like Japan, when homicides do take place, it's typically one young male killing another young male. You see this for chimpanzees as well, where 92% of chimpanzee killers and 73% of the victims are males.
- 6.72** As an aside here, there was a really cool study looking at the self-evaluations of prison inmates, their own moral character. Prison inmates were asked to compare their own prosocial characteristics with non-prison inmates. If you were an inmate, I would ask you to basically compare yourself to the average member of society, someone who's not in prison, on traits like kindness, morality, law-abidingness. On every single prosocial trait, with the exception of one, prison inmates rated themselves as higher than the average of society.
- 6.73** Inmates thought of themselves as kinder than the average person who's not in prison. They thought of themselves as more moral, better moral character than average. The only exception was law-abidingness, for which prison inmates rated themselves as perfectly average. They were exactly as law-abiding as someone who isn't in prison, which there's something amusing there because if you're in prison, almost by definition, you're probably not average on law-abidingness.
- 6.74** There's a lot of interesting work from criminologists on this point about how, by the time a person is actually charged and convicted of a felony, they've done a lot of crimes before they got to that point. Even for something like drinking and driving, by the time a drunk driver is pulled over by the police, on average, that person has been drunk on

the road somewhere between 85 and 500 times. You can drink and drive a lot before you're caught, which isn't advice, but it is just a fact that you can do a lot of things before you're finally held to account for it.

- 6.75** This is a quote from the criminologist Stanton Samenow, who writes that "the feature of the criminal mind I found most surprising was that every offender believes he is at heart a good person. 'If I thought of myself as evil, I couldn't live,' one offender told me." This helps to illuminate the finding that inmates think they're pretty good, average on law-abidingness, but better on everything else. So, it does seem to be the case that women are more moral than men. They rate moral violations more harshly. They're less likely to break the law. They're less likely to cheat in laboratory experiments. Why is this the case?
- 6.76** There's a physiological reason, and then there's an evolutionary reason. First off, I mean, men are higher in what anthropologists describe as embodied capital—larger, heavier, more robust—and lower on certain personality traits like anxiety and neuroticism and fearfulness. Formidable individuals who have low levels of stress and anxiety can take more risks, not just physical risks like skydiving or bungee jumping or fist fighting, but also more moral risks as well. If someone's doing something wrong, it doesn't activate as much anxiety and outrage in you because you feel like, "What's the big deal? I'm not at risk." Whereas if you are at risk, you probably are more willing to express moral outrage, condemnation, support for punishment, holding people to account here.
- 6.77** Women, on average, score higher on social anxiety than men do. Social anxiety here is defined as "the anxiety resulting from the prospect or presence of personal evaluation in real or imagined social situations." This was a study I conducted a couple of years ago, where I found—this was during COVID, so I was doing a lot of online studies. In this paper, I found that social anxiety strongly correlates with how wrongful people evaluate moral transgressions. The higher you are in social anxiety, the more likely you are to report that various kinds of moral transgressions are extremely wrong. Everything from theft to violence to betrayal, the more socially anxious you are, the more sensitive you are, the higher you'll rate those moral transgressions as being very wrong.
- 6.78** Neuroticism—similar pattern, not quite the same magnitude, but the higher you are in neuroticism, the more sensitive you'll tend to be toward moral transgressions. But what's interesting here is that both anxiety and neuroticism, which again are associated with moral condemnation, sensitivity to moral violations, thinking that these things are especially wrong, anxiety and neuroticism are highly correlated with upper body strength.
- 6.79** What these researchers did was they brought people into the lab. They had them fill out the anxiety questionnaires and all these instruments measuring negative emotion. They measured their upper body strength with a handgrip device. What they found is

that the stronger your hand grip, the lower your social anxiety scores, and the weaker your hand grip, the more socially anxious people tend to be.

- 6.80 This was true within sexes as well. If I were just looking at men, the men with stronger hand grip scores are less anxious than the men with weaker hand grip scores. Same thing with women. Stronger women are less anxious, weaker women tend to be more anxious. The mind-blowing finding from this line work is that when you control for hand grip strength, the sex difference in anxiety disappears.
- 6.81 In other words, if I were to take a man and a woman who had the same level of hand grip strength, I would be able to predict that their anxiety doesn't differ from one another. Then, the reverse is implied as well, that if I find a man or woman with equal levels of social anxiety, I could predict that their hand grip strength is about the same.
- 6.82 This is fascinating because it suggests that our psychological traits, at least to some extent, reflect our physical traits. As you become stronger, for instance, your personality can change. You see this pattern with neuroticism. People who have stronger hand grip strength tend to be less neurotic. People who have weaker hand grip strength tend to be more neurotic. Again, this explains differences within this axis, but also between them as well.
- 6.83 This also supports this idea that if you are strong, robust, you can take risks, not just physical risks or social risks, but also moral risks, like taking a lenient attitude toward moral transgressions, then you're in a better position to handle those risks. Whereas if you are in a position of a vulnerability, then you'll express more moral outrage in an attempt to contain possible threats. And so greater strength is associated with lower levels of agreement with statements like, "I would feel afraid if I had to travel in bad weather conditions." It measures fearfulness. Statement measuring anxiety. "I sometimes can't help worrying about the little things." The stronger you are, the less likely you are to agree with these types of statements.
- 6.84 As I mentioned, psychological mechanisms seem to be responsive to how much danger you might possibly be in. If you're a vulnerable person, your anxiety is amped up. That's actually a reasonable adaptive response. Anxiety serves as an alarm bell, a warning sign for danger. If you are a vulnerable, potential target, potential victim, then it's good to be vigilant and to be aware of your surroundings and to react when you see people doing something that could be harmful. Men, because of the higher physical formidability, lower susceptibility to danger, have these subdued traits, subdued anxiety, subdued fearfulness.
- 6.85 Moral condemnation deters exploitation from wrongdoers. You see this in developing countries in small-scale societies that don't have formal legal systems, they don't have prisons. How do they punish wrongdoers? A lot of it is just condemnation, criticism, ridicule, ostracism. Those things in themselves can serve as punishment because they're unpleasant. If you could imagine living in a small-scale, pre-industrialized

society, and you've made a fool of yourself, or you broke one of the unspoken rules, and everyone's criticizing you and mocking you and making fun of you, that can serve as a form of punishment. So we have this impulse to condemn wrongdoers because, on average, that will lead to reduced instances of those behaviors in the future.

- 6.86** Individuals who have embodied capital have fewer concerns about safety and security. Along this point, it may not just be embodied capital that leads to reduced attitudes around moral transgressions, reduced negative attitudes, condemnation of moral transgressions. It may also be the case for economic capital as well. You see this with rich societies and then rich individuals within those societies.
- 6.87** We talked about the ethic of autonomy in a previous session and how Western countries have this ethic of autonomy. As long as no one's hurt, you're fine. No big deal. Then affluent, credentialed, educated individuals within those wealthy societies are even more so inclined toward an ethic of autonomy. But affluent, educated individuals in rich countries are probably the safest people on Earth. They don't need to have particularly strong views on conventional moral transgressions, things like violence, things like theft, things like crime, because they are relatively removed from those threats, they can take a permissive attitude toward them.
- 6.88** You do see this in Western countries. The higher you go in socioeconomic status, the more relaxed the attitudes of individuals are with regard to conventional moral transgressions. Of course, they still have this moralistic instinct, but it can be redirected and channeled toward more fashionable movements of the day, what I sometimes call luxury beliefs. If most people are concerned about crime, I can distinguish myself. I can show off my luxurious position in society by dismissing that and focusing on recycling instead, or whatever mental cause.
- 6.89** You see this even within the Democratic Party, the working class Democratic voters care more about economic issues and crime, whereas more affluent and educated Democrats, are more interested in these abstract ideals that are more disconnected from people's everyday life, things like preserving democracy and things like climate change, where it's very hard to actually implement long-term policies in order to— It's much more vague how you would achieve those goals. Whereas for things like crime and unemployment and economic issues, those are more within our control. Those are actually things that people seem to care about in their everyday lives if they're less formally educated, less credentialed.
- 6.90** So you have embodied capital, economic capital. Basically, the more you're able to withstand potential threats, the more permissive you are towards moral transgressions. That's the physical argument.
- 6.91** But there's also, of course, the evolutionary perspective, reproductive considerations, where women have historically been more valuable in a reproductive sense. They have the children. They have historically been more responsible for child rearing, for

caregiving. They're responsible not just for themselves, but also for very vulnerable young children. In this case, it helps to be very alert, very aware, hyper-vigilant, and be interested in getting people to behave in predictable ways, and to avoid the possibility of danger, including from immoral individuals. This serves to aid an evolutionary fitness.

- 6.92** Whereas men, historically, have been in a position to take more risks simply because they've been less involved in child rearing and their contribution historically to raising children to adulthood, they've been less involved in that.
- 6.93** It's possible that in the midst of evolutionary history, there were women who took a permissive attitude towards moral wrongdoing, who were more thrill-seeking, more impulsive, more willing to take risks the way that a man would. But those women—if you look at the death rates for young men versus young women, even in things like accidents, it's dramatically higher for young men. Maybe at some point, there were women who had those same traits, but they would, of course, get lost. That genetic lineage would be cut off at some point because they were unable to raise children to survive. They didn't pass on their genes. It was the cautious, careful, tactful women who were the ones who were more likely to become mothers and then raise children to adulthood.
- 6.94** Those are the sex differences. It does seem to be the case that on average, women are more moral than men. Again, this doesn't mean that every woman is more moral than every man or every man is less moral than every woman. But on average, women are better behaved, less likely to break the law, less likely to cheat.
- 6.95** Of course, this isn't necessarily—maybe this is a moral argument, too, but this doesn't necessarily imply that one is always better than the other. In some cases, moralizing can go too far. We discussed moral grandstanding. In some cases, some of the foundations that underlie the moral impulse, the moral concerns, things like compassion and empathy, you have this runaway effect where people compete to be the most empathic and compassionate, and this, too, can be redirected.
- 6.96** There's an anthropologist I like, Manvir Singh, who recently suggested that throughout history, people have been extremely concerned with threats from the out-group: people who look different from you, have different culture than you, speak a different language, different value system, different religion. That has been the historical norm. But at some point, in the wake of World War II, in the wake of the Holocaust, a lot of our moral standards were reconsidered. That old form of morality of prioritizing the in-group—that's who you should care about, everyone outside of that circle has less value—that sounded to a lot of people suspiciously like what led to something like the Nazi Holocaust.
- 6.97** Then, the reaction in a lot of cases was to essentially do the opposite of that, of valuing, in some cases, maybe the out-group even more than you would value the in-group. Whatever the most evil people did, do the opposite of that. But then, of course, if you

have this runaway effect of experiencing extreme compassion and empathy for people who are not in your group, because they're not in your group, that means that you're not in their group either. Most people still have that historically normal way of thinking that if you're not in their group, they don't value your life as much. If you value their life a lot, they don't value your life as much. This can create difficulties.

- 6.98** I think you see versions of this now. In many cases, in Western countries, for example, you'll see people expressing more sympathy for criminals than the victims. Those sentiments are primarily expressed by, again, people with large amounts of economic and cultural capital, people who can afford to have luxury beliefs.
- 6.99** Let's transition here to this question of moral improvement across the lifespan. Older generations have been complaining about young people for as far back as we have written documentation. Here's an example from the British newspaper, The Hull Daily Mail, from 1925. "We defy anyone who goes about with his eyes open to deny that there is, as never before, an attitude on the part of young folk, which is best described as grossly thoughtless, rude, and utterly selfish." That was literally one century ago. You can imagine a lot of people today still have that sentiment. You have the Abraham Simpson: "get off my lawn."
- 6.100** But because this viewpoint has been expressed so frequently throughout history, it's worth asking: Is there something to it? Are young people actually worse than old people? Is there no difference? Maybe young people are actually better than old people in terms of their moral character. Let's have a look here.
- 6.101** The intuition is there. You see this with advanced age and responsibility; the average age of a successful startup founder is 42 years old. A lot of people have this pop culture-driven myth that successful founders are very young. They actually typically tend to be about 40, 42 years old. The average CEO of a Fortune 100 company, 57 years old. Again, it seems to reflect this view that age and responsibility are intertwined. The average age at the time of hire among S&P 500 company CEOs, 58 years old. The average U.S. Senator is 64 years old. The current and previous U.S. Presidents are 197 years old. You have this link between responsibility and age. Well, if they have this responsibility, you would want them to be more ethical, more moral, more principled.
- 6.102** Let's first look at age differences in the dark versus the light triad. Over the lifespan, dark triad traits, as I've mentioned, peak in adolescence and in early adulthood, and then taper off with age. The link between age and the dark triad is the most pronounced for psychopathy, which is often described as the darkest of the three traits. For any individual, if you were to give them repeated measures of the dark triad throughout their lives, you would see that it peaks in the late teens and early 20s, and then gradually declines throughout middle age.
- 6.103** Older adults have elevated scores on the light triad. Older people are higher on faith in humanity, humanism, Kantianism than younger people. There was a really neat study

recently on gossip. Who's more likely to spread positive gossip? Who's more likely to spread malicious gossip? Older adults are more likely to spread positive gossip about their friends and acquaintances and family members. Younger adults are more likely to spread malicious gossip about their friends and people in their social circle. They prefer to share reputational damaging gossip, which aligns with the general dark versus light triad personality style.

- 6.104** There was a study about two decades ago of business professionals in organizations, and they found that the younger professionals, relative to the older ones, younger ones were more likely to endorse these dubious behaviors like using company office supplies for personal use or using company funds for personal holidays, maybe bending the truth to take a day off or to extend their vacation time. Younger people seemed to be more dishonest. Younger professionals seem to be more dishonest than older professionals.
- 6.105** What about for moral decision making? Younger adults—more consequentialist, more utilitarian, less deontological. Again, younger adults relative to older adults, more likely to flip the switch in the original trolley problem, more likely to push the large man off the bridge, more likely to think that the surgeon can sacrifice one life to save five others, whereas older adults are more fixed in their moral principles and they think something's either right or it's wrong. There's no situational ethics where you can add up the goods and the bads. There's a way you should behave. Whereas younger people are more situational in their approach to ethical dilemmas.
- 6.106** A recent study found that younger people are becoming more utilitarian or more consequentialist in their moral decision making compared with younger people in the past. I don't really know what to make of this, but it is an interesting point here that younger people are increasingly inclined toward a situational approach to ethics.
- 6.107** There was a study of more than a thousand individuals, from young children all the way up to 77 years old. The outcome measure that these researchers were concerned with was frequency of lying. Who is most likely to lie and who's the most likely to formulate believable lies? They found that young children, so very young children, and elderly adults, were the least likely to be deceptive in their everyday lives, whereas young adults between the ages of 18 and 29 were the most likely to lie and to be deceitful. Young adults also exhibited the greatest proficiency in formulating believable lies. They seem to be especially talented at deceptions. Not only are they more likely to lie, they're more likely to be successful in this behavior.
- 6.108** Same thing goes for age and moral judgment. There is a gap between older adults and younger adults. This was a study that I conducted three years ago, I guess, three years now. I analyzed multiple large data sets, not only in the U.S., not only in Europe, but all around the world, including non-WEIRD, non-Western countries. What I found was that older adults consistently rated moral violations more harshly than younger adults. So younger adults were more permissive. Older adults were more likely to condemn

immoral acts. Older adults rated things like tax evasion or theft as especially wrong, relative to younger adults who held a more permissive attitude about tax evasion or theft.

- 6.109** Which is okay, fair enough. I mean, it's a difference. Maybe this could be explained by something like economic position. On average, older people tend to have more money than younger people. So maybe younger adults think that if you want to steal something or commit some tax fraud to keep what you have, maybe that's okay. Whereas if you're more wealthy, you're more likely to condemn theft or tax evasion.
- 6.110** But what was surprising here is that younger adults also rated physical violence to be more permissible than older adults. So younger adults said that political violence and child abuse and spousal abuse were also more okay than relative to the ratings of older adults.
- 6.111** The political violence one didn't really surprise me, that younger adults would be more lenient on the political violence question. The spousal abuse and child abuse ones blew my mind because you could imagine that the older generations, the spanking was okay, domestic violence, it was less stigmatized, and so on. Whereas today, younger adults are enlightened; they haven't been taught those bad things. And so, of course, they're going to say, spousal abuse and child abuse are worse. In fact, they think that these acts are more okay relative to older adults.
- 6.112** Now, I want to be clear here that overall, everyone across the board rated these things as more bad than good. Most people said that these were wrong, all of these acts: tax evasion, theft, violence. Everyone said that they were wrong. It's just that the magnitude of how wrong you thought it was shifted depending on your age, such that young people are like, "Yeah, that's wrong," whereas older people are like, "No, that's extremely wrong." Again, everyone thinks it's wrong, but young people are a little more tepid in their judgments.
- 6.113** Of course, one obvious response is that maybe this is a political difference. Older people are more conservative. They have these rigid moral attitudes. Older people are wealthier; maybe that changes their attitude. But in these studies, I controlled for income, for political orientation and for education. So if you were to have two equally educated adults, both the same political orientation, both the same level of income, but one is young and one is older, the younger adult would have a more permissive moral view than the older adult.
- 6.114** This is unlikely to be what some psychologists will call a cohort effect, which is that if you take a snapshot of a society and you say that the older people are more moral than the younger people, and therefore, something changes across the lifespan, people could say that maybe it's not a change in the lifespan. You're just measuring old people at this time point and young people at that time point, but you're not saying anything about changes across the lifespan.

- 6.115** But the thing is that these data sets that I analyzed dated back to the early 1980s. What I found was that regardless of the period of time when you measure this question of age differences in moral judgment, you find it. You find it in 1981, you find it in 1994, you'll find it in 2010. Essentially, at any given point in society, you'll find that it is the case that older people seem to be more moral, at least in terms of their judgments, than younger people. This doesn't seem to be a cohort effect. The magnitude of this effect was similar across each data set as well. I found this for each of the samples that I looked at. Older adults consistently rate moral violations more harshly than younger adults, regardless of the time that you're looking at.
- 6.116** What about for crime? What about for actual conduct, actual behavior? Unsurprisingly, young people are far more likely to commit crimes. Developmental criminologists sometimes refer to this as the age-crime curve, such that the inclination to commit crimes seems to peak somewhere between the ages of 18 and 20. In the U.S., a 20-year-old man is 10 times more likely to commit a violent crime than a 60-year-old man. This remains true even when you control for socioeconomic status. A rich 20-year-old is more likely to commit a crime than a rich 60-year-old. A poor 20-year-old is more likely to commit crimes than a poor 60-year-old.
- 6.117** You see the dramatic difference for males because males commit the bulk of the crimes. But even when you look at women, you find this difference, where 20-year-old women are much more likely to commit a crime than a 60-year-old woman. Now, again, the overall magnitude is way lower than it is for men. But still, if you wanted to just look at women and look at patterns of criminality, you'll see that in their late teens and early 20s, that is when a woman is the most likely to commit a crime.
- 6.118** You see something similar with the dark triad across the lifespan. I'd mentioned that it tends to burn out over time. You tend to peak in late adolescence and early adulthood in the dark triad scores, and then it gradually declines. At every single time point in the lifespan, men score higher on the dark triad than women. But the age differences in the dark triad often dwarf the sex differences. What I mean by this is that it is true that the average 20-year-old male is higher on the dark triad than the average 20-year-old female. But the average 20-year-old female is way higher on the dark triad than the average 60-year-old male. The differences across the lifespan, sex differences remain, but the effect of age is actually more powerful than the effect of gender with regard to the dark triad.
- 6.119** This raises the question of why older people are more moral. One reason, it may be the same as it is for women. Older people are more vulnerable to physical violence, to danger, so they have to exhibit stricter moral attitudes to increase the predictability of the behavior of those around them, to remain safe. Dark triad traits tend to burn out with age, as I mentioned. So the older you get, the lower your dark triad scores become, which in turn seem to raise people's standards for moral behavior. The decline in physical formidability might be intertwined with the dark triad traits as well.

- 6.120** One reason why the dark triad peaks in early adulthood is that, again, They're not always entirely negative. Having a bit of— being a bit strategic, maybe having a little bit of that tendency toward influence, manipulations, some inveigling, that might actually be beneficial in small to moderate amounts in early adulthood, when you're trying to make your way in the world, getting a job, making friends, romantic partner, figuring out who you are, taking risks, being a bit bold. Being very low on the dark triad might not be advantageous in early adulthood. So you want to be a little bit more assertive and maybe even a little bit more confrontational early in life in order to attain some worldly success.
- 6.121** But then, once you've achieved a good job, you have a spouse, you have kids, your priorities are reconfigured, and you no longer need to partake in those dark triad tactics to succeed, and you can focus more on maybe more of those light triad tendencies. That may be another reason. When you're constantly elbowing other people on your way up, you have to be a bit more Machiavellian, whereas once you've already acquired some success, that's no longer necessary.
- 6.122** Another reason why older adults might be more moral than younger adults may also be due to wisdom. As you get older, you start to appreciate the structures that are in place. You start to value other people more. You start to recognize how important relationships are and promote stability, including the moral behavior that contributes to peace and calm and harmony and stability.
- 6.123** There's a quote from the historian, Robert Conquest, who once said something like: "Everyone is a conservative about what he knows best." People who have been around a long time and have a lot of knowledge about something tend to appreciate its benefits even while acknowledging its flaws. Whereas people who are not as well-versed in whatever the domain happens to be will often develop revolutionary ideas because they're not aware of the intricacies of what it takes to make that system work.
- 6.124** I like this quote here from the Cambridge Handbook of Wisdom, edited by Robert Sternberg. In this chapter, the authors write that "wisdom requires more than just the acquisition of theoretical knowledge. Intellectual or theoretical knowledge is knowledge that is understood only at an intellectual level, whereas wisdom is understood at the experiential level. It is only when an individual realizes the truth of this preserved knowledge that the knowledge is retransformed into wisdom and makes the person wiser."
- 6.125** This is an amusing bit here. They go on to write, "In several of our own studies, we asked people about the most important insights they have gained from their life. Most of these insights can indeed easily be related to proverbs or adages such as "No man is an island" or "You can't always get what you want," things that basically everyone knows. But it makes a crucial difference to experience the importance of being close to others for the first time in one's life, as one struggles with a serious illness, or to experience the difficulty of letting go of a goal to which one dedicated most of one's

time over the years. Insights gained in this way from experience have the potential to change one's life and worldviews, even if they were part of one's theoretical knowledge since childhood."

- 6.126** You can say things to a kid, "No man is an island," and things like, "You can't always get what you want." The thing is, clichés are often clichés for a reason. They've been around a long time. Those are compressed nuggets of wisdom that have been passed on and have been stripped of their complexity to its simplest form. And then, they get passed around and then young people hear it, and it sounds banal to them. But clichés are clichés for a reason. They've been around for a long time.
- 6.127** I think that one benefit of this empirical work in modern academic psychology is that you can use these instruments and these tools to reclaim the wisdom of moral philosophers. We've spoken about Aristotle on happiness, and psychologists were able to test whether those claims were true or not. We did find that there is this link between morality and happiness. We spoke about Adam Smith on the moral sentiments that we do tend to feel empathy toward others: when they're happy, we're happy; when they're sad, we feel sad.
- 6.128** We spoke about reciprocity and found that that is the basis of morality, especially for unrelated individuals. In this case, Christ and Confucius were on the mark on this point. We spoke about Kant versus Bentham on morality and how to some extent they were both right. The folly of youth, this is also this age-old, well-worn idea that young people are behaving so badly. This is something else we can test and found evidence for. You can use these tools to rediscover these timeless truths.
- 6.129** We've covered a lot of ground in these six lectures. We spoke about the evolutionary foundations of morality. We spoke about the competing moral frameworks, moral foundations theory versus moral dyad theory, and moral typecasting. We spoke about the intuitions around blame and punishment, the two process theory of morality, political differences between liberals and conservatives. We spoke about evil, cruelty, psychopaths, narcissists, sadists, Machiavellians,
- 6.130** We spoke about whether moral character leads to improvements in happiness, some sex differences in morality. At least at this point, the evidence suggests that women are more moral than men. We also looked at moral character across the lifespan and found that older people are more moral than younger people. We've concluded with this discussion of wisdom.
- 6.131** At the start of this series, I quoted Anton Chekhov, and I do hope that by now, after going through these lectures, maybe we have also spotted some wisdom in his quote, "Man will become better when you show him what he is like." We've gone over a lot of findings in psychology. We've learned a little bit more, maybe, about others. Hopefully, we've learned a bit more about ourselves. I'll leave it at that, and we'll open up for questions. Thank you.

- 6.132** I want to delve a little bit more into the sex differences. I know that with aggression, both men and women are aggressive, but how they express it is very different. So I'm interested in the dark triad. Do women express the dark triad in a different way than men do?
- 6.133** It's a good question. So again, overall, average sex differences: men score higher on the dark triad than women. But there are cases of women with elevated dark triad traits, of course. As I mentioned, averages do not negate exceptions, and exceptions do not negate averages. But when you look specifically at women with dark triad traits, there are some similarities, as with men—more prone to criminality—but the aggression is expressed often indirectly. Rather than direct physical confrontation and violence, it would be more redirected toward gossip, innuendo, backbiting, emotional manipulation, plausible deniability. Those actually require a lot more, I think, cognitive effort that I think most men are not equipped to.
- 6.134** I had this conversation with the author Louise Perry recently, and she told me this story about how one of her friends was a woman who was the department head of some organization, and she saw these two women who were always creating difficulties in the office. But it was always very subtle. The male higher-ups had no idea what was going on, and only this woman, her friend, the department head, could tell. So she brings both of these women into her office and says, "I can tell exactly what you both are doing. You guys knock it off right now. I know they can't tell, but I can. You're going to stop this." Women are better at picking up on these subtle dark triad traits as well.
- 6.135** Then, there are the more mundane expressions of this. There was one study that found that women who are higher on the dark triad are more likely to engage in foodie calls. You guys have heard of this phrase of going out on dates for a free meal, not with the intent of going out to meet someone interesting and build a relationship, but more because the guy invited them to a nice restaurant and they want to check it out. There are some other interesting characteristics of women who are higher on the dark triad, but we'll leave it there for now. So next question.
- 6.136** The quote you ended with, "Man will become better when you show him what he was like." I was hoping you might comment on the practice of a personal moral inventory.
- 6.137** Explain personal moral inventory.
- 6.138** Addressing one's personal moral transgressions.
- 6.139** I think that there's benefit to introspection and to looking inward and saying, "Here's where I have fallen short of my own ideals," and recommitting to that moral improvement. This is not a course that is prescriptive, telling people how they should behave. But based on everything we've covered, it does seem like improving moral character improves happiness, well-being, reduces feelings of self-loathing. So there can be a benefit to yourself, of course, in attempting to improve your moral character.

If that's one way to do it with the moral inventory, then that might predictably lead to increased life satisfaction and happiness.

- 6.140** But the reason that might work is not necessarily because you yourself are behaving better, but also because you're helping the people around you and making their lives less miserable. I think when you often get a lot of very dark personalities together, they collectively reduce the overall level of happiness. Not only can behaving in a more principled way benefit you, but it can benefit others, and then they'll feel better and then, in turn, treat you better. There are a lot of benefits there.
- 6.141** With this whole discussion of dark triad and the age of the 20s being a more risky experimental moment to define what their morality is, have there been other societies that have had this age gap lower due to circumstances or their environment? Because I guess my understanding is just through documentaries and seeing examples of younger youth or children going through war times and just harder circumstances, they don't show these tendencies as much as you could say WEIRD societies, because they, at least my understanding is, they have the privilege to experiment more, to be more risky. So in harder situations, would you say the morality comes quicker to their understanding and their decision-making due to their environment?
- 6.142** Yes. I think that maybe the most intuitive example of something like this, of how wealth and abundance and technological advancement can shape our moral values, is specifically for attitudes around purity. Historically—and I think I mentioned this in one of the lectures—a lot of traditional societies have very rigid rules around food, around sex, around cleanliness. Those did not appear out of nowhere. Those arose because historically, infections and illnesses accounted for most deaths.
- 6.143** Before the rise of medical advancements and vaccines and technologies and medicines, people had to abide by strict behavioral rules that became moralized in order to reduce the likelihood of infection and death. But then, once you have all of these advancements and all the wealth and prosperity in place, people can suddenly take a much more permissive view of food, of sex, of personal preferences, of relationships, and so on.
- 6.144** You could probably see this same pattern elsewhere as well. The other two binding foundations I'd mentioned, of authority and loyalty, may be critical when you need to rely on relationships in order to survive. But once you live in a rich society where most of your basic needs will be met, regardless of how good your social life is going, you no longer need to place as much emphasis on those values.
- 6.145** So I do think there's something here about, as a society becomes wealthier, they need other people less, they're less preoccupied with moral questions, at least conventional moral questions. Sometimes you see grandstanding around moral questions that are new and would be unrecognizable to people in impoverished societies.

6.146 There's a story of the anthropologist, Napoleon—I think his last name is Chagnon, I am probably mispronouncing it. He writes in one of his books that he visited the Yanomami, a remote Amazonian tribe. He's telling them, because they're talking about war, he and some of the men in this community, they're like, "Oh, you go to war, too." He's like, "Yeah, my country goes to war." Then they ask, "Why?" He says, "We're trying to free people and promote democracy," and blah, blah, blah. The guys start laughing at him. They're like, "What?" Then, he says, "Well, you also have intertribal skirmishes and warfare, why do you go to war?" They say, "For women." A very simple, straightforward response. So yes, values can shift depending on material conditions and technology. I think we'll leave it there. Thank you.